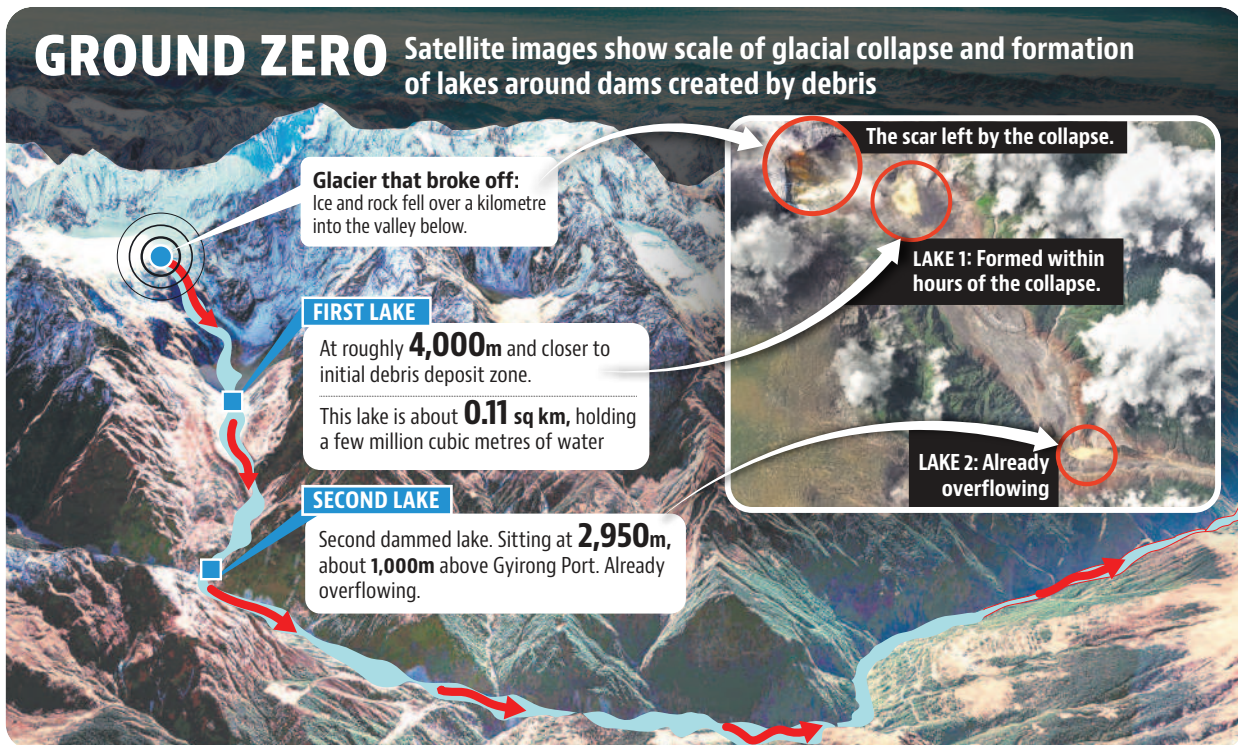




Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



Search on for hundreds of hydropower workers

Nepalese military locates workers trapped in one project tunnel; 320 Indians still missing

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

NUWAKOT: The number of people missing in Nepal and China leaped to more than 2,400 Friday, underscoring the scale of the disaster days after a tsunami-like wall of water and debris swept away villages and killed hundreds.

Rescuers were battling through mud even as the threat of new floods loomed, with

emergency teams recovering 584 bodies so far -- and some of the dead swept downstream as far away as India.

The new figures came as Nepal's disaster authority added 933 hydropower workers to a missing list already including trekkers and pilgrims to Tibet's sacred Mount Kailash. India's foreign ministry said 320 Indians were missing in Nepal and 400 were stranded in China.

Relatives have crowded hospi-

tals in Nepal's capital in a painful hunt for their loved ones, with posters on the walls bearing photos and names of the missing, AFP journalists saw.

"Today is the third day and we don't know anything. Hopefully he (my brother) is in a safe place," Samjhana Thing, 27, told AFP. "We lost everything, he is our everything."

The US Geological Survey said the disaster -- the deadliest for Nepal since a 2015 earthquake -- was caused by a glacial collapse that triggered a vast flow of icy debris.

continued on →12

KATHMANDU AGREES TO FOREIGN HELP FOR FLOOD RESCUE OPS

The Nepal government has reversed its earlier decision to not seek help from international search-and-rescue teams in the flash flood-hit areas, following "intense diplomatic pressure" from countries whose nationals are among people still missing in the disaster, the Kathmandu Post reported citing officials. On Wednesday, the government said Nepali rescuers were capable of handling the search-and-rescue operations, and that it would not allow foreign rescuers. AGENCIES

IRAN URGES NATIONS NOT TO JOIN NEW U.S. SANCTIONS

DUBAI: Iran condemned the US's new economic sanctions on Friday as "state terrorism" and said other countries were legally obliged not to implement them, while the US Treasury Department announced additional targeted Iran-related measures.

The Iranian foreign ministry's statement came as mediators stepped up efforts to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. President Donald Trump's administration on Monday warned countries to cut their business ties with Iran or face secondary sanctions.

Iranian foreign minister Abbas Aragchi on Friday renewed his appeal to the US to stop putting military and economic pressure and to resume negotiations. "Putting diplomacy back on track isn't impossible. It hinges on US understanding of one simple fact: pressure doesn't work," Aragchi said on X. →P3

FSSAI proposes warning labels on food items

Utkarsh Anand
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has proposed prominent red warning labels on the front of packaged foods high in added fat, added sugar or salt, marking a significant shift by the regulator a fortnight after the Supreme Court questioned its reluctance to introduce such warnings.

The proposal, disclosed in a compliance affidavit filed before the Supreme Court on Thursday, envisages a red hexagonal warning on the front of food packages where the product is high in any two or more of the specified nutrients of concern

—fat, sugar or salt. The thresholds would be those prescribed under the Dietary Guidelines for Indians, 2024, issued by the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition (NIN). The labels are designed to allow consumers to identify such products at a glance.

continued on →2



B Nagendra

25 DAYS AFTER JOINING CABINET, K'TAKA MINISTER SAYS WILL RESIGN

Naheed Aatulla
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka minister B Nagendra, who is facing opposition protests over allegations that he was involved in a funds misappropriation case, submitted his resignation on Friday, 25 days after he was re-inducted into the state cabinet. At a press conference, a tearful Nagendra said he was stepping down to spare the Congress embarrassment and not due to opposition allegations of involvement in the misappropriation of funds from a state welfare agency. →P6

Penguin likely nixed Sonia book deal over PM, RSS, China portions



Sonia Gandhi in a file photo. The Indian edition of the book is likely to have a different cover, featuring the Congress leader in a saree, in a photo taken by Rajiv Gandhi.

Sunetra Choudhury
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's book deal with Penguin Random House India (PRHI) fell through after she refused to make changes to or delete references to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), and Chinese intrusions into India, HT has learnt.

Gandhi, 79, maintained that it is her story and there was no question of allowing any distortions to her telling of her life, a person aware of the matter said, asking not to be named.

The Indian edition of the book is likely to have a different cover than the close-up headshot featured in the international edition.

The Indian book jacket is likely to feature Sonia Gandhi in a saree, a photograph taken by her husband and former Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, HT has learnt.

Alfred A Knopf, an imprint of Penguin, is expected to release the memoir, 'Belonging: A Journey of Love', worldwide on November 10. HarperCollins in reportedly close to finalising an agreement to publish and

continued on →12

NO STUDENT WILL 'FAIL' IN CLASS 10, 12 STATE BOARD EXAM IN BIHAR: MINISTER

Arun Kumar
letters@hindustantimes.com

PATNA: The Bihar government has decided to remove the word "Fail" from the marksheets of students appearing for Class 10 and Class 12 state board exams, education minister Mithilesh Tiwari said. Students who do not clear the exams will instead have the phrase "Eligible for Skill Training" mentioned on their marksheets, allowing them to opt for vocational training programmes. →P2

Abducted, set on fire, Punjab influencer dies

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHANDIGARH: A 28-year-old social media influencer died during treatment nearly two months after she was allegedly abducted, assaulted and set on fire by two of her acquaintances in Rupnagar district of Punjab, police said on Friday.

Citing a complaint filed by the mother of the deceased, Manjeet Kaur, police said the two accused, identified as

Shubhi and Pinda, called the victim to meet them at Sector 34, Chandigarh, from where they allegedly abducted her and drove her to Morinda, around 30km away. The accused then allegedly tied her to a tree and set her on fire, police officers aware of the matter said.

"A case of kidnapping and murder has been registered on the complaint of the woman's mother," Chandigarh Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Kanwardeep Kaur said. →P5

NC MP INDICATES HE WILL RESIGN, QUESTIONS PARTY ON ARTICLE 370

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

SRINAGAR: Amid reports suggesting that his formal resignation could come on November 3, estranged National Conference Lok Sabha MP Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi on Friday said he will resign from Parliament but demanded answers on the "shift" in party's stand on Article 370 before stepping down.

Party president Farooq Abdullah asked him to seek a fresh mandate for opposing the party line. →P6

MANESAR: BOY CRUSHED UNDER PITCH ROLLER AT CRICKET ACADEMY

Debashish Karmakar
letters@hindustantimes.com

GURUGRAM: An eight-year-old boy was killed after he was crushed under a pitch roller that was left unsupervised and accidentally switched on by children at a cricket academy in IMT Manesar, police said. According to police, the children climbed onto the roller, weighing around 750kg. "Accidentally, one of the children managed to switch on the miniature circuit breaker which started the roller," a police officer said.

Stock delivered, lifted



Two boys carry a sack of onions from the Kanda Express after its arrival in Delhi. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

PRAGG OVERCOMES ODDS TO BECOME 1ST INDIAN TO WIN GRAND CHESS TOUR

NEW DELHI: Grandmaster (GM) R Praggnanandhaa became the first Indian to win the coveted Grand Chess Tour after defeating the US's Fabiano Caruana in a come-from-behind effort. Praggnanandhaa lost the first Classical game and drew the second, trailing Caruana 3-9 going into Thursday. He then won both Rapid games to take a 11-9 lead.

The players scored equal points in the Blitz section and Praggnanandhaa won the final 15-13. →P16

{ SUKUMARA KURUP }

Murder, fake death, 42-yr mystery: Notorious fugitive back in spotlight

Vishnu Varma
letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: One winter morning in January 1984, Sukumara Kurup strangled a man who bore some resemblance to him, burnt his body near a field in Alappuzha and faked his own death -- in the process committing one of India's first insurance crimes.

The 38-year-old then vanished.

For over four decades, Kurup's proven brutality and

KURUP KILLED A MAN WHO BORE A RESEMBLANCE TO HIM AND FAKED HIS OWN DEATH TO COMMIT ONE OF INDIA'S FIRST INSURANCE CRIMES

mythical escape became the subject of countless stories, movies, television plots and reams of neighbourhood gossip.

The police believed it futile to search for the elusive fugitive. Until now.

This week, a claim by a police officer who investigated the case in 2017 that Kurup was still alive in Brunei, and a photo of a hirsute man with neatly combed hair released by a Malayalam channel, kicked the police into action and rumour mills into overdrive -- only for the authorities to conclude that one of Kerala's most-wanted men was probably still in the wind, or dead. →P5

19001/221/2627

A Celebration of Handloom Heritage

UP TO 40% DISCOUNT AVAILABLE!

Celebrate India's Handloom. Support Artisans. Wear Heritage.

COME AND BRING ODISHA'S BEST PRODUCTS HOME!

SILVER FILIGREE

SAMBALPURI SAREE

TUSSAR SILK SAREE

KOTPAD SAREE

KHANDU SILK

SAMBALPURI FABRIC JEWELLERY

DHOKRA JEWELLERY

AND MANY MORE COLLECTIONS

11TH AUGUST TO 10TH SEPTEMBER 2026

DLF AVENUE SAKET, NEW DELHI

FOLLOW ORMAS ODISHA @ormas.odisha

ORMAS, Panchayati Raj & Drinking Water Department, Government of Odisha

OIPR - 19001/19004/2/26-27/0009

From Archives

BAHUGUNA'S COLUMN FOR HT, 1996



Sunderlal Bahuguna and his wife Vimla in 2005. The two were among the most prominent faces of the Chipko Movement, which aimed to dissuade deforestation. HT ARCHIVE

Himalayas reel under mounting price of progress

In a 1996 HT column, noted environmentalist Sunderlal Bahuguna stressed development's cost, which was echoed by the Nepal disaster

Sunderlal Bahuguna

Sages, saints and scholars since time immemorial have sung to the glory of the Himalaya. The great sage-scholar Ved Vyasa did all his writing in Badri Van (Badrinath). The great Sanskrit scholar Kalidasa was born, according to some, in Kali Math in Kedarnath valley. Himalaya has not only been a place of pilgrimage for the Hindus, but also has in its folds, holy places of Muslims (like Hazratbal), besides the Buddhist monasteries scattered all over it.

The Himalaya is still a source of spiritual inspiration to seekers. All the great teachers of India from Adi Shankaracharya to Mahatma Gandhi and Rabindranath Tagore have visited the Himalaya to get inspiration. Its enchanting scenic beauty attracts nature lovers, and its highest peaks are a challenge for mountaineers.

But the great Himalaya has not remained attractive or even a place worth living for the Himalayan people themselves. You can see them in thousands in big cities, some of them settled there in search of a bright future for themselves and their children. This was not so a century ago, when the Himalaya was prosperous. The accounts of travellers and researchers reveal that there was a flourishing trade between Tibet and India.

Why has the Himalaya, which was so prosperous, become a centre of appalling poverty? The answer escapes the planners and rulers of India, and even China and Pakistan who periodically come out with reports of spending huge amounts on the development of this region. As a matter of fact, the cause of the Himalaya's poverty lies in this very development which is being enthusiastically promoted in this region. For the rulers ruling over this mountain region from Islamabad, Beijing or New Delhi, development of the Himalaya means construction of roads and now even airstrips on a priority basis. For them the roads 'open' the country. Roads mean easy access to the hidden treasures of the Himalayas, that is, its natural resources. The proponents of modern development believe in converting nature into cash. As such, the lush green forests of the Himalaya which were the sources of its prosperity have vanished to satisfy the greed of the metropolitan elite who need wood and even the skins of wild animals to decorate their drawing rooms. The rape of forests continues; it has accelerated during the last few years in the whole Himalayan region and it continues even in the upper sensitive catchments of rivers emerging from the Himalayan glaciers. Only recently, more than 5,000 cedar trees were felled in the Gangotri region, not by smugglers but by the Uttar Pradesh government undertaking, the UP Forest Corporation under the orders of the forest department. Despite a ban on felling of green trees for commercial purposes above 1000 metres since 1981, trees are being felled under the pretext of removing dead and dying trees in thousands every year from virgin forests. The latest victims are the forests of Tons valley which lie in the Govind Pashu Vihar wildlife sanctuary.

This is not peculiar to India alone; in Tibet, half of the forest has been cut down to meet the demands of wood-hungry Chinese cities. In Pakistan, the Himalayan forests fell prey to the greed of immigrant officers from India who clear-felled the mountain forests to raise orchards. Later, refugees from Afghanistan settled down here. The forests of India in the beginning fell prey to the greed of Indian forest contractors and later to the settlers from mountains to the Terai region. India had, under the influence of American interests, clear-felled its Terai forests. Bhutan and the Eastern Himalaya like Arunachal Pradesh and Sikkim had some natural forests but during the last 20 years the proponents of 'scientific forestry' have started the commercial exploitation of these natural mixed forests under the pretext of 'scientific management'.

In Arunachal Pradesh, where there was no commercial exploitation of forests, clear felling of natural mixed forests has resulted in the monoculture plantations of teak in the foothills. But instead of teak, inferior species like bamboo eventually came up.

With forest destruction came climatic changes, recession of glaciers and scarcity of water, erosion of top-soils, and finally the poverty of the people. The efforts to modernise the Himalayan region have resulted in both ecological disaster and economic ruin. It has been difficult for the policy-makers to understand that ecology and economy are interrelated. This has happened all over the world and it is only as a result of this that "the income of the wealthiest 20 per cent of the population is 150 times greater than that of the poorest 20 per cent."

continued on →12



HT carried Bahuguna's write-up in its September 29, 1996 edition.

{ MY INDIA } JAN 2025 STABBING

Accused in Saif attack case to plead guilty



Mohammad Shariful Islam alias Vijay Das, an incarcerated Bangladeshi national, told a sessions court on Friday that he wants to plead guilty for attacking actor Saif Ali Khan during a robbery attempt at his residence in Mumbai, in January 2025, and sought leniency in sentence. This comes after the court had framed charges against him on August 14, after the accused had pleaded not guilty. "He is repenting for the act he committed; hence wants to plead guilty," his lawyer, advocate Vipul Dushing said. The case has been posted for September 11. HTc

{ MY INDIA } IN BILASPUR

Alliance Air aircraft's tyre bursts while landing; all safe



A Bilaspur-bound Alliance Air flight from Delhi suffered a tyre burst during landing at the airport in Chhattisgarh on Friday, but all 41 people on board were safely evacuated, officials said. The flight was carrying 37 passengers and four crew members when the incident occurred at around 11 am, an official said. The left-side tyre suffered a puncture as the flight landed. All passengers and crew members were evacuated and taken to the terminal building, said the official. The airline cancelled the flight scheduled to operate onward from Bilaspur. HTc

{ MY INDIA } IN BISHKEK

Putin to meet Modi at SCO, says Kremlin



Russian President Vladimir Putin will take part in the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit on August 31-September 1 in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, where he will meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Kremlin confirmed on Friday. Putin will also meet China's Xi Jinping and Iran's Masoud Pezeshkian, the Kremlin said. Modi and Putin are expected to review the bilateral relationship during the meeting, the ministry of external affairs said. PM Modi will leave for Uzbekistan on Saturday from where he will head to Kyrgyzstan. AGENCIES

Subhash Chandra case: Why banks lose money in personal guarantor claims

mint

Krishna Yadav and Subhana Shaikh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/MUMBAI: The insolvency court's approval of Zee Group founder and chairman emeritus Subhash Chandra's ₹6.5 crore repayment plan has raised questions about how much banks can recover from personal guarantors when company loans go bad.

Mint explains what personal guarantor insolvency means, why recovery can still be low, and the nuances in the recent Subhash Chandra case.

What is the law on personal guarantors?

A personal guarantor is someone who vouches for a borrower, guaranteeing repayment of the loan in case of a default. Under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), personal guarantors can face separate insolvency proceedings. The IBC lays down the definition of a personal guarantor, how creditors can start the process and prepare the repayment plan, and how it is binding upon approval by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT). In simple terms, a guarantor can be held personally responsible, but the actual recovery depends on the assets available with the guarantor.

Amendments introduced in 2026 have strengthened disclosure requirements. Guarantors must now provide details of assets held directly or indirectly, including beneficial interests and digital assets. The aim is to give creditors and the resolution professional a clear picture of the



Subhash Chandra, Zee Group founder and chairman emeritus.

guarantor's assets.

Why do banks need personal guarantees from company promoters?

Banks typically seek personal guarantees from promoters as an additional layer of protection when lending to companies. It helps the bank to attach assets of the guarantor through a court.

But a guarantee does not replace the lender's primary assessment of the borrower's ability to repay, which in a company's instance is based on its assets and its ability to generate cash flows.

A promoter guarantee should be viewed as a "second way out" for a lender, a senior private sector banker said on condition of anonymity. "We don't give a loan just based on a guarantee. Ultimately, it is the cash flow that pays the

bill."

Even then, the guarantee does not necessarily mean the promoter has sufficient wealth to make good the company's liabilities.

The value of a promoter's guarantee can vary over time, depending on the promoter's personal wealth and the changes in the group's businesses and assets.

How successful have personal insolvency cases been so far?

Data from the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India showed that, as of June, creditors have got about 1% of their admitted claims against personal guarantors since fiscal year 2020 (FY20).

Of the 2,137 proceedings against personal guarantors where resolution professionals were appointed, 64 have led to an approved repayment plan. In other words, for every ₹100 loan that went bad and was backed by personal guarantees, just ₹1 was recovered.

What is the nub of the problem and what do legal experts say?

According to lawyers, the main problem is that personal-guarantor insolvency can establish liability but does not guarantee recovery.

"The purpose of personal guarantor insolvency under the IBC is not to guarantee a particular recovery but to bring the guarantor's assets and financial position within a transparent and enforceable process," said Dikshat Mehra, a partner at Rajani Associates. "Accountability is distinct from recovery." Somdutta Bhattacharyya, a partner at Argus Partners, said the NCLT's role is limited to checking statutory compliance and legality once creditors approve a plan and does not extend to questioning the commercial wisdom of the committee of creditors or the reduction in recoveries agreed upon.

What is Chandra's case history?

Chandra was admitted into insolvency in April 2024 on a plea by Indiabulls Housing Finance, now Sammaan Capital, after he had given a personal guarantee for a ₹170 crore loan to Vivek Infracon that turned bad.

After more than two years of proceedings, NCLT member Nilesh Sharma on Tuesday approved Chandra's ₹6.5 crore repayment plan, acting as the tiebreaker after the original two-member bench gave differing views. Sharma relied on the majority creditors' approval and their commercial wisdom, finding that the procedural lapses and objections were not serious enough to reject the plan.

The plan received 80.81% support from creditors by value, although several lenders opposed it.

To be sure, Sharma's opinion is not the final consequential order and the matter has been sent back to the regular bench for further directions. Once the final order is passed and Chandra fully implements the repayment plan, he will complete the personal insolvency process and exit insolvency.

What has Chandra said about the case?

Chandra said he had only provided personal guarantees for loans taken by companies associated with the Essel Group, not personally borrowing money.

The companies for which he had given guarantees borrowed almost ₹45,000 crore as of January 2019, of which about ₹43,000 crore had since been repaid. This could not be independently verified by Mint.

He also said his net worth was ₹31.79 crore in 2024, including a house worth about ₹25 crore, and that the repayment plan was based on what he could pay from his personal assets.

On the other hand, according to the NCLT order, one respondent had alleged that the resolution professional wrongfully admitted the claims of five entities – Veena Investments, Direct Media Distribution Ventures, World Crest Advisors, Lemonade Capital Advisors, and Corpcall Capital Advisors – which collectively held 61.78% voting share and helped approve Chandra's repayment plan.

However, the tribunal found no evidence establishing them as related parties.

On Friday, Chandra's office said the companies belonged to Jawahar Goel, his younger brother whose business interests were separated from Chandra's in 2008-09 through a family business separation.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

FSSAI-WARNING LABELS

The proposed warning would carry declarations such as "HIGH FAT", "HIGH SUGAR" and "HIGH SALT", depending on the nutrients crossing the prescribed thresholds. For products meeting two criteria, the label would display the corresponding two warnings, such as "HIGH FAT HIGH SALT" or "HIGH FAT HIGH SUGAR". A separate "HIGHLY SWEETENED BEVERAGE" warning has also been proposed for specified sweetened drinks.

The FSSAI said the proposal was prepared to provide consumers with "simple, prominent and easily comprehensible" information about food products high in specified nutrients of concern. The regulator said the approach was intended to facilitate informed food choices, particularly for children and other vulnerable sections of the population.

The proposed labels would have to be displayed in a font size one point larger than the font used in the nutritional information table on the back of the pack, according to the affidavit filed by FSSAI joint director Dr Kavitha Ramasamy.

The shift comes after the Supreme Court's intervention on August 13, when a bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran gave the Centre and FSSAI two weeks to place their final decision on front-of-pack labelling on record.

The court had then questioned FSSAI's reluctance to adopt warning labels for foods high in sugar, salt and saturated fat and asked whether pressure from food manufacturers was influencing the regulator.

"You don't want people of this country to remain healthy? More particularly growing children?" the bench had asked, warning the authorities: "This is your last chance. Next time we will dictate the judgement," it had added.

The court had made clear that its concern was not about banning any particular food but ensuring that consumers, particularly children, knew what they were consuming before making a choice.

The affidavit, filed in compliance with the August 13 order, says the FSSAI has now prepared the proposal and intends to implement the front-of-pack nutrition labelling (FoPNL) system in phases, giving consumers time to accept the new system and the food industry adequate time for reformulation.

Phase I would cover products high in two or more of the specified nutrients – added fat, added sugar and salt, besides specified sweetened beverages. Phase II would extend the warning requirement to products high in any one of these nutrients.

The FSSAI has proposed exempting single-ingredient food products from the warning requirement.

It has also proposed excluding foods that are inherently rich in fat, sugar or salt, specifically citing ghee, edible oil, salt, sugar, jaggery and honey, subject to other requirements under food safety and labelling regulations.

The FSSAI has told the court that the proposed changes will be notified through amendments to the relevant regulations after following the prescribed procedure.

The affidavit comes against the backdrop of a long-running dispute over India's front-of-pack labelling regime.

The original PIL was filed by 3S and Our Health Society, seeking warning labels on packaged foods containing high levels of salt, sugar and saturated fats.

The FSSAI had earlier considered an Indian Nutrition Rating (INR) system based on a star-rating mechanism. But the process stalled amid extensive stakeholder consultations and disagreement over the proposed format.

The Supreme Court had, in its August 13 order, specifically emphasised that countries, including developing nations, had adopted international standards on food packaging and said India should take affirmative steps to protect public health.

The court had also asked the Centre and its expert committee to seriously consider its suggestions and take an appropriate decision at the earliest.

Bihar: No student will 'fail' in Class 10, 12 state board exam

Arun Kumar

letters@hindustantimes.com

PATNA: The Bihar government has decided to remove the word "Fail" from the marksheets of students appearing for Class 10 and Class 12 examinations conducted under the Bihar School Examination Board (BSEB), state education minister Mithilesh Tiwari said on Friday.

According to the minister, students who would not clear the exams will instead have the phrase "Eligible for Skill Training" mentioned on their marksheets, allowing them to opt for vocational training programmes under the Bihar Board of Open Schooling and Examination (BBOSE).

"The Education Department will soon issue the necessary directives in this regard. A student may fail due to a number of reasons and that does not point to his talent, which may flourish in later stages. Therefore, the word 'Fail' will not be used in a marksheet," Tiwari said.

The minister said the initiative has already been approved by chief minister Samrat Choudhary, which will also ensure that month-long special classes are held for students appearing in

STUDENTS WHO DO NOT CLEAR EXAMS WILL INSTEAD HAVE THE PHRASE 'ELIGIBLE FOR SKILL TRAINING' WRITTEN ON THEIR MARKSHEETS

the matriculation supplementary examination to help them perform better.

BBOSE was set up as an autonomous organisation of Bihar's education department in 2011 to provide all students opportunity to excel. The CM is also scheduled to launch the Teacher Support Portal on Teachers' Day to be observed on September 5. The state government has also launched the "Vidya Saathi" app for students of Classes 9 to 12. The platform will connect students with teachers around the clock, with about 75,000 teachers expected to provide one-on-one academic support. The education minister said that the choose transfer of teachers would also be completed in September. He also said that the number of vacancies in TRE-4 could further increase.

MY BENGALURU

STATE GOVT HOLDS MEET WITH HOTEL INDUSTRY OVER FOOD SAFETY

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The Karnataka government on Friday held a high-level meeting with office-bearers of the Karnataka State Hotels Association and leading hotel owners to discuss measures to protect public health and maintain food safety and hygiene across the state, officials said. The meeting was held under the chairmanship of state health and family welfare and food safety and drug administration minister U T Khader, they said.

Over the past one month, food safety officials have conducted continuous and intensive inspections at hotels and restaurants across Karnataka, during which several deficiencies and violations were found, prompting the government to convene the advisory and review meeting.

According to a statement shared by the health department, Khader directed hotel and restaurant managements to accord top priority to food hygiene and quality, noting that millions of people depend on hotel and restaurant food every day. He said strict hygiene and food safety measures must be followed at all levels, from star hotels to small eateries, and that hotel managements should not operate solely with the objective of making profits but also demonstrate social responsibility and concern for public health.

The minister instructed hotels and restaurants to have scientifically designed storage rooms for safely storing food items.

'Don't want to embarrass Cong': Nagendra submits resignation

Naheed Ataula

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka minister B Nagendra, who is facing opposition protests over allegations that he was involved in a funds misappropriation case, submitted his resignation on Friday, 25 days after he was inducted into the state cabinet.

At a press conference in Bengaluru, a tearful Nagendra said he was stepping down to spare the Congress embarrassment and not due to opposition allegations of involvement in the misappropriation of funds from a state welfare agency that came to light in 2024.

The Ballari Rural MLA, then tribal welfare minister, had resigned and was reinducted by chief minister DK Shivakumar as a cabinet expansion on August 3.

Nagendra, who returned from Delhi earlier in the day, requested the Congress leadership to allow him to resign as an MLA so that he could take on his detractors and clear his name.

The four term MLA said his resignation should not be construed as buckling under pressure from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) or the Janata Dal (Secular-JDS). "It's out of my own volition as I don't want to embarrass the Congress party. I will tour the 15 Assembly con-



Minister B Nagendra (left) announces his resignation from the Cabinet at Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru on Friday. PTI

stituencies reserved for the scheduled tribes in the state and explain how the Manuvadis (BJP and JDS) by repeating one lie have tried to make it the truth," he said.

Shivakumar said Nagendra met him after addressing the media and handed over his resignation, but added that he would consult the party high command before taking a final decision. He maintained Nagendra was innocent of the charges levelled against him.

The four term MLA, who had been given the planning and statistics portfolio by Shivakumar, said his resignation should not be construed as buckling to pressure from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) or the Janata Dal (Secular-JDS), whom he referred to as "Man-

uwadis".

"It's out of my own volition as I don't want to embarrass the Congress party. I will tour the 15 Assembly constituencies reserved for the scheduled tribes in the state and explain how the Manuvadis (BJP and JDS) by repeating one lie have tried to make it the truth," he said.

The BJP and the JD(S) had disrupted the monsoon legislature session demanding Nagendra's resignation over his alleged involvement in the misappropriation of Rs 89 crore funds from in the Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation (KMVSTDC).

The BJP had announced a 10-day padayatra from Raichur to Ballari beginning September

1 demanding Nagendra's resignation, which the opposition party announced will continue as there are other issues related to the 2024 case.

Nagendra said this was the era of BR Ambedkar's constitution and not of the Puranas.

"The BJP's Manusmriti mindset is that no Dalit or women, or minorities or Adivasis should rise, but I will not allow this to happen," he said.

He claimed that the state run special investigative team and the Criminal Investigation Department had given him a clean chit. But the Enforcement Directorate (ED), which had initially not included his name in the investigations, had named him after he was inducted in the cabinet for the second time.

Karnataka BJP leaders on Friday termed minister Nagendra's resignation as a "victory" for their sustained agitation over the alleged Valmiki Development Corporation fund scam, while asserting that their fight would continue to establish accountability for the entire episode. Leader of Opposition in the state Assembly R Ashoka told reporters in New Delhi that the resignation marked the first setback for the D K Shivakumar-led Congress government, which, he said, had not completed three months.

"Our struggle, and the struggle of our workers, resulted in this government losing its first wicket in the form of Nagendra's resignation," Ashoka said. "This government headed by Shivakumar has not even completed three months. Nagendra has not even completed 25 or 26 days as a minister, and already one wicket has fallen. Going forward, there will only be more wickets falling."

Calling it "a complete victory" for the BJP's struggle, Ashoka said he would consult party leaders and state president B Y Vijayendra on the proposed padayatra. He said the BJP would continue its agitation on issues concerning people, farmers and the poor.

Ashoka also said he had met the BJP's national president in Delhi and discussed developments in the party. "Our national president also conveyed the message that we should undertake more struggles," he said.

Meanwhile, Karnataka BJP president B Y Vijayendra said Nagendra was only a small player in the alleged scam and demanded that the money be recovered and the larger conspiracy exposed.

"Nagendra is only a small fry. There are big sharks involved in this scam," he told reporters in Bengaluru.

CM: Identify 5 cities for industrial development

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

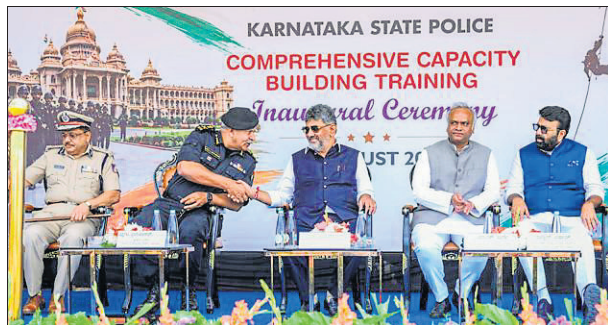
BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister D K Shivakumar on Friday directed officials to identify five cities outside Bengaluru for industrial development.

He was speaking at a progress review meeting of the Commerce and Industries Department at his home office here. The government plans to attract industries to these cities by offering special incentives to investors and creating more job opportunities, the CMO said in a statement.

Shivakumar directed officials to identify five suitable cities with airport connectivity and other necessary infrastructure for the purpose. To streamline the single-window system for industrial approvals, he directed all concerned departments to process applications within the stipulated timeframe. He said he would discuss the matter with the respective departmental ministers.

"Under this system, 22 departments and 119 services have been integrated, with an emphasis on digital and timely approvals. Karnataka ranks ninth in the NITI Aayog's Investor-Friendly Index. The CM directed that measures be taken to improve this ranking further," the statement said.

According to the statement, measures being taken by states such as Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Madhya Pradesh to attract invest-



CM DK Shivakumar with minister Priyank Kharge and others at the inauguration of the Comprehensive Capacity Building Training programme in Bengaluru on Friday. PTI

ments were discussed.

The meeting discussed reforms expected by investors from the state, it said.

Officials said Karnataka had ranked third in attracting investments worth Rs 5.58 lakh crore in the manufacturing sector over the past three years, it added. Special incentives are being offered for investments in semiconductors, aerospace and defence, clean mobility, cell manufacturing and other emerging sectors, it said.

Discussions were held with 80 CEOs at a consultative meeting titled 'Utpadana Manthana' (Manufacturing Churn). Of the 55 suggestions received, 35 have already been addressed, the statement added.

Large and medium industries minister MB Patil, chief secretary to the government Shalini Rajneesh, financial advisor to the CM LK Atheek, additional chief secretary to the chief min-

ister Tushar Girinath, Additional chief secretary of the finance department Ritesh Kumar Singh, principal secretary of the commerce and industries department S Selvakumar, and other senior officials were present at the meeting.

The chief minister also announced that the government will increase the hardship allowance for police personnel by 50 per cent on the lines of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, stressing that those who protect the people should be able to lead a good life.

He was speaking at the launch of comprehensive capacity-building training for Karnataka State Police at Manik Shah Parade Ground here.

"Priority will be given first to the financial needs of the police. The Home Department will provide all the facilities needed by the police," he assured.

KPSC recruitment irregularity row: IAS appears before CID

Coovercolly Indresh

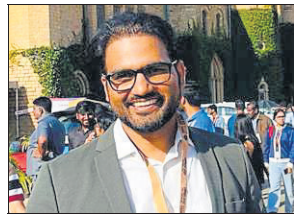
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar, whose whereabouts had come under scrutiny following Enforcement Directorate (ED) searches in connection with the alleged Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) veterinary officer recruitment irregularity, appeared before the criminal investigation department (CID) on Friday for questioning.

Gangwar appeared before CID investigating officer ACP Raghavendra Hegde after the agency issued him a notice directing him to appear before officer for investigation. Officials are questioning him about the alleged irregularities in the recruitment process and his role when he was serving as KPSC examination controller.

The development follows ED searches at Gangwar's residence in Bengaluru and his native place in Uttar Pradesh. The searches were conducted as part of the probe into alleged financial irregularities surrounding the recruitment of veterinary officers. Gangwar, a 2016-batch IAS officer, had reportedly sought 15 days' leave from the government, citing his father's health condition.

He had stated that his father had suffered a heart attack and required medical treatment. However, questions were raised over his whereabouts after



Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar

investigators reportedly visited his native place in Uttar Pradesh following the ED searches. Officials were unable to locate the officer there, leading to speculation about his absence and prompting the CID to issue a notice directing him to appear for questioning.

The alleged KPSC recruitment scam is being investigated by both the ED and CID. While the ED is examining the financial transactions and possible money trail linked to the alleged irregularities, the CID is probing the recruitment procedure and the possible involvement of officials and other persons.

Gangwar had served as KPSC examination controller when the veterinary officer recruitment examination was conducted. He is currently serving as director of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME) in the Karnataka Department of Industries and Commerce. Meanwhile, suspended KPSC chairman Shiva-shankarappa Sahukar has also appeared before the CID and was questioned in connection with the case.

COPS OPEN FIRE AT ILLEGAL ARMS MANUFACTURER

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A suspected illegal arms manufacturer was shot at in the leg during exchange of fire with the police team in the wee hours of Friday, police said. The accused had been identified as Zeeshan (34), a resident of Subhash Nagar in Electronic City, they said.

Police said the incident was reported in Bandepalta police station limits. According to M Narayana, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Electronic City), acting on credible intelligence, Inspector Manjunath RV of Bandepalta Police Station deputised a team led by PSI Sachin Gowda and Constable Sandeep Kamble to track down the suspect.

When cornered, Zeeshan allegedly attacked constable Kamble, who sustained injuries on his left hand, he said. In self defence, the PSI shot one round in air as a warning but when the accused continued to attack, Gowda fired one round at Zeeshan's right leg, the officer said.

28 from Karnataka stranded, untraced in Nepal, Tibet; 4 confirmed safe: Govt

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Twenty-eight people from Karnataka are stranded or untraced in Nepal and the Tibet Autonomous Region following flash floods, with four confirmed safe, the state government said on Friday. Chief minister D K Shivakumar and deputy chief minister G Parameshwara are closely monitoring the situation, and urgent measures have been taken to rescue the affected persons, it said.

The state government is in constant touch with the Union ministry of external affairs and the Resident Commissioner of Karnataka Bhavan in New Delhi to coordinate the rescue and safe return of those affected, officials said. In a press release, the Karnataka government said the State Emergency Operations Centre had, as of 5 pm on Friday, collated details of 28 people from the state stranded or untraced in Nepal and the TAR.



The devastation after mudslide hit Nepal's Nuwakot. PTI

"Of these, 23 are from Bengaluru Urban district, two from Mysuru district, one from Dharwad district, one from Udupi and one from Vijayanagara district," it said. Most of the stranded or untraced persons are reported to be in Timure in Nepal's Rasuwa district, while a few are in Darchen in the TAR, the government said. "Of the 28 persons, four have been confirmed safe, while search and tracing efforts are underway to locate the remaining 24 persons," it said.

The government said a Google form had been created to collect essential information about those stranded, such as their current location and status, contact details, assistance required, travel or group details and tour operator information, wherever applicable.

The information will be used to facilitate rescue, evacuation and other assistance in coordination with the MEA. Indian missions in Kathmandu and Beijing, other concerned authorities

and tour operators, as required, it said. Officials said the SEOC was operating round-the-clock to coordinate assistance, while the Resident Commissioner of Karnataka Bhavan had constituted dedicated teams to monitor developments and liaise with the concerned authorities.

Helpline numbers of the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu and the Embassy of India in Beijing have also been shared for assistance, it said.

The SEOC and the Office of the Resident Commissioner are regularly sharing details of the stranded persons with the MEA's Rapid Response Cells and Indian missions in Kathmandu and Beijing, the statement said.

The details have been shared with the Integrated Control Room of the Union ministry of home affairs to facilitate timely assistance and evacuation, it said. People from Karnataka have been advised to remain in safe locations and follow instructions issued.

foodrun

Mulbagilu dose is hard to find, harder to miss



Ajit Bhaskar

This one is a eulogy. Certain places, you get used to. They leave a fine taste in your mouth, day in and day out, they tick all the boxes and tie all the right knots and hit all the right spots. Then, you taste a void. And it's bitter for a while, to say the least, and then some of us move on.

Shri Thindipotha Mulbagilu Dose Angadi was one such piece of my heart. The place had a few things going for it. For one, a decent Mulbagilu-style dose spot is already hard to come by in this city. And this lay in the Yeshwanthpur-Mathikere area of all places. Second, of course, was the fact that I could smell and taste the ghee in something that came at ₹50 a plate. And they smeared it with kempu chutney and a signature pudu masala for good measure. It was terrific!

Anyway, exposition time. *Mulbagilu* dose is best described as a cross between an *appam* and a *dose*. Made individually in deeper cast iron pans, they take time and some technique. The ones at *Shri Thindipotha* were crisp on the outside and porous and soft within, and mercifully, it wasn't too heavy. Served with 2 chutneys, no complaints.

They also had rice bath. The *palav* was suspiciously green, but it tasted alright. The seating was nothing too fancy, but it was visibly clean.

Recently, I felt let down when I visited the area but found that it had shut down. I had to drown my sorrows at my favourite *Thatte idli* point nearby, but I do really miss this place sometimes. They also offered plain and *masal* *dose*, in addition to *pudi masale* on their menu. Opening as early as 7-730am, it used to be fairly packed. But then again, some things remain inexplicably confusing. Usually, good food made honestly does well in this city. Sadly, this didn't seem to. I really hope they reopen at some point in time. At least somewhere else if not in Yeshwanthpur. Sometimes I suspect it was the really low prices that did them in.

(Ajit Bhaskar, a researcher with a multinational, is famous in Bengaluru for his Thindi (food) runs. He will profile one of his preferred (or newly discovered) haunts for HT every week)



Bengaluru cop dies in bus accident in MP

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A Bengaluru police inspector, who was in Madhya Pradesh as part of an investigation, was among four who died in a bus accident in Rajgarh district on Friday morning, police said.

The deceased, identified as Ravi K B, was serving at the CEN (Cyber Crime) Police Station in Bengaluru City's South-east Division, they said.

The accident occurred on a flyover near Biaoira in Rajgarh district, police said, adding that his colleagues were injured but stated to be safe. Taking to

social media platform 'X', DCP SouthEast of Bengaluru City Police said Police Inspector Ravi K B had travelled to Madhya Pradesh along with a police team to investigate a cyber-crime case.

While proceeding from Bhopal to Indore, the bus in which he was travelling lost control and fell into a gorge.

He sustained serious injuries and succumbed to them, the post said. Chief minister D K Shivakumar expressed grief over the demise of the inspector and said, "I share the grief of his family and the police department in losing this dedicated officer."

Will not allow implementation of Kasturirangan report, says Dy CM

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka deputy chief minister G Parameshwara on Friday said the state government strongly condemned the Centre's "anti-people" notification seeking to implement the Kasturirangan report, adding that it will not be implemented under any circumstances.

"I wish to make it clear to the people of Karnataka that there has been no change in our stand that the report must not be implemented under any circumstances," Parameshwara, who also serves as minister for revenue and sports said, in a statement. According to him, the notification issued by the Union government declaring 1,449 vil-



G Parameshwara

lages across 10 districts in the Western Ghats as Ecologically Sensitive Areas (ESAs) has caused serious concern among lakhs of families in the State.

"Keeping the interests of the people living in Malnad and the Western Ghats regions in mind, we have decided to discuss the Centre's decision and explore solutions. We have also decided to convene a one-day special ses-

sion of the Legislature for this purpose." Parameshwara noted that for centuries, the people living in Karnataka's Western Ghats have built their lives by adopting a balanced way of living in harmony with nature and respecting the environment around them. "This close relationship between people and nature is what has sustained the vitality of the Western Ghats even today. In such cases, attempting to displace people in the name of environmental protection is an anti-life and inhumane approach," he stated.

The deputy chief minister said if the central government genuinely cared about protecting the environment, it must listen to the grievances of the people who have lived in those villages.

SOUTH REGION

21 Nepal flash flood survivors from TN safely arrive in Delhi

S Vijay Karthik

letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: The 21 Kailash Manasarovar Yatra pilgrims from Tamil Nadu who survived the flash floods that hit Nepal's Rasuwa region on Wednesday arrived at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport and met external affairs minister S Jaishankar.

Senior govt officials and BJP's Tamil Nadu chief Nainar Nagen-thran was also present.

The group was part of the 57 pilgrims who left for the yatra on August 24 through a travel agency based in Kumbakonam. They were travelling in three buses, two of which were hit in the flash floods and left 36 people missing. The survivors were housed in camps at an Armed Police Force outpost in Timure, around 160 km north of Kathmandu.

"Received a group of 21 pilgrims from Tamil Nadu who were rescued from the floods in Nepal. Was moved to hear their experience first hand. Thank the Nepali Army headquarters and the Embassy of India in Kathmandu for this rescue effort. Appreciate facilitation of their smooth return to India," Jaishankar wrote on X.

Earlier, a four member team of state ministers arrived at New Delhi to monitor the steps underway to facilitate the return of over 80 people from the state who were stranded in Nepal after the disaster. The group included ministers Aadhav Arjuna, A Rajmohan, R Vinoth and Thangam Thennarasu. They met officials at a control room set up at Tamil Nadu House to take stock of the situation. They also met the 21 rescued pilgrims at the venue later.

"I am happy. But, there were 40 more people with us who



External affairs minister S Jaishankar meets flash flood survivors from Tamil Nadu upon their arrival at New Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport on Friday.

remain out of contact," said Navu Kabirdoss, one of the 21 returnees. Minister Rajmohan said that around 83 pilgrims from Tamil Nadu and Puducherry who were in Nepal when the incident took place remained missing.

The four ministers also met foreign secretary Vikram Misri to discuss the ongoing rescue operations. The state delegation said the control room in Tamil Nadu received over 900 calls in the last two days.

"Right now, around over 140 people are reportedly safe in another location. They will be brought to Kathmandu soon. Today, 21 pilgrims have been rescued. I can say, as of now over, 90 people remain without any contact," Rajmohan said.

8 from Keralam still missing in Nepal: CM

Vishnu Varma

letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Keralam chief minister VD Sathesnan said on Friday that eight people, including four Australian citizens of Keralam origin, who are stranded in Nepal following the flash floods there are yet to be contacted.

Their details have been forwarded to the Ministry of External Affairs for urgent trace and contact operations, he said.

The CM said that helpline calls regarding 82 persons were

received in the state of which 60 are from the state and have been deemed to be safe. Another 14 individuals belong to other states in the country and their details have been forwarded to the MEA and respective State governments.

19 Keralites belonging to a 23-member Kailash Manasarovar Yatra are safe and currently travelling towards Kathmandu, he added.

Norka Roots, the nodal agency for expatriate Keralites, is coordinating operations with the ministry, said Sathesnan.

FAMILY OF FOUR FROM A.P. AMONG THOSE MISSING AFTER FLOODS

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Amid ongoing relief operations after the devastating flash flood in Nepal's Rasuwa region, four more people from Andhra Pradesh were found missing, officials said, adding that efforts were underway now to trace a total of ten people from the state.

The four reported missing on Friday were identified as Santosh Kumar Sahu (47), his wife Surabhi (43), their son Spandan (18), and daughter Shaina Sahu (13). The family was from Vizianagaram district's Parvatipuram.

"They are feared to have been swept away after their vehicle was caught in sudden floodwaters while crossing a bridge in Nepal," said an official with the state IT department's Real-Time Governance Society (RTGS) wing.

The family, originally from Panda Veedhi in Parvatipuram, had settled in London for nearly two decades.

On a happier note, the official confirmed that one of those suspected missing was confirmed safe on Friday. "We have information that Kakani Aparna, a resident of Guntur, who was believed to be missing in the Nepal floods, is safe at Saga in Tibet," the official added.

The others missing include Choppapaparu Ramesh, Vennelakanti Balasubramanyam, Annandevara Venkatram and Annandevara Anagha, Athuri Shashikumar and Nimmagadda Rajyalakshmi.

HC notice to Stalin in ₹1-cr defamation suit

Ayesha Arvind

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The Madras high court on Friday issued notices to former chief minister and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) chief and the party's IT wing on a civil defamation suit by Tamil Nadu minister Aadhav Arjuna, seeking damages worth ₹1 crore over an X post linking him to an accused in a narcotics case.

Justice K Govindarajan Thilakavadi ordered the notices, returnable by September 15, after hearing preliminary submissions from Arjuna's counsel. The judge also took note of senior counsel J. Ravindran entering appearance for Stalin and the DMK IT Wing.

Arjuna told the court that post by DMK's IT Wing was "ex facie false" and highly defamatory. It claimed that Arjuna was related to John Britto, accused of smuggling narcotics worth ₹258 crore, which were seized in two separate DRI raids in 2024. The post claimed that John Britto, an accused in a narcotics case involving the alleged smuggling of banned substances worth



MK Stalin and Aadhav Arjuna

₹258 crore, was related to Arjuna.

Arjuna has denied any connection with Britto and maintained that his relative, P John Britto, had in fact approached the Greater Chennai Commissioner of Police to complain that he was being wrongly identified as the suspected drug smuggler. He sought a permanent injunction restraining Stalin and the DMK IT Wing from making similar statements against him, as well as directions to issue unconditional apologies in both Tamil and English through their social media accounts as well as widely circulated Tamil and English newspapers and television channels. He has sought that the apologies be given the same prominence as the allegedly defama-



tory post. He has also asked the court to direct the deletion of the post and screenshots of it circulating on social media, and to surrender electronic records relating to its creation. He has sought reimbursement of the costs incurred in filing the suit.

Arjuna has alleged that the post was not an isolated statement by a social media functionary of the DMK, but was published on the instructions of Stalin.

In June, Arjuna had issued a legal notice to Stalin and the DMK IT Wing demanding a public apology within 48 hours over the allegations. At the time, he had alleged that Stalin and the DMK were "wantonly and wilfully" tarnishing his image.

TN CM Vijay inspects Puzhal Central Prison

S Vijay Karthik

letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Friday inspected the Puzhal Central Prison in North Chennai.

Established in 2006 at an outlay of ₹77 crore, it consists of three jail complexes with a capacity to accommodate 3,000 prisoners.

"The chief minister inspected the isolation ward, visitor's room, de-addiction rehabilitation centre, library, advanced

computer training centre, execution area," the government said in a statement.

Vijay visited the inmates' workshops and reviewed products made there—including iron vegetable racks, paper bags, and office file boards—as well as blankets made in the powerloom unit and the tailoring section. He also checked the quality of food served to the prisoners and asked them about their requirements.

Later, he also inspected the M3 Puzhal Police Station.



Konda Surekha

SUREKHA CALLS ON REVANTH FOR RAKHI BONHOMIE AS CONG MULLS PUNITIVE ACTION

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Telangana state environment and forests minister Konda Surekha on Friday met chief minister A Revanth Reddy at his residence on Raksha Bandhan and tied a rakhi to him.

Surekha drove to the chief minister's residence on Friday and tied a rakhi to him. She, however, did not get an opportunity to have a one-on-one meeting with Revanth Reddy.

Speaking to reporters at her residence later, Surekha sought to play down the political overtones surrounding the occasion. "I have tied a rakhi to the chief minister for the third time. I am a sister to everyone. I will not make any political comments in the festive atmosphere," she said.

Meanwhile, the Congress high command is examining the report submitted by the Telangana PCC recommending disciplinary action against her for violating party discipline.

On August 23, the PCC submitted its report to the high command suggesting appropriate action against Surekha, whose daughter Konda Sushmita Patel allegedly made derogatory and defamatory comments against Revanth Reddy at a programme held at Parkal in Warangal district on August 19.

1 dead in TN bus accident



The wreckage of a bus after it collided with a truck on Salem-Chidambaram National Highway in Cuddalore district early on Friday. The incident left one person dead, said police.

46-year-old woman from AP found dead in Tiruvallur district

S Vijay Karthik

letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: A 46-year-old woman from neighbouring Andhra Pradesh was found dead in Tiruvallur district early on Friday, police said, adding that a probe was underway.

The body of the victim, who was identified as Aruna from Savarambakkam Village in Andhra Pradesh, was found on the banks of Vellakulam lake in Uthukottai in Tiruvallur district on Friday morning, police said.

A senior officer said she had come to attend a function at her relative's house in Vadattur Kandigai village.

A group of young men found the body and told police, who rushed to the spot and recovered the body of the deceased and a smartphone lying nearby.

Police said initial investigations led by police inspector Devaraj suggested that the perpetrators allegedly poured acid on the victim's face and sprinkled salt around the face to prevent easy identification, police said.

"Three special teams have been formed. The body has been sent to the district govern-

POLICE RULED OUT ROBBERY BECAUSE ALL OF THE ITEMS OF JEWELLERY ON THE VICTIM'S PERSON WERE FOUND INTACT

ment hospital for an autopsy," the official said on conditions of anonymity.

Since the jewellery worn by the victims including the mangal sutra and earrings remained intact, police have ruled out a robbery.

Based on surveillance cameras located nearer to the spot where the body of the victim was discovered, the police are probing various angles to determine the motive behind the murder, they said.

Meanwhile, during a brief Assembly address on Friday, Premalatha Vijayakant—DMDK general secretary and Virudhachalam MLA—called on the government to ensure a thorough probe into the incident and bring all perpetrators to justice. The DMDK is an ally of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) in Tamil Nadu.

THREE DROWN ACROSS KERALAM IN SEPARATE INCIDENTS

KOZHIKODE: Three people, including two minors, drowned in separate incidents at Vadakara and Kodaluvally here on Friday, police said.

In one of the incidents, two people drowned in the Chovva river at Maniyur near Vadakara this evening, they said.

The deceased were identified as Nabeel (19) and Sinan (12), both natives of Orkkatteri near Vadakara.

According to police, a four-member group entered the river to learn swimming. All four got caught in the strong current, but two managed to escape. Nabeel was found during a search by locals and rushed to Vadakara Cooperative Hospital in a critical condition, where he died. Sinan was found around 6 pm during a joint search by locals and Fire and Rescue Service personnel, but he could not be saved.

In another incident, a 15-year-old boy drowned at a waterbody at Manipuram, here on Friday evening. The deceased was identified as Muhammad Shahin.

Vikramarka reviews SCCL plans for exploring K'taka's Devadurga

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Singareni Collieries Company Limited (SCCL), a public sector coal mining company owned by the Telangana government, has moved towards diversifying into gold and copper mineral exploration in Karnataka's Devadurga block.

Telangana deputy chief minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, who visited the Devadurga gold-copper block in Raichur district on Friday, directed the Singareni officials to expedite exploration activities and use advanced technologies to assess the quantity and quality of the deposits.

SCCL secured the exploration rights for the Devadurga block through an auction conducted by the Centre. On Thursday, Vikramarka formally launched SCCL's gold and copper exploration programme at Lingadahalli village in Devadurga taluk. He inspected the identified exploration areas and reviewed the plans prepared by officials.

He also visited an exhibition of mineral samples collected from the block and sought details about the proposed exploration and extraction.

"Given the block's proximity to Hutti Gold Mines, a Karnataka government undertaking, there is a considerable scope for leveraging the expertise of the neighbouring state with decades of experience in gold exploration, mining, processing and refining," Vikramarka, who holds the finance and energy portfolios, told reporters.



Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka

tion areas and reviewed the plans prepared by officials.

He also visited an exhibition of mineral samples collected from the block and sought details about the proposed exploration and extraction.

"Given the block's proximity to Hutti Gold Mines, a Karnataka government undertaking, there is a considerable scope for leveraging the expertise of the neighbouring state with decades of experience in gold exploration, mining, processing and refining," Vikramarka, who holds the finance and energy portfolios, told reporters.

During his second-day visit to Karnataka's gold-mining areas on Friday, the deputy chief minister inspected the Hutti and UT gold mines in Raichur district and studied the entire process, from extraction of gold-bearing ore to the production of refined gold.

He directed Singareni officials to consider establishing a joint venture between SCCL and Hutti Gold Mines, saying that combining the technical capabilities of the two public sector undertakings could help increase domestic gold output.

Vikramarka asked officials to prepare an action plan covering joint exploration, mining, ore extraction, processing, adoption of modern technologies, deployment of technical experts and training of personnel.

He said Hutti Gold Mines' expertise in gold mining and SCCL's experience in large-scale mining could complement each other and help achieve better results in the project.

{ SUKUMARA KURUP } NEW LEAD FOUND TO BE FALSE

Decades-old fugitive saga gets a new twist

Vishnu Varma

letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: One winter morning in January 1984, Sukumara Kurup strangled a man who bore some resemblance to him, burnt his body near a field in Alappuzha and faked his own death—in the process committing one of India's first insurance crimes.

The 38-year-old then vanished.

For over four decades, Kurup's proven brutality and mythical escape became the subject of countless stories, movies, television plots and reams of neighbourhood gossip. The police believed it futile to search for the elusive fugitive.

Until now.

This week, a claim by a police officer who investigated the case in 2017 that Kurup was still alive in Brunei, and a photo of a hirsute man with neatly combed hair released by a Malayalam channel, kicked the police into action and rumour mills into overdrive—only for the authorities to conclude that one of Keralam's most-wanted men was probably still in the wind, or dead.

The unlikely revival saga began with retired policeman Ali Akbar, a sub-inspector in the same station where the original first information report was filed in 1984 and who later reopened the case in 2017. Akbar claimed he had found Kurup alive, living as an Indian-origin Malaysian citizen, frequenting a particular hotel on most evenings.

"I, and another officer, travelled to a lot of places that were associated with Kurup's life both in mufti and in uniform and collected a lot of evidence. We got information from some of his family members that he was indeed alive. I submitted a report attesting the same, but no further action was taken," said Akbar.

The former police officer said Kurup was living as an Indian-origin Malaysian citizen in Brunei for years and nudged the police to arrest him. "There is a hotel that he frequently visits, mostly in the evening hours. The information that I collected can be easily verified using modern technology," he said.

Malayalam channel 24 News took the theory further, broadcasting photographs of a man it claimed as Kurup living in Brunei.

KERALA HOME MINISTER RAMESH CHENNITHALA SAID HE DIRECTED THE STATE CRIME BRANCH TO VERIFY THE REPORT'S ABOUT KURUP

nei. The channel reported that Kurup worked in the construction sector, led an affluent life by pretending to be a Malayali-origin Malaysian citizen, and was in regular contact with his wife and son living in Abu Dhabi. The network alleged that the notorious fugitive was in his 80s and healthy.

But on Friday, a family based in Thrissur said that the man, whose photo and passport were aired on TV, was actually Damodara Menon, not Kurup.

"The photo circulating on TV and social media is that of my elder brother Damodara Menon. Reports that it is Kurup are baseless. He is based in Brunei and is in his 80s," a family member told local media.

The Keralam crime branch team also confirmed that the

photo was that of Menon, not Kurup. Bijoy Thomas, special branch assistant commissioner of police, visited the family in Thrissur to record their statement. "Preliminary findings show that it is Damodara Menon. We will relay it to higher authorities. The investigation on Kurup will continue," he said.

Keralam home minister Ramesh Chennithala said he directed the crime branch to verify reports about Kurup, who was played by actor Dulquer Salmaan in an eponymously titled 2021 movie Kurup.

"I have instructed ADGP crime branch Venkatesh to investigate. The Keralam Police need to contact Interpol and find out the actual truth of the matter. Right now, what we have are just rumours. These are not verified facts," the minister said.

Chennithala also denied Akbar's claim that the former police officer submitted a report to the authorities stating Kurup was still alive. "It has been around 40 years now. What is there to suppress? In any case, let the investigation proceed, and the truth will come out. We don't know yet whether this is true or false. In any case, the govern-

ment has initiated the necessary actions," he said.

The developments have held Keralam in a fever grip this week, adding another unlikely twist to the long saga.

Born Gopalakrishna Kurup in Cheriyannad near Alappuzha, Kurup is wanted in the 1984 murder of Chacko, a film representative.

According to the police, Kurup hatched a plot with his co-brother Bhaskara Pillai and two others to kill a man who held a physical resemblance to him, and claim the insurance payout by faking his own death.

In the early hours of January 22, 1984, police say Kurup kidnapped Chacko on the side of the national highway in a car, rendered him unconscious using liquor laced with ether, and strangled him to death. The group then scorched Chacko's face to make him indistinguishable, put him in the front seat of a car and set fire to it, police said.

However, subsequent investigation unearthed the conspiracy and revealed that the victim was Chacko. Though multiple teams of the police fanned out across the state and country looking for Kurup, he remained elusive.

SPOTLIGHT | NEPAL FLOODS

MEA: 320 missing, 400 stuck in China



Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: At least 320 Indians remain missing and around 400 others are stranded on the Chinese side following devastating flash floods along the Nepal-Tibet border and India is ready to extend all possible help to Kathmandu in its rescue efforts, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said 96 Indian nationals who were stranded on the Chinese side have safely crossed over to Nepal by land route.

Twenty-one Indians arrived in New Delhi this afternoon, a day after they reached Kathmandu from the flood-affected areas of Nepal, he said.

The Indian nationals from Tamil Nadu were received at the airport in the national capital by External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar.

The death toll from Wednesday's flash floods in Nepal rose to 538 with more bodies recovered as search and rescue operations continued, according to latest details shared by Nepalese authorities.

"As far as the number of people (Indians) whom we are not able to contact or who are missing, the figure at this point in time is 320," Jaiswal said.

"There are also around 100 persons of Indian origin who remained uncontactable. These are people of Indian origin who may have gone for Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, but they hold other nationalities," he said.

Jaiswal said 400 Indians are stranded on the Chinese side but they are safe.

"They have been in touch with their family. Our embassy has been in touch with several of them. Many of their family members also contacted us through the helpline numbers that our embassy is running in Beijing." "Our embassy is in touch with local authorities in China, and they are working out as to how these people who are there can be evacuated," he noted.



(Top) EAM S Jaishankar meets Indian survivors of the Nepal flash flood at Delhi airport on Friday. (Above) Rescuers pull out a person in a tunnel hit by a mudslide in Nepal's Rasuwa

ANI/REUTERS

In a related development, Jaishankar held a high-level meeting with senior officials and reviewed the situation in Nepal with a focus on tracking the status of missing Indians. Indian envoys to Kathmandu and Beijing also joined the meeting online.

"Discussed the relief and rescue efforts underway in Nepal today. Our Embassies in Kathmandu and Beijing provided an updated picture in respect of the status and well-being of Indian nationals," Jaishankar said on social media.

"The concerned MEA Divisions apprised us of the further relief supplies to be sent to Nepal. We give highest priority to this issue," he said.

Jaishankar said New Delhi is making "urgent efforts" to ascertain the status and well-being of Indians stuck in flood-hit areas.

Since Wednesday night, India sent a total of 47.5 tonnes of emergency supplies to Nepal in two military transport aircraft and is in the process of sending more relief materials.

State govts revise numbers of those missing in Nepal

NEW DELHI: Several states on Friday reported more people missing in flood-hit Nepal, with many able to get information about the safety of those stranded.

A Maharashtra government official said 404 people from the state are stranded but confirmed safe in various parts of Nepal. Besides, 105 people have returned to India.

West Bengal chief minister Suvenudh Adhikari said two of the 39 reported missing have been found to be safe, and efforts were underway to trace the rest.

Keralam chief minister VD Satheesan said that eight people, including four based in Australia, were stranded in Nepal and are yet to be contacted. He added that helpline calls regarding 82 people were received, and 60 have been deemed to be safe.

In Odisha, three more people from the state were reported missing in Nepal, besides a Melbourne-based couple.

Andhra Pradesh authorities revised the total number of missing people to 10, with one presumed missing being traced.

Chhattisgarh reported two NRIs missing and two, who were earlier presumed missing, establishing contact with their families in the state on Friday.

Nine more people from Gujarat were reported missing in Nepal on Friday, taking the total to 26, including several NRIs. **HTC**

TRUCKS STRANDED AT U.P. BORDER, NEPAL TRADE HIT

MAHARAJGANJ/KUSHINAGAR (UP): The Nepal flash floods have disrupted cross-border trade between India and the neighbouring country, with the movement of goods vehicles to Kathmandu and other parts of Nepal via Maharajganj in Uttar Pradesh, affected by damaged and flooded roads., officials said.

A queue of around 16km of cargo vehicles has formed on the Indian side of the Sonauli border in Maharajganj as trucks wait to enter Nepal, they said.

A queue of around 16km of cargo vehicles has formed on the Indian side of the Sonauli border in Maharajganj as trucks wait to enter Nepal, district police officers said. **PTI**

Satellite images show destruction at China-Nepal border crossing

APRIL 19, 2024



AUGUST 27, 2026



A combination of handout satellite images released by Vantor on Thursday. (Left) An image taken on April 19, 2024 showing an overview of the China-Nepal border and Gyirong Port/Rasuwaadhi border post before flooding and (right) an image taken on Thursday after flash floods and landslides hit the area. Rescue teams waded through mud on Thursday searching for people missing after flash floods and landslides struck the Nepal-Tibet border on Wednesday, sweeping entire villages away. The first Chinese teams also reached the Gyirong port.

HANDOUT / SATELLITE IMAGE © 2026 VANTOR / AFP

Nepal flood debris choke Gandak river

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

GORAKHPUR: Flash floods in Nepal have sent a heavy load of silt, wood and household debris into the Gandak river system in Kushinagar and Maharajganj districts, prompting irrigation authorities to temporarily shut canals amid concerns that the sediment could choke the network.

The Gandak river flows in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh from Nepal.

Chief engineer (irrigation) Vikas Singh said nearly 13 cubic metres of silt has been added to the river, making the sediment load a major concern. He said canals would be reopened after the high-silt flow subsides.

Debris, including LPG cylinders, tyres, cupboards and large quantities of wood, all swept away from flood-affected areas of Nepal



Debris washed down from Nepal into Gandak.

has also been spotted on the banks of Gandak in Kushinagar and Maharajganj districts, local authorities said.

Kushinagar District Magistrate Mahendra Singh Tanwar said teams were monitoring the river

and vulnerable stretches. "The water level and movement of material in the Gandak are being continuously monitored. People have been advised to remain alert and stay away from the river," officials said.

District authorities remain on high alert in villages along the Gandak and other rivers receiving water from Nepal. Revenue officials, police, SDRF teams and other agencies have been deployed at vulnerable locations, with evacuation arrangements in place if the situation worsens.

The floods have also disrupted travel in Nepal, with tourists returning to India through the Sonauli border (Maharajganj district) after road closures, mudslides in the Himalayan nation.

Mumbai resident Meena Satpal, who was travelling to Kathmandu

with her family, said they were stopped near Narayanghat. (a transport hub in Nepal). After learning about worsening flood conditions and road damage, they abandoned their trip and returned to India through the Sonauli border, she said.

Meanwhile, four more bodies were recovered at different places along the river on Friday, police said. Six bodies were recovered by NDRF personnel on Thursday.

Bihar on flood alert

Parts of Bihar are facing a threat of a deluge as water levels in the Ganga, Gandak, Kosi and Burhi Gandak rivers showed a rising trend following the devastating flash floods and rains in neighbouring Nepal. Around 1.02 lakh cusecs of water were released from the Gandak Barrage by 5 pm on Friday.

INFOSYS PUBLIC SERVICES CEO 'NOT REACHABLE'

NEW DELHI: Infosys on Friday said its subsidiary Infosys Public Services' chief Lax Gopisetty is not reachable following the devastating floods in Nepal.

Gopisetty was visiting the region in a personal capacity, the Bengaluru-headquartered IT company said.

"We can confirm that our colleague Lax Gopisetty, who was visiting the region in a personal capacity, is currently not reachable," Infosys said in a statement.

The company further said it is working with relevant agencies to gather information and establish contact with Gopisetty.

Infosys also said it remains in close communication with his family and is providing all necessary support during the difficult time. **PTI**

Transit hub at the centre of search for foreigners

Prawesh Lama

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Rasuwa, a critical transit hub near the Nepal-China border, has become the epicentre of a multi-agency search and rescue operation after flash floods along the Trishuli River basin flattened infrastructure across the district and left hundreds, including foreign tourists, stranded.

On the eve of the disaster, Rasuwa hosted an estimated 800 to 1,000 foreign tourists during the peak season for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, Langtang, and Gosai Kunda treks. These travellers were concentrated across 40 to 45 main hotels and 80 to 90 homestays in Kerung, Syabrubesi, and Timure, according to the Trekking Agencies' Association of Nepal (TAAN).

TAAN is helping the Nepal police and army with details of

travellers (mostly tourists) who registered with them and moved toward this border town from Kathmandu for the three main treks. Nepalese authorities are using these details to track missing persons and share information about foreigners with their embassies.

Karma Sherpa, senior vice president of TAAN, said, "This is the peak season for the Kailash Mansarovar and the other two treks. They stay the night in the town area of Rasuwa near the Trishuli river. There are around 40-45 hotels in Kerung, Syabrubesi, and Timure. By our estimate and data collected from all trekking agencies, nearly 800 to 1,000 foreigners had converged at Rasuwa or were on their way towards the border district, having reached Nuwakot. The number could be higher because some tourists may not have registered and came for the



Devastation seen in Rasuwa after the flash flood.

Langtang and Gosai Kunda treks, which do not require crossing the border."

Sherpa said breakfast time at these hotels is usually before 8 am, after which tourists proceeding toward the Mansarovar Yatra have to travel higher into Tibet for immigration and other formalities. "We are hoping the tourists may have left their hotels early in the morning before the flash flood

swept the structures away, as is being reported. Perhaps many tourists have climbed into the higher reaches before the flash flood swept through the town," he said.

According to the latest data shared by Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA), at least 1,924 people have been reported missing, while 579 bodies have been recovered. Tourism department records show that of the 743 tourists reported missing, 622 are yet to be traced. The trekking body said all the tourists were in Rasuwa or its adjacent districts of Dhading and Nuwakot, heading towards Rasuwa for the three treks. Both neighbouring districts are among the six impacted by Wednesday's flash floods.

The foreigners include citizens from various countries, including India, the US, the UK, Australia,

Ukraine, Malaysia, Canada and Singapore. Of the 183 Indians reported missing, 85 have been rescued or contacted. The US accounts for the second-highest number of missing foreigners at 67 (with two rescued), followed by Ukraine at 61.

TAAN's second vice president, Sanam Sherpa, said they have been unable to contact staff at the hotels in Rasuwa where tourists stay. "The bridges and villages in Nuwakot, which connect to Rasuwa, are also destroyed. We are unable to get in touch with the hotels. There are reports that the hotels and towns in both districts (Nuwakot and Rasuwa) are washed away. Our association has shared the passport and registration details of every foreigner registered with the different trekking companies before proceeding to this border district."

ABHISHEK, DEREK AMONG 4 BOOKED OVER SCUFFLE IN KOLKATA OFFICE

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: Three FIRs have been registered against Trinamool Congress (TMC) national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, Rajya Sabha MP Derek O'Brien and two others, and 13 people were arrested on charges of attacking police and Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) officials during their visit at Abhishek's Camac Street office in south Kolkata, police said on Friday. Meanwhile, a Kolkata court on Friday denied bail to those arrested and remanded them to police custody until September 3, according to lawyers aware of the developments.

In a related development, the Calcutta high court denied relief to Abhishek who filed a petition on this issue, lawyers said.

According to police, a scuffle broke out between TMC leaders and Abhishek's supporters on Thursday afternoon when civic body officials, accompanied by a police contingent, entered the office premises to remove a billboard that the TMC had allegedly installed there without permission. The arrests were made between Thursday evening and Friday morning, they added.

Kolkata police commissioner Ajay Kumar Nand said that more people would be charged after reviewing video footage of Thursday's incident. "We are reviewing video footage to see who was involved. Action will be taken on that basis."

Influencer abducted and set on fire dies; no lead on suspects yet

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

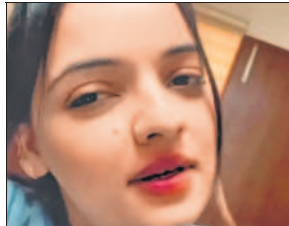
CHANDIGARH: A 28-year-old social media influencer has died during treatment at the Postgraduate Institute of Medical Education and Research (PGIMER), Chandigarh, nearly two months after she was allegedly abducted and assaulted before being set on fire in Morinda in Punjab's Rupnagar district, police said on Friday.

According to police, the incident took place on July 3, when Manjeet Kaur, the victim who was a resident of Kharar, was called by her acquaintances, identified as Shubhi and Pinda, to meet them near a liquor shop in Sector 34, Chandigarh.

Citing a complaint registered by Manjeet's mother Kanta Devi, police said upon reaching near the shop, the suspects allegedly abducted Manjeet in a car and drove her to Morinda, where she was physically assaulted, tied to a mulberry tree and set on fire.

Meanwhile, Manjeet's friend arrived at the spot and doused the fire using a blanket. She was rushed to a local hospital in Morinda, later moved to PGIMER-Chandigarh on July 9 due to her critical condition.

Manjeet remained unconscious at PGIMER for several weeks before briefly regaining consciousness on August 5, when she recounted the entire



Manjeet Kaur

ordeal to her family. Despite medical efforts, her condition deteriorated, and she succumbed to her severe burn injuries on August 26.

Police are still trying to ascertain the reason behind the killing of the woman.

Officers aware of the matter said Manjeet was a divorcee, was in a live-in relationship with one of the suspects and is survived by her seven-year-old son.

Following her death, the Sector 34 police station registered an FIR under Sections 140(1) (kidnapping), 103(1) (murder), and 3(5) (joint criminal liability) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). "A case of kidnapping and murder has been registered on the complaint of woman's mother," Chandigarh senior superintendent of police Kanwardeep Kaur said.

Officials said police are yet to make any arrest in the case and teams are currently conducting raids to locate Shubhi and Pinda.

{ SUKUMARA KURUP } NEW LEAD TURNS TO BE FALSE

Decades-old fugitive saga gets a twist

Vishnu Varma

letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: One winter morning in January 1984, Sukumara Kurup strangled a man who bore some resemblance to him, burnt his body near a field in Alappuzha and faked his own death—in the process committing one of India's first insurance crimes.

The 38-year-old then vanished. For over four decades, Kurup's proven brutality and mythical escape became the subject of countless stories, movies, television plots and realms of neighbourhood gossip. The police believed it futile to search for the elusive fugitive.

Until now. This week, a claim by a police officer who investigated the case in 2017 that Kurup was still alive in Brunei, and a photo of a hirsute man with neatly combed hair released by a Malayalam channel, kicked the police into action and rumour mills into overdrive—only for the authorities to conclude that one of Kerala's most-wanted men was probably still in the wind, or dead.

The unlikely revival saga began with retired policeman Ali Akbar, a sub-inspector in the same station where the original first information report was filed in 1984 and who later reopened the case in 2017. Akbar claimed he had found Kurup alive, living as an Indian-origin Malaysian citizen, frequenting a particular hotel on most evenings.

"I and another officer, travelled

A FORMER POLICE OFFICER SAID KURUP WAS LIVING AS AN INDIAN-ORIGIN MALAYSIAN CITIZEN IN BRUNEI FOR YEARS AND NUDGED POLICE TO ARREST HIM

to a lot of places that were associated with Kurup's life both in mufti and in uniform. We collected a lot of evidence. We got information from some of his family members that he was indeed alive. I submitted a report attesting the same, but no further action was taken at the time," Akbar said.

The former police officer said Kurup was living as an Indian-origin Malaysian citizen in Brunei for years and nudged the police to arrest him. "There is a hotel that he frequently visits, mostly in the evening hours. The information that I collected can be easily verified using modern technology," he said.

Malayalam channel 24 News took the theory further, broadcasting photographs of a man it claimed as Kurup living in Brunei. The channel reported that Kurup worked in the construction sector, led an affluent life by pretending to be a Malayali-origin Malaysian citizen, and was in regular contact with his wife and son living in Abu Dhabi. The network alleged that the notorious fugitive was in his

80s and healthy.

But on Friday, a family based in Thrissur said that the man, whose photo and passport were aired on TV, was actually Damodara Menon, not Kurup.

"The photo circulating on TV and social media is that of my elder brother Damodara Menon. Reports that it is Kurup are baseless. He is based in Brunei and is in his 80s," a family member, Karunakara Menon, told local media.

The Kerala crime branch team also confirmed that the photo was that of Menon, not Kurup. Bijoy Thomas, special branch assistant commissioner of police, assisted the family in Thrissur to record their statement. "Preliminary findings show that it is Damodara Menon. We will relay it to higher authorities. The investigation on Kurup will continue."

Keralam home minister Ramesh Chennithala said he directed the crime branch to verify reports about Kurup, who was played by actor Dulquer Salmaan in an eponymously titled 2021 movie "Kurup". "I have instructed ADGP crime branch Venkatesh to investigate. The Kerala Police need to contact Interpol and find out the actual truth of the matter. Right now, what we have are just rumours. These are not verified facts," the minister said.

Chennithala also denied Akbar's claim that the former police officer submitted a report to the authorities stating Kurup was still alive. "It has been around 40 years now. What is there to suppress? In any case, let the investigation proceed, and the truth will

come out. We don't know yet whether this is true or false. In any case, the government has initiated the necessary actions," he said.

The developments have held Kerala in a fever grip this week, adding another unlikely twist to the long saga.

Born Gopalakrishna Kurup in Cheriyanad near Alappuzha, Kurup is wanted in the 1984 murder of Chacko, a film representative.

According to the police, Kurup hatched a plot with his co-brother Bhaskara Pillai and two others to kill a man who held a physical resemblance to him, and claim the insurance payout by faking his own death.

In the early hours of January 22, 1984, police say Kurup kidnapped Chacko on the side of the national highway in a car, rendered him unconscious using liquor laced with ether, and strangled him to death. The group then scorched Chacko's face to make him indistinguishable, put him in the front seat of a car and set fire to it near a paddy field, police said.

However, subsequent police investigation unearthed the conspiracy and revealed that the victim was Chacko. Though multiple teams of the police fanned out across the state and country looking for Kurup, he remained elusive.

A Malayali nurse said she identified Kurup after he allegedly stumbled into a hospital in Ranchi in 1988, for treatment of a serious illness in the 90s. Neither that claim nor that of any subsequent sighting has been confirmed.

EXPLOSION NEAR MANIPUR BJP MLA'S RESIDENCE

Thomas Ngangom

letters@hindustantimes.com

IMPHAL: An explosion occurred near the residence of Manipur government spokesperson Sapam Ranjan Singh in Imphal West in the early hours on Friday, police said.

According to police, the explosion took place at around 1.30 am on Friday within the residential complex where the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MLA's house is situated, which left a minor damage on the walls of the compound. However, no casualties were reported.

A case has been registered against unidentified people and investigation to identify the nature of explosives, police added. Later in the day, chief minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh visited the residence and personally inspected the site of the blast.

"This act of violence is an attack on our democracy and the perpetrators will be brought to justice soon," the chief minister wrote on X.

Bodies of four Naga members retrieved

The remains of four Naga community members shot dead in an ambush were retrieved and carried in a procession to a district hospital in Senapati on Friday, where the post-mortem of the bodies will be conducted, police said.

The deceased were identified as Tadsongbou Ringkangmai, Mariakidbou Wijnamai, Wisobou Charenamai and Anil Wijnamai, police added.

{ VALMIKI CORP CASE ROW }

K'taka minister submits resignation

Naheed Ataulla

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka minister B Nagendra, who is facing opposition protests over allegations that he was involved in a funds misappropriation case, submitted his resignation on Friday, 25 days after he was inducted into the state cabinet.

At a press conference in Bengaluru, a tearful Nagendra said he was stepping down to spare the Congress embarrassment and not due to opposition allegations of involvement in the misappropriation of funds from a state welfare agency that came to light in 2024. The Ballari Rural MLA, then tribal welfare minister, had resigned and was reinducted by chief minister DK Shivakumar as a cabinet expansion on August 3.

Nagendra, who returned from



Karnataka minister B Nagendra (left) announces his resignation from the Cabinet at Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru on Friday. PTI

Delhi earlier in the day, requested the Congress leadership to allow him to resign as an MLA so that he could take on his detractors and clear his name.

Shivakumar said Nagendra met him after addressing the media

and handed over his resignation, but added that he would consult the party high command before taking a final decision. He maintained Nagendra was innocent of the charges levelled against him. The four term MLA, who had

been given the planning and statistics portfolio by Shivakumar, said his resignation should not be construed as buckling to pressure from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) or the Janata Dal (Secular-JDS), whom he referred to as "Manuwadis". "It's out of my own volition as I don't want to embarrass the Congress party. I will tour the 15 Assembly constituencies reserved for the scheduled tribes in the state and explain how the Manuwadis (BJP and JDS) by repeating one lie have tried to make it the truth," he said.

The BJP and the JD(S) had disrupted the monsoon legislature session demanding Nagendra's resignation over his alleged involvement in the misappropriation of Rs 89 crore funds from in the Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation (KVMSTDC).

The BJP had announced a 10-day padayatra from Raichur to Ballari beginning September 1 demanding Nagendra's resignation, which the opposition party announced will continue as there are other issues related to the 2024 case.

Nagendra said this was the era of BR Ambedkar's constitution and not of the Puranas. "The BJP's Manusmriti mindset is that no Dalit or women, or minorities or Adivasis should rise, but I will not allow this to happen," he said.

He claimed that the state run Special Investigative Team and the Criminal Investigation Department had given him a clean chit. But the Enforcement Directorate (ED), which had initially not included his name in the investigations, had named him after he was inducted in the cabinet for the second time.

NC MP MEHDI CHALLENGES NC LEADERSHIP ON ART 370, MAY QUIT

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

SRINAGAR: Amid reports suggesting that his formal resignation could come on November 3, estranged National Conference Lok Sabha MP Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi on Friday said he will resign from Parliament but demanded answers on the party's shift in stand on Article 370 before stepping down.

In a two-page letter to party president Farooq Abdullah, who had asked him to seek a fresh mandate for opposing the party line, Mehdi asserted that his resignation would come "even without you asking, but before that must come accountability".

Taking to X, Mehdi said he has written a letter to his party president in response to the latter's public demand for his resignation. "Awaiting his response to the questions I have asked in the letter," Mehdi said in the post.

Referencing Abdullah's recent press statement urging Kashmiris to be self-reliant rather than seeking economic concessions from the Centre, Mehdi said that those words resonated deeply with him, capturing the frustration of being expected to assume a "posture of supplication" before the BJP.

However, the Shia leader questioned why the party leadership objected when he raised the very same concerns about Jammu and Kashmir's constitutional rights. "The uncomfortable truth is that we are not even 'begging' for Article 370; we are 'begging' for statehood – a right the Supreme Court itself has recognised," Mehdi said in his two-page letter, arguing that NC's position has become indistinguishable from that of the BJP.

The letter comes at a time when reports suggest that the Srinagar MP is likely to resign from the Lok Sabha on November 3, coinciding with the death anniversary of his father Aga Syed Mehdi, who was assassinated by terrorists in an IED blast on November 3, 2000.

Mehdi warned that accepting statehood as the outer limit of political aspirations risks legitimising the constitutional changes of August 2019 and surrendering essential protections for the region's land, culture, and fragile environment. Questioning the NC's core narrative, Mehdi said the NC fought and won the 2024 assembly elections on the promise of restoring Articles 370 and 35A.

Children tie Rakhi to PM



PM Narendra Modi celebrates the occasion of Raksha Bandhan with schoolchildren at his residence on Friday. DPR PMO

'What azaadi are you looking for?' CM slams Jadavpur protesters

Tanmay Chatterjee

letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: West Bengal chief minister Suwendu Adhikari on Friday said his government will not allow Kolkata's Jadavpur University campus to remain a free ground for "Maoist sympathisers" and elements seeking Kashmir's independence, adding that he "knows the medicine to the disease".

"You keep saying azaadi (independence). What azaadi are you looking for? Azaadi to consume heroin and ganja? You are the *tukre tukre* gang," Adhikari told a large crowd that gathered outside the sprawling JU campus to attend a BJP-held mass singing of the Vande Mataram.

The term 'tukre tukre gang' was coined by the BJP to bracket members of Left and ultra-Left parties and intellectuals.

"You don't express grief or hold rallies when 45 CRPF jawans are killed by terrorists in Awantipora and tourists belonging to a specific religion are gunned down at Pahalgam. But anti-war rallies are held when Operation

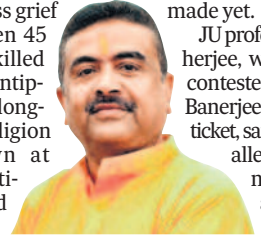
Sindoor is carried out against Pakistan".

Adhikari alleged that the CPI(M), during its 34-year-long regime, and the TMC shielded Maoist elements at JU for electoral gains. "The Maoist elements did not vote for TMC but they gave only one dividend. They raised the 'No vote to BJP' and 'No vote to Narendra Modi' slogans during elections. Mamata kept the Maoists alive for this political dividend," he said.

He made the remarks days after a wooden JU emblem installed on one of the gates was damaged on August 20 when members of the Akhila Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad, allegedly tried to enter the campus following a clash between its members and supporters of Left student unions the earlier night.

The university lodged a complaint but no arrests have been made yet.

JU professor Nandini Mukherjee, who unsuccessfully contested against Mamata Banerjee in 2011 on a CPI(M) ticket, said: "He made wrong allegations. There are no Maoists in JU. It is a centre of education."



Bihar Cong plans dharna outside party HQ in Delhi

Saubhadra Chatterji

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: It will be Congress versus Congress on September 8 as Bihar leaders are planning to stage a dharna outside the party headquarters, Indira Bhavan, over the lack of opportunities to meet Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi and to remove key functionalities for the party's dismal performance in Bihar elections.

A large group of Congress leaders have called for "a peaceful dharna and demonstrations outside the Indira Bhavan". They want general secretary for Bihar Krishna Allavaru and state party chief Rajesh Kumar removed.

In recent times, Congress workers had protested outside 24 Akbar Road and then party chief Sonia Gandhi's residence 10 Janpath only once in May 2004 when Sonia decided not to become the Prime Minister.

The demonstrations next month are planned differently.

"Congress People from across Bihar will join this protest. We are trying to meet Rahul Gandhi from November 2025 onwards but they are not giving us time. So we have decided to protest outside Indira Bhavan," said

Anand Madhav, a member of the All India Congress Committee, the body that elects party president. "We had a meeting with Mallikarjun Kharge ji, KC Venugopal and Ashok Gehlot on November 3, 2025. They have promised to pay heed to our demands — but nothing has happened," added Madhav.

The leaders joining the protests include Bihar unit's former vice presidents Jamal Ahmed and Rajkumar Rajan, AICC members Nagendra Paswan, former MLA Chhatrapati Yadav, B Akhtar, former Secretary, BPCC and former MLA Anil Kumar Singh.

In the 2025 Bihar elections, the party won just six seats, down from 19 in the 2020 poll. Allavaru and Kumar had faced criticism from party's rank and file over the poor performance. Kumar himself lost his seat.

Senior party leader in Bihar Kishore Kumar Jha, an AICC member, supported the protestors and said, "They are dedicated Congress workers. The party High Command must listen to them and address their grievances. However, it would be better if a solution can be found through discussions."

CENTRE APPOINTS 2 MORE SENIOR OFFICERS TO NTA

Sanjay Maurya

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Friday appointed an IRS officer as director and another as joint secretary in the National Testing Agency (NTA), taking forward its ongoing overhaul of the testing body following a series of examination-related lapses.

According to two separate orders issued by the department of personnel and training on Friday, Anshuman Sharma, IRS (IT:2005), has been appointed joint secretary in the NTA under the department of higher education for five years, or until further orders, whichever is earlier. The appointment has been made by temporarily upgrading a vacant deputy secretary/director-level post to joint secretary level for an initial period of two years, the order issued by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) said.

In a separate order, the ACC approved the appointment of Sathya S, IRS (IT:2011), currently director in the ministry of cooperation, as director in the NTA on a lateral-shift basis. She will serve in NTA until August 24, 2030, the balance period of her five-year deputation at director level or until further orders.

{ NILEKANI-LED TASK FORCE }

Suggestions invited on exam system reform

Sanjay Maurya

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The high-powered task force (HPTF) headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to recommend reforms in India's public examination system on Friday invited suggestions from students, parents, teachers, academic institutions and other stakeholders, including those involved in exam security, technology, governance and student well-being.

Stakeholders can submit their suggestions by September 13 through the task force's website, email, phone or WhatsApp +917827042830.

Submissions are allowed in English, Hindi and regional languages, according to a press statement of the ministry of personnel, public grievances and pensions, issued on Friday.

The six-member HPTF, constituted by the Centre on July 27, has been tasked with examining comprehensive reforms in the conduct, security, design and governance of public examinations, including those conducted by the National Testing Agency.

The panel will examine measures to strengthen institutional processes, improve examination integrity and security, deploy technology, expand examination infrastructure, improve accessibility and inclusion, and safeguard student well-being.

As part of its exercise to fulfil its mandate for creating a "robust, secure, transparent, equitable and future-ready" examination system, the HPTF has invited suggestions on the conduct and security of public examinations, examination design and assessment methodology, and governance, accountability and institutional arrangements.

Stakeholders can suggest measures for "prevention, detection and redressal" of examination malpractices, greater use of technology, including "secure Computer-Based Testing", and creation and augmentation of examination infrastructure.

Suggestions are also invited on promoting student well-being "throughout the examination process", besides any other measure that could add value to the examination system.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



HT wknd
A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY

Army inks pact to buy Javelin anti-tank missiles

Rahul Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Indian Army has signed a letter of offer and acceptance (LOA) to buy the Javelin anti-tank guided missile system from the United States through its foreign military sales process, a move the US said would further deepen bilateral defence cooperation.

"This agreement reflects a defence partnership that is growing deeper, more capable, and more consequential," US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor said on Friday.

"The Javelin agreement demonstrates the depth of US support for the Indian Army and creates new opportunities for our defense

industries to work together. We see tremendous potential for future cooperation that strengthens the defense industrial bases of both countries."

The deal listed the non-MDE (major defence equipment) items, including Javelin LwCLU or CLU Basic Skills Trainers; missile simulation rounds; battery coolant unit; interactive electronic technical manual; Javelin operator manuals; lifecycle support; physical security inspection; spare parts; system integration and check out; Security Assistance Management Directorate (SAMD) technical assistance; Tactical Aviation and Ground Munitions (TAGM) Project Office technical assistance; tool kits; training; Block I CLU refurbishment servi-



The Javelin system sale will be worth \$45.7 mn. LOCKHEED MARTIN

ces; and other related elements of logistics and program support.

The development comes nine months after the US State Department approved the possible sale of the weapon system to the Indian Army following New Delhi's request.

The Javelin system sale will be worth \$45.7 million. The missile

system is used by the US Army, US Marine Corps and several international customers. It is designed for the use against a wide array of targets, including armoured vehicles and fortified positions. It is produced by the Javelin Joint Venture, a partnership between RTX and Lockheed Martin.

The development also comes after India and the US signed a 10-year framework last year to deepen the bilateral defence relationship.

"The landmark signature further strengthens the US-India Major Defense Partnership by demonstrating the depth of ongoing US support to the Indian Army. It also opens discussions on mutually beneficial co-produc-

tion and additional opportunities to strengthen the defense industrial bases of both countries," the US embassy said.

The US Defense Security Cooperation Agency (DSCA) hailed the proposed sale last November.

It will support the foreign policy and national security objectives of the US by helping to strengthen the US-Indian strategic relationship, the DCSA said at the time. "The Government of India has requested to buy one hundred (100) FGM-148 Javelin rounds; one (1) Javelin FGM-148 missile, fly-to-buy; and twenty-five (25) Javelin Lightweight Command Launch Units (LwCLU) or Javelin Block I Command Launch Units (CLU)," the DCSA said in a statement on November 19, 2025.

Defence ministry eases export rules to boost market access

Rahul Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The defence ministry on Friday announced a set of reforms to streamline procedures and ease access for Indian industry to foreign markets as it steps up efforts to boost defence exports.

The department of defence production has undertaken a comprehensive set of reforms to simplify the defence export standard operating procedure (SOP) and the open general export licence (OGEL) framework, it said. India has set a target of achieving ₹50,000 crore in defence exports by 2029-30.

The OGEL is a standing one-time authorisation that enables eligible exporters to self-generate export authorisations for multiple consignments of specified defence items without seeking separate authorisation for each consignment. It provides greater flexibility while reducing repetitive procedural requirements.

"These reforms seek to reduce procedural requirements, facilitate faster access to international markets and enable Indian defence companies to respond more effectively to global business opportunities, while ensuring that national security considerations remain fully safeguarded," defence minister Rajnath Singh said.

The ministry said the defence export SOP has been simplified

THE OGEL IS A STANDING I-TIME AUTHORISATION THAT ENABLES EXPORTERS TO SELF-GENERATE AUTHORISATIONS FOR MULTIPLE CONSIGNMENTS

in several ways. Stakeholder consultation has been dispensed with for exporting non-lethal defence items to most destinations, while appropriate safeguards remain for sensitive countries.

Three existing OGEL SOPs — covering major platforms and equipment, parts and components, and intra-company transfer of technology — have been consolidated into one unified framework, providing exporters with a common and simpler structure, the ministry said.

"The measures are expected to particularly benefit Indian defence manufacturers, including MSMEs, by enabling them to respond more quickly to international tenders and exhibitions," the ministry said.

Defence production reached an all-time high of ₹1.78 lakh crore, while defence exports stood at ₹38,424 crore in FY 2025-26, the ministry said and said that the reforms would strengthen the momentum of India's defence manufacturing.

UGC-NET RESULTS ANNOUNCED FOR 84 SUBJECTS; OVER 4K QUALIFY FOR JRF

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The results of the UGC National Eligibility Test (NET) for 84 subjects have been announced, with more than 4,000 candidates qualifying for the Junior Research Fellowship, the National Testing Agency said late on Friday.

"Out of 6.07 lakh candidates who appeared for the exam in 84 subjects, over 97,000 have qualified for PhD admissions and over 4,000 for JRF," a senior NTA official said. The National Testing Agency (NTA) had ordered fresh examinations for candidates who appeared for the English, Commerce and Sociology papers in June this year after an expert committee found factual, typographical, translation and language-related errors in the question papers. The NTA released the UGC-NET answer key on August 16, nearly two months after the examination, while issuing a special notice concerning the Sociology, Commerce and English papers.

Later, on the same day, it announced that the three examinations would be conducted afresh in September, citing the errors. The re-examinations are scheduled for September 9 and 10, for which candidates will not be required to pay an additional fee. The NET is conducted by the NTA to determine the eligibility of Indian nationals for the role of assistant professor and for the Junior Research Fellowship in Indian universities and colleges.

CM VIJAY SEEKS VACATING STAY ON BYPOLLS TO 5 SEATS

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Friday moved the Madras High Court seeking to vacate its interim order restraining the Election Commission from issuing notifications for bye-elections in five constituencies where MLAs had resigned.

The plea was filed in response to a Public Interest Litigation challenging the proposed bypolls under Section 151-A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951.

Vijay, who had resigned from Tiruchirappalli (East), sought dismissal of the PIL with exemplary costs. **PTI**

Stir over Malala book reading in Guj, 3 held

HT Correspondent

letter@hindustantimes.com

AHMEDABAD: Two people have been injured when members of Hindu right-wing groups staged protests at the AUDA Garden in Gujarat's Ahmedabad against a book-reading session featuring Nobel laureate Malala Yousafzai's memoir and Holocaust victim Anne Frank's diary, police said on Friday, adding that three of the accused have been arrested.

The incident comes a few weeks after a private school in Ahmedabad was forced to drop books by Yousafzai and Frank from its mandatory reading list after protests from right-wing groups.

"On Thursday evening, a group

had gathered at AUDA Garden for a book-reading session when they were confronted by around 20 people carrying sticks, who said they were associated with the VHP and Bajrang Dal. They questioned the group about reading books by Malala Yousafzai and Anne Frank, following which an altercation took place. Two people sustained minor injuries and three have been arrested," said Vastrapur police inspector Geeta Chaudhari.

According to the FIR, the participants had gathered at the garden around 4pm on Thursday to read Yousafzai's *I Am Malala* and Anne Frank's *The Diary of a Young Girl*, along with books by other writers.

Yousafzai's book details her early life and an assassination

attempt made against her by the Taliban. Frank's book shares details of her time in hiding during the Nazi occupation.

"Around 6.30pm, a group of men arrived and questioned the participants about reading Yousafzai's book. The confrontation escalated and some members were assaulted," said the complaint, registered by one Jaykumar Natvarlal.

It alleged that three of the participants — Sneha Bhavsar, Savan Zalaria and Shashikumar — were assaulted, a woman was pulled by her hair and another was slapped.

Based on the complaint, a case has been registered against at least 20 people, including two identified as Hiren Rabari and Jimeet Rabari. The accused have been

booked for rioting and unlawful assembly, along with several other sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, said an officer aware of the matter. So far, six people have been identified in the case.

On Thursday, the Bajrang Dal's Gujarat unit posted on X that it had opposed Yousafzai's book after it was included in the school's reading material. "When Bajrang Dal got wind of this Pakistan-supporting mentality, they first tried explaining... but when that didn't work, they explained it in true Bajrang Dal style," the post said.

Taking swipe at the incident, Congress leader Pawan Khara said: "Ignorance, with a dash of communalism, is an incurable disease."

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.





OPINION

The
Hindustan Times
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

The lesson from student suicides

Entrenched discrimination and scant support for students in institutions need urgent addressing

A week ago, a 31-year-old masters student at IIT-Delhi died by suicide. The incident — the eighth such death of a student in the institute in three years — has ignited unprecedented protests on a campus where stirs are uncommon and pupils are involved in breakneck academic pursuits; students are demanding the resignation of some senior office bearers and professors, a transparent probe, and compensation. In response, the IIT has inducted students into the panel looking into the issue, and announced measures such as curricular flexibility, more mentorship, mental health care infrastructure, greater support and more diversity, inclusion and bias sensitisation that it hopes can ameliorate the problem.

They won't be enough. At the heart of this crisis that has engulfed Indian educational campuses — especially its prestigious higher education institutions (HEIs) — is a toxic cocktail of widespread discrimination meted out by students and teachers, weak institutional grievance redressal mechanisms, and the misplaced but closely held belief that creating structures to level the playing field are antithetical to merit. Unless the government and academic leadership show will and intent — both have been in short supply — to uproot such attitudes, inquiry panels can only deliver piecemeal solutions that act as patchwork salves, not life-saving medicine.

The grim story has repeated itself over and over. Students, many of whom come from marginalised backgrounds and castes, find that after years at coaching institute cubbyholes and achieving their goal of landing at one of India's premier institutions, their struggle begins all over again. For some, it is the medium of instruction; for some, socialisation and related isolation; for some, structural discrimination they find difficult to counter; and for some, it is the sheer academic pressure — further complicated by the overwhelming aspirations of their families, for whom the student represents the only shot at economic and social mobility in a country where such ladders are few.

Government data bears this out. The number of student suicides in India climbed to a record high of 14,488 in 2024, marking a 4.3% rise from 13,892 cases in 2023 even as overall suicides declined marginally by 0.4% from 171,418 to 170,746 during the same period, according to the latest data from the National Crime Records Bureau. While overall suicides in 2024 rose 11.6% over five years and 27.8% over 10 years, student suicides grew at a sharper pace, rising 15.7% in five years and 62.2% over 10 years. It is not like the problem is not known. A Supreme Court-appointed National Task Force termed student suicides an "epidemic" earlier this year. It found 65% HEIs have no access to mental health service providers, 73% lack full-time mental health professionals, and fewer than 4% conduct suicide-risk assessment. Almost half of the HEIs had not conducted faculty sensitisation workshops in the 18 months the panel took to finalise its interim report.

But if little has changed, it must be attributed to lack of genuine intent to move the needle. If the government and institutional leadership feel that academic excellence can be divorced from student well-being, they are wrong. If young people are being driven to extreme steps because they find their institutions too hostile, it is a blot on our democracy. A course correction is urgent. Plenty of road maps exist — from dedicated bridge courses and flexibility in medium of instruction to functional SC/ST cells, robust mental health support that's not only on paper, and diversity initiatives beyond glossy pamphlet photographs. But to initiate change, the problem has to be taken seriously, and not treated as an irritant. Unfortunately, leadership at every level is guilty of doing just that.

{ THIRD EYE }

Barkha Dutt



Does the Opposition really enjoy a sweet spot at present?

An important factor to consider here is that the youth likely sees the BJP-led dispensation as the establishment

There are two parallel narratives about Rahul Gandhi's politics at this moment — well, three, if you include those who oppose him. But, among those who think the Leader of the Opposition is enjoying a bit of a sweet spot, two varying responses are on offer.

One line of thinking is that Gandhi is the unflinching ideological counter to the BJP and the Indian Right wing, who, after a brief flirtation with soft Hindutva (remember the temple runs and the Congress' claim of him being a *janeudhari* Brahmin?), has doubled down on a hard mix of secularism and social justice invocations. This school of thought casts the battle between the BJP and the Opposition as a clash of principles and assumes the floating voter has seen the light.

The other, very different argument explaining the traction Gandhi is enjoying suggests that India has entered a post-ideological political phase. Economic restlessness, a veritable jobs crisis, and an angst over administrative and governance issues figure at the top of everybody's minds. Right-Left ideological binaries, in this scenario, are irrelevant.

As is often the case with much in Indian politics, neither theory fits neatly or exactly.

There definitely seems to be a distinct ennui with the oft-repeated tropes of religious identity politics. And that hasn't started now. In 2024, the BJP slipped below the majority mark; the inauguration of the Ram Mandir a few months prior to the elections barely yielded any extra points.

You could argue that a host of other factors led to the knocks the BJP took in UP, including an alleged lack of perfect synchronicity between Amit Shah and Yogi Adityanath and the absence of full engagement by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).

But I remember meeting a host of BJP supporters who dismissed the idea of the temple as any sort of voting issue. It was almost as if, with the temple built, the political power of Hindutva somewhat weakened.

For instance, while it is impossible to prove empirically, I don't think most Indians are agitated too much about the two-stanzas-versus-full-song debate around Vande Mataram. The Congress may have bungled, with a rare dropping of guard by Sonia Gandhi who was visibly uncomfortable on camera when the full song played at the Congress headquarters on Independence Day. This happened days after Parliament passed legislation making the full version of *Vande Mataram* compulsory. The episode became especially embarrassing given that the full song was played at official functions in Congress-helmed states. But, despite the BJP's "minority appeasement" charge, it is tough to believe that such rows will create a measurable electoral backlash.

Equally, I don't think most voters see the Congress as a fount of ideological purity. The INDIA bloc was a pastiche of parties with little in common ideologically. Many of the parties that came together to take on the BJP have actively opposed each other. The unlikely coupling of the Thackerays-led-Sena and proclaimed hard-core secularists is perhaps the most obvious example of this.

Amid the noise about whether this is an ideological fight for the idea of India, a more mundane reality is lost: The Modi government, in its 12th year of power, is experiencing old-fashioned anti-incumbency. For an entire generation of voters — many of whom would have supported the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests at Jantar Mantar — the BJP has become the status quo; it is the establishment now. So, while the BJP, under Modi, still sees itself as led by a self-made outsider who took on the old, entrenched elite, for younger voters, the Sangh Parivar is the old elite.

The India Against Corruption (IAC) movement of 2011 that birthed the Aam Aadmi Party and the CJP protests of 2026 are not exactly analogous. But there is one parallel that is important to understand. Every few years, a generation



It is the CJP that mainstreamed the idea of protests. And it is the CJP — not the Opposition parties — that secured the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as education minister.

of voters, quite naturally, starts seeking something new and fresh. Modi never participated in the Anna-Hazare-Kejriwal protests despite RSS supporters making up, at least in part, the crowds that defined the IAC movement. But, he did politically benefit from the anti-Congress and anti-establishment mood that the IAC protest amplified.

Similarly, the CJP, by placing protests at the heart of the citizen's compact with the State, opened a door for the traditional Opposition. Paradoxically, the CJP's ability to create a movement out of a meme simultaneously reflected the limitations and failures of the Opposition parties while creating a new and willing audience for the latter.

Rahul Gandhi has not openly allied with, or supported, the CJP. While other Opposition leaders spoke comfortably from the Jantar Mantar stage, it took Sonia Gandhi's intervention for Congress leader Pawan Khera to visit the protestors at the site of their hunger strike. Gandhi pointedly held his own separate protest outside the PM's residence while the CJP's Abhijeet Dipke and team were at Jantar Mantar. But, even if Gandhi did not go to the CJP protests, he did have some of the youth protesters by his side in public appearances — the alleged pellet-gun victim, Sahil, and Rhiya, the young woman who stopped a police van in Mumbai being among them.

While that is strategically a smart move by him, let us give credit where it is due: It is the CJP

that mainstreamed the idea of protests. And it is the CJP — not the Opposition parties — that secured the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as education minister.

Another factor we will miss if we look at the present situation solely through the conventional lens is how Indians, especially the younger ones, have emphasised the value of individual liberty and freedom. One of the reasons Rahul Gandhi's all-women event at Pune was so popular is because it put a girl's liberty at the centre of conversation. When Gen Alpha and Gen Z students come out on the streets in different parts of India, it is about the right to demand better from their administration. But, it is also about the right to speak and be heard.

The BJP is a behemoth, a clever and smart election machine led by a leader who should never be underestimated. Modi won Uttar Pradesh in the aftermath of demonetisation. So, we should be careful in drawing any hasty conclusions about electoral consequences. It will also be important to see how the BJP course-corrects. After all, just some months ago, the West Bengal win made them seem invincible. A win in Uttar Pradesh will change the political framing of today's conversation all over again.

But, for now, there is a fascinating churn unfolding.

Barkha Dutt is an award-winning journalist and author. The views expressed are personal

Cortisol: Just a stress hormone, not a villain

“Doctor, my cortisol is acting up.” It is a sentence I hear often. A patient recently came to see me with fatigue, disturbed sleep, and some weight gain. Searching the internet, she was convinced that her “cortisol was too high” and had discovered a bewildering array of advice on how to “lower cortisol naturally”.

Cortisol has become one of the most talked-about hormones on social media. It is blamed for abdominal obesity, poor sleep, anxiety, ageing, and lack of energy. Numerous websites and holistic practitioners promote coconut water, apple cider vinegar and rhodiola as ways of reducing cortisol. However, there is no good evidence that these remedies reliably lower or manage cortisol. The irony is that cortisol is not a bad hormone. We cannot live without it.

Produced by the adrenal glands, two small glands above the kidneys, cortisol is essential for maintaining energy, blood pressure and the ability to respond to physical and psychological challenges. One of its major functions is in glucose metabolism—the process by which the body produces, maintains and uses glucose, its principal source of energy. Cortisol helps ensure that sufficient glucose is available to the brain and other vital organs, particularly during stress.

Cortisol also follows a precise daily rhythm. Levels are normally highest in the early morning, helping us wake up and become alert, and gradually decline during the day, reaching their lowest levels around midnight. Thus, it is not simply the amount of cortisol that matters; its timing and

pattern are important too.

What happens when we become stressed?

The body activates two closely coordinated systems. The first is the autonomic nervous system. Within seconds, the sympathetic nervous system triggers the familiar “fight-or-flight” response. Heart rate and blood pressure rise, breathing becomes faster and energy is rapidly mobilised. This is the immediate, adrenaline-mediated response. The second response is slower but more sustained. The brain activates the hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal, or HPA, axis. The hypothalamus and pituitary communicate with the adrenal glands, which release cortisol. This helps maintain glucose and other energy supplies while the body continues to deal with the challenge.

Cortisol is, therefore, part of an elegant survival mechanism. If confronted with danger, the body does not want to spend energy on long-term projects such as building bone or storing nutrients. It wants energy immediately available to the brain, heart and muscles.

Short-term stress, therefore, is not necessarily harmful. Our bodies are designed to cope with it. The difficulty comes when the stress response is repeatedly activated or remains disturbed for prolonged periods. Modern life exposes many people to persistent pressures — work demands, financial worries, inadequate sleep, family responsibilities and constant digital stimulation. Chronic stress can influence immunity, metabolism, nar-

diovascular function and mood, and may be associated with fatigue, disturbed sleep, hypertension and depressive symptoms.

But this does not mean that every person with fatigue or weight gain has excess cortisol. Genuine cortisol excess is a medical condition. In Cushing syndrome, persistently high cortisol can produce a characteristic pattern: weight gain, particularly around the abdomen and face; muscle weakness; thinning skin; easy bruising; purple stretch marks; high blood pressure; high blood glucose and osteoporosis. Menstrual disturbances and psychological symptoms may also occur.

At the opposite extreme, too little cortisol can be equally dangerous. Adrenal insufficiency may cause profound fatigue, weakness, loss of appetite, weight loss, dizziness and low blood pressure. Nausea, abdominal symptoms and salt craving may occur, while primary adrenal insufficiency may cause increased skin pigmentation. During severe illness, surgery or another major physical stress, inadequate cortisol can precipitate an adrenal crisis, a potentially life-threatening emergency.

These are genuine medical disorders requiring proper evaluation and treatment.

What about measuring cortisol to diagnose “stress”?

Cortisol testing is generally reserved for situations in which doctors suspect a specific disorder, particularly adrenal insufficiency or Cushing syndrome. It is not a routine test for psychological stress.

Chronic stress can influence the HPA axis and alter the normal pattern of cortisol secretion. But this does not necessarily mean that chronically stressed people have persistently high cortisol levels. The relationship is much more complicated. Two people experiencing similar levels of stress may have quite different cortisol responses. Corti-



Ambrish
Mithal

Renew, don't renegotiate, 1951 Refugee Convention

The 1951 Refugee Convention recently marked its 75th anniversary. A reflection on the future of refugee protection, and India's role in shaping it, is merited. Long before a modern refugee protection regime emerged, the institution of asylum embodied the humanitarian tradition of protecting refugees. This found expression in the 1951 Convention, adopted in response to the displacement that followed World War II. The Convention enshrined the principle of non-refoulement: States must not send refugees back to territories where their lives or freedom are under threat. Today, refugee crises, from Myanmar to Ukraine, continue to test the resilience of the framework. Is the world ready to renew the commitment that gave birth to the Convention?

The Convention's legal framework has dem-

onstrated a remarkable ability to adapt — through interpretation, State practice, and regional instruments — without needing renegotiation. Yet calls to reopen or replace it have become more frequent. Critics argue a post-WW-II treaty can't adequately respond to protracted conflicts, mixed migration, climate-induced displacement, and growing national security concerns. These concerns deserve attention. But, reopening the Convention amid rising scepticism towards asylum risks weakening existing protections.

The Convention does not establish a binding framework for equitable responsibility-sharing

among States that can deliver durable solutions for refugees. As a result, neighbours of conflict-afflicted countries shoulder a disproportionate share of housing the displaced simply because of proximity. Recognising this, the New York Declaration for Refugees and Migrants was adopted in 2016, followed by the Global Compact on Refugees (2018), to affirm more predictable responsibility-sharing, strengthen international cooperation, and expand third-country resettlement and complementary pathways.



Vinai K
Singh

tection to millions fleeing persecution, many people displaced by generalised violence, State collapse, and the climate crisis fall outside its scope. Additional protection frameworks can



Jyoti
Singh

respond to these emerging forms of displacement without weakening the Convention's core guarantees.

Although India is not a party to the Convention, it has provided refuge to Tibetan refugees, Sri Lankan Tamils, Chakmas, Afghans, and others through executive action, judicial intervention and constitutional protections — showing that refugee protection need not depend on treaty commitments alone, but can also be supported through administrative practice, judicial engagement, and humanitarian commitment.

Its position, reflected in the Bangkok Principles, places it in a unique position to contribute to discussions on the future of refugee governance, as the geography of displacement shifts towards the Global South. The 1951 Convention is premised on a timeless principle: People fleeing persecution deserve protection grounded in law. Preserving that needs renewing the commitment that gave birth to it.

Vinai K Singh is an associate professor at JNU, and Jyoti Singh is an advocate based in Delhi and visiting faculty at the Indian Society of International Law. The views expressed are personal

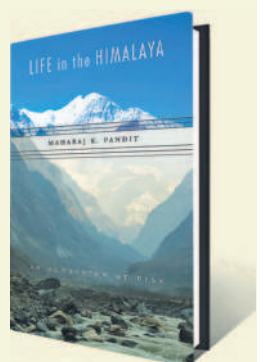
{ EDITOR'S PICK }

HT's editors offer a book recommendation every Saturday, which provides history, context, and helps understand recent news events

TOWERING, FRAGILE MOUNTAINS

The tragic flash flood in Nepal has put the fragility of the Himalayan ecosystem under the spotlight again. For a sharper understanding of this, we recommend academic Maharaj K Pandit's *Life in the Himalaya: An Ecosystem at Risk* (2017).

The book begins with the formation of the mountain range, the youngest in the planet's history. This details how climatic factors got altered as the mountains rose, which, in turn, gave rise to giant glaciers and massive, fast-flowing rivers. Pandit details the course of human settlement — from nomadic pastoralists to today's large towns, with their infrastructure needs — and the pressures this has created on the region. *Life in the Himalaya* looks at the mountains from both an anthropological and ecological lens and contends that rather than sustainable development, the Himalayas need sustainable living; one that doesn't alter or extract from the mountains but focuses on adapting to their topography and environment.



Life in the Himalaya: An Ecosystem at Risk
Maharaj K Pandit
2017

BOOKS

{ ROOPA UNNIKRISHNAN }
AUTHOR, THE JASMINE MURDERS

This is going to be shocking, but the murders in the book are all based on true stories!

On the Books & Authors podcast



{ MAKENNA GOODMAN }
AUTHOR, HELEN OF NOWHERE

'Love is about finding a place of true relating'

The author of the Booker-longlisted novel discusses the absurd nature of her work, and the philosophical questions she was pondering while writing it

Mohammad Farhan
letters@hindustantimes.com

1 The title *Helen of Nowhere* is wonderfully paradoxical. What does "nowhere" mean? This book is about finding a place, learning to know a place, and being rooted close to the land. Helen is a messenger of sorts, or a guide, from a place that seems grounded but is in fact a conceptual space. This "nowhere" can be anything. The Man thinks he is looking for one specific place to call home, but it's the nowhere in himself he must attend to. There are many possible meanings, though, which is the fun of it.

2 The novel is interested in the relationship between love and power. Can love ever be separated from unequal structures of power? I think so. I think love is about finding a place of true relating, where we can face ourselves and each other with kindness, with honesty, and with vulnerability.

3 There are moments when the book seems to move from novel into fable, myth and allegory. Do you think contemporary fiction has become too cautious about crossing such boundaries? We are in a very commercial moment, in publishing, at least in the US; which has to do with a lot of things. But I don't think it means writers are experimenting less. I just think those writers are not spotlight as readily.

4 What philosophical questions were you thinking about most intensely while writing the novel? I have been reading the zen poetry of (the 18th-century Japanese monk) Ryokan, and that is unusually philosophical for its size. I don't know why philosophy has to be synonymous with big, though. It seems to me these are simple questions that have been asked over and over again since the dawn of time, really. What does it mean to live a good life? How do we love? What is justice? How do we forgive

5 Is marriage, in the book, meant to imply the political institution and the emotional one? I wasn't really thinking of marriage as a political institution, any more than I was thinking of it as a structure with its own rules and obligations. I was thinking of it as one possible socially accepted framing device to contain and make sense of love, I guess.

6 Which books accompanied you while you were writing *Helen of Nowhere*?

I always come back to the Greek myths, old fables, stories that have been told and retold for centuries and since ancient times. I am fascinated by how these stories are carried with us. I think of it as a conversation across time. With each book, I turn back to these stories as a foundation, and ask myself: How am I still learning from this? In this new phase of life, how has my interpretation changed?



121st birth anniversary of Major Dhyhan Chand

Probably the greatest field hockey player ever, Major Dhyhan Chand (August 29, 1905–December 3, 1979) captained the Indian team that won gold medals at the Olympic Games of 1928, 1932 and 1936. The 8-1 win against Germany in the 1936 Olympics was especially noteworthy as it came at the height of both Nazism and colonialism, when ideas of eugenics and White supremacy were entrenched. India's highest sports honour, the Major Dhyhan Chand Khel Ratna Award, is named after him. His birthday is celebrated as National Sports Day. At left, Major Dhyhan Chand in action on August 15, 1936, in Berlin.

GETTY IMAGES

A sense of wonder

The Man Who Made Plants Write: Essays by Jagadish Chandra Bose, translated from the Bangla by Sumana Roy, takes the reader on a journey through the scientist's life

Yashodhara Sirur
letters@hindustantimes.com

Is there a child today who has not been told the story of Newton sitting under an apple tree and the discovery of gravity? The story is entrenched in the folklore of science. In *The Man Who Made Plants Write*, Sumana Roy introduces the reader to another such story that deserves to be told just as much to every science student.

Jagadish Chandra Bose (1858-1937) once stepped on a touch-me-not (*Mimosa pudica*) plant. He noticed the folding of its leaves and wondered how and why that response occurred. The touch-me-not was his apple; the impetus that led him to study plant responses and ways of communication.

Roy's masterful translation of Bose's *Abyakta* is similarly captivating. In lyrical prose that retains the local flavour, Roy takes us on a journey through Bose's life, through the medium of his essays.

Her own writing in the book gives the reader a sense not just of Bose, the scientist, but also of Bose, the writer, patriot, poet and thought leader, with her translation capturing the Bengali essence of the original.

Words such as "jhankaar" and sounds like the "thorr thorr" of a tree's rustling leaves are retained, which makes the reader feel closer to the original writing. In the soulful introduction, Roy tells the reader about Bose: his love for Bangla, his childhood education and rise to fame, his dreams and his challenges.

While doing so, it becomes

clear that Roy is invested in the scientist's life and work. Like Bose, she is a "plant-mad parent", as someone once called her. In keeping with Bose's theme of interconnected life, Roy also ruminates on the legacy that childless people leave the world.

Abyakta, literally "the unsaid", is not just a collection of science essays; it is an exploration of the poetic quality of science. Some of these pieces were written for children, some were lectures delivered to a largely lay audience, and one was addressed to the Bengali Sahitya Sammelani, a literature conference. Bose sees music in the surrational of leaves, in sounds that are audible and those that are beyond the human auditory range.

Like Rachel Carson's *A Sense of Wonder* (1965), written 43 years after *Abyakta*, these works seek to sow the seed of awe and love for nature, in the general populace. It is only with love that one can understand the natural world, as Bose says.

"Earlier, when I would go to the fields or mountains by myself, I felt an emptiness," he writes. "I then learned to love plants, trees, birds, worms, and insects. I am able to understand many of their words that I couldn't before. These trees that do not speak—that they have a life, that they eat like us, that they grow with time, I did not know any of this. I understand it now."

The writing is full of interesting analogies: seeds are like a sleeping infant; pollination is a flowering tree that invites its dear friends, the birds and butterflies, over.

He tells us of the special invitation trees extend to nocturnal insects. Since they cannot venture out in the day, he says, the trees release fragrances to guide the insects to the party at night.

The homemaker is not forgotten. While explaining how a zigzag cut is more injurious to a plant than a straight one, he makes a tongue-in-cheek comment about how this may be applied while cutting a koi fish.



The Man Who Made Plants Write: Essays by Jagadish Chandra Bose
Translated by Sumana Roy
136pp, ₹599
HarperCollins

The essays also convey a deep sense of patriotism; exploring a wish to make science accessible to the masses and touching upon the eventual establishment of the Bose Institute in Calcutta.

The scientist recalls instances where he was treated with thinly veiled contempt by colonial peers. Even when he was appreciated, he was often singled out as an outlier in what was viewed as the largely uneducated, uncreative Indian population. His writing serves as vindication against those who have held such views.

His writing shifts the anthropocentric focus of contemporary science too, and turns attention towards plant life. A polymath and a proponent of interdisciplinary science, he set up the Bose Institute as a way for specialists in different disciplines to come together and work towards solving common problems.

Quite contrary to the scientific mindset of the era, he did not shy away from showing his love for his test subjects.

Just as Jane Goodall sought to name the chimpanzees she studied, Bose, in an earlier era, spoke lovingly about his plants and chose to explain the science behind them by using human emotional analogies. This was an unsurprising quirk, considering he was the inventor of the crescograph, an instrument that measured the movements and growth of plants, in ways that metaphorically let plants "write".

Yashodhara Sirur is a part-time writer and full-time IT professional based in Mumbai

{ MEMOIR } A VIEW OF YOUNG INDIA

The poet as a man of action

Deepansh Duggal
letters@hindustantimes.com

What makes a memoir special? It is often the author's experiences: the people they meet and positions they hold, all of which allow readers a rare peek into a life and its times. Occasionally, an individual's life unfolds alongside a nation's defining moments, and their memoir transcends the personal to become a testament to history. Urdu poet, wrestler and bureaucrat Kanwar Mohinder Singh Bedi 'Sahar' *Yaadon Ka Jashn* (1983), ably translated by Kamna Prasad as *A Celebration of Memories*, falls squarely in this category.

The contemporary reader unaware of the radically different world of pre-Independence India could possibly be taken aback that the memoirist was once in charge of a government department titled National War Front, meant to garner the support of Indians for the British during World War 2. How did a pro-peace and anti-war crusader occupy such a position, even if he did use most of his resources to promote Hindu-Muslim unity?

Perhaps memoirs, especially those set in the not-so-distant historical past, are interesting precisely because they challenge our presentism and ideas of chronological snobbery.

A professional administrator, Bedi navigated the worlds of district magistrates and viceroys

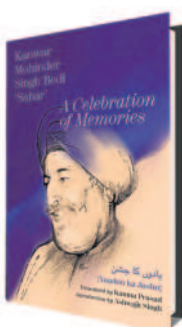
with fragile egos, even as he rubbed shoulders with figures such as Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru.

A secularist who penned evocative *na'ats* or poems in praise of Prophet Mohammad, and made sure the Ramlila was held in Delhi on the very first Diwali after independence, he also ensured that the procession commemorating Guru Tegh Bahadur's martyrdom passed through Old Delhi during namaz time without sparking unrest.

Bedi kept his passion for Urdu poetry alive even as he navigated the labyrinthine corridors of Indian bureaucracy. At mushairas, he disseminated his pro-peace, anti-war and anti-communal ideals, often soothing those looking for an escape from reality in the wake of Partition. He also writes about other prominent personalities who were part of the subcontinent's Urdu poetry circles of the period.

Faiz Ahmed Faiz once wrote a *qasida* (ode) addressed to Bedi, which the latter calls a "masterpiece". Josh Malihabadi and Sahir Hoshniarpuri are remembered fondly. A few others are not. The poet Naqshab never returned money borrowed at Bedi's behest and how the latter chose to deal with this makes for an interesting anecdote. He reminisces too about punching a bus driver who refused to transport refugees during the Partition riots. Then, there's the interesting chapter titled *Eminent Personalities* that focuses on his interactions with mid-20th-century celebrities such as Dilip Kumar, Sunil Dutt, Nargis, Meena Kumari, Muhammad Ali and Mohammad Rafi.

A Celebration of Memories
Kanwar Mohinder Singh Bedi 'Sahar'; Translated by Kamna Prasad
100pp, ₹899
Speaking Tiger



The book, published a year before the assassination of Indira Gandhi, made no mention of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots. However, in his introduction to this English translation, Bedi's grandson Ashwajit Singh writes: "The man who had spent his entire life preaching secularism had to be ridden in the back seat of a car

and smuggled out of his Greater Kailash home to safety... Even champions of *insaaniyat* are not immune to humanity's failures."

The memoir also does not mention Bedi's wife Sohinder Kaur, to whom Singh dedicates a section in the introduction, in an attempt to correct the omission. If Bedi lived in an alternate world writing *shayaris* and *nazms*, Kaur was the practical force in the marriage. This must have been trying at times, especially as Bedi, ever generous, often allowed young, aspiring poets to live in the annexe of his house.

This is a remarkable book. In the end, the reader is left wondering how much worse the horrors of Partition might have been without individuals like Bedi who made such active efforts to foster communal harmony. If his is not a life worthy of a *jashn* — or perhaps several *jashns* — whose is?

Deepansh Duggal writes on art and culture, and is @Deepansh75 on X

{ POETRY PICK }

FLASHBACK OF SHOE-SHOPPING

Somewhere between heaven and the mezzanine is a storage room for shoes. On the ground

floor is where you get your foot measured by an attendant. He calls out its size

so god's helper can send own a rain of shoes. Sometimes daddy leaves home

with an outline of my foot on paper, making me wonder whether putting

foot to page is a sin. I conclude it is a pardonable offence, and imagine

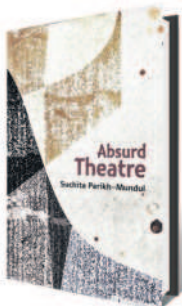
him at the store, passing the footprint to an attendant, the interlude between

earth and sky, the shower of shoes that follows. I imagine the scent

of leather and cardboard, my father bringing back a new pair of shoes,

The joy on his face when they fit me perfectly. I imagine.

— From *Absurd Theatre*, a deeply resonant poetry collection.



Absurd Theatre
Suchita Parikh-Mundul
100pp, ₹399
Paperwall Publishing

{ HT PICKS } NEW READS

THE MODERN-DAY POLITICS OF DISEASE

When the British first arrived in India in 1608, they did not foresee how swiftly deadly tropical diseases would puncture European medical hubris. Ipshtita Nath's *In Sickness and in Death* draws on a vast body of research to examine how disease reshaped colonial policy and altered everyday life across the subcontinent. She also shows how the politics of disease, determined by fear and force, are glaringly present even today, in the post-pandemic era.

In Sickness and in Death: How Faith, Medicine and Race Shaped British India
Ipshtita Nath
409pp, ₹699, HarperCollins

TURNING A FRACTURED CENTURY INTO FORM

Tyeb Mehta is the first comprehensive book devoted to the artist's practice since his death in 2009. One of the defining painters of India's first post-colonial generation, Mehta spent five decades distilling the upheavals he witnessed into a visual language of extraordinary economy. Growing out of a landmark retrospective at the Kiran

Nadar Museum of Art, Delhi, this volume explores his painting, sculpture, and his rarely seen 1970 film *Koodal*, through a range of essays.

Tyeb Mehta: Bearing Weight With the Lightness of Being
Roobina Karode et al
240pp+180 photographs, ₹4,000, Mapin

ontheweb

READ: Wit, tenderness and an unsparing eye are evident in *It Will Come Back to You*, a collection of 13 stories by American writer Sigrid Nunez. About unreliable memory, difficult families and the truths we invent in order to live with ourselves, the past in these pieces is unruly, selective and embarrassingly alive.



Scan the QR code to read the review by Nawaid Anjum



About 50,000 people gathered at the refugee camp at Purana Qila in Delhi, waiting for protected transport to Pakistan, as the city simultaneously struggled to accommodate thousands of others who poured in from the newly formed country in 1947. GETTY IMAGES

RELAX. THE WEEKEND'S HERE brunch



We're in this together

Some couples don't film mushy moments. They chronicle the boring Tuesdays, the chores, the snores. Happily Ever After looks pretty good on Reels, if you know what to share

Shubhangi Bajpai
letters@hindustantimes.com

Love is patient, love is kind. Love will also make you lose your mind. Because no fairy tale or rom-com ever tells you what happily ever after is actually like. What goes on in the day-in-day-out of a relationship, as the dishes pile up in the sink.

Until now. Turns out, short-form video is a great showcase for the long-form adventure of couplehood. Tolstoy was right: Happy couples are really all alike. They can't decide what to eat tonight, put off chores, forget to buy milk, but remember each other's transgressions in ultra-HD detail, and yell "What?" to each other from different rooms until one of them dies.

Filming domesticity is harder than it looks. It calls for recognising what's worth celebrating, worth calling out, and what's worth keeping private. Take a look.

In this together

On Reels, the couple du jour is Paul and Jane from the AI-generated micro-drama @LowBatteryPeople. They've sighed through everything, from digital detoxes and being hangry to meme overloads and waltzing in the kitchen, via 15-second clips. Episode 36 has them both in bed, ready to sleep. "You snore," Paul says. "No, I don't," says Jane. "I recorded it," he says. "Delete it!" she objects. "I can't. I play it when you travel. It helps me sleep." The bit is titled *Weird Things Men Do When They Are In Love*. It has 384K Likes on Insta.

Kriti Vij has been posting videos featuring herself and her husband Viren Barman on @ItsKiviTime since 2022. "We started putting out things that were happening with us in real life," says Vij. Soon, friends, family and followers began to chip in with suggestions for new videos. They've done skits in which he shaves off his beard because she

"doesn't like prickly kisses". One video is from the POV of the phone charger that will inevitably get left behind as they check out of their hotel. In the comments are couples who swear that this is their story too.

Balance of payments

Psychologist Richa Saini, who runs the online platform Wellness With Richa, says content about "shared routines, everyday disagreements, and small acts of care resonate because viewers have often lived versions of them". Audiences feel less alone in their own relationship challenges. Short-form video formats activate that "so us" sense of recognition especially quickly. Gorang Grover and Meru Panwar Grover have been married for five years and chronicle everyday life as @Gorang.Grover and @Meru.Panwar.Grover. Life is "naturally full of chaos, emotion and funny moments," says Grover. "Instead of seeing it as a problem, we see it as content. The only secret is being a good observer, because in a joint family, every day feels like a reality show."

He recalls filming one Reel built around a familiar household joke: The husband who spent so much time in the washroom that, by the time he emerged, his wife had aged, their son had grown up, and was about to get married. "It was such a simple idea, but millions of people related to it," he says. "It taught me that there's no such thing as an ordinary moment. The smallest, everyday situations connect the most because they're real."

The genre is crowded, admits Ninad Nashikkar, the Bengaluru-based creator behind Low Battery People. "A lot of relationship content starts to blur together because everyone is drawing from the same family dynamics." The challenge, he says, is not in identifying a telling moment, but turning it into art. Nashikkar's hack is to avoid using "the obvious take, the moment that feels easy or immediately shareable, because chances are, if it came to us quickly, it's already been done elsewhere." In one recent episode, Paul asks Jane if she still

Content creator Pooja posted about her husband asking for her consent before he put a mangalsutra on her (top), Kriti Vij and husband Viren Barman (above) do skits about his prickly beard and their misaligned sleep schedules. INSTAGRAM/ @LIFE_OF_POOJA, @ITSKIVITIME

gets excited when he comes home. Instead of the expected reassurance, Jane says she gets worried when he doesn't. That flip — the less predictable version of love — is why the show shines.

Spreading the love

Grover, a banker, doesn't believe a relationship ever runs out of stories. "One day, you're learning how to handle each other's anger. Another day, you're learning when to give each other space. The next, you're simply enjoying the little moments together." It means he and his wife don't chase new ideas, they look closer at their own life. "The toughest part is convincing my parents and grandparents to be part of the skits."

The other tough part: To not make love seem cringy or preachy. Nashikkar's goal is to make Paul and Jane's conversations not sound too polished. "It should feel like something you might have actually overheard, rather than something written for effect."

Couplehood content is so popular worldwide that more than a few creators have faked the love. Singaporeans Darshen K and Dr Samuel Choudhury went viral last year for filming videos showcasing the Type A vs Type B dynamic — one spouse does all the travel planning, the other just shows up. In March, they not only revealed that they had parted ways, but hinted that they weren't even a couple, after all.

There's a limit to how much you can connect to a skit, even one about everyday love, Saini says. "Every relationship has two stories: The one you live and the one you post." All content is ultimately shaped for entertainment. And no matter how real the videos aim to be, sometimes, things get too real for Insta. Vij and Barman learnt this the hard way when Barman was confined to bed after a serious back injury in December 2025. It brought their content production to a halt for five weeks. "Real life happens, and there's no way around that," he says. So now, instead of creating content week by week, they bank videos for a contingency. Love Is... after all, knowing what to prioritise on a rainy day.

column { rude food }

Fold it, flip it, beat it

Nearly every country has its own iconic omelette. France keeps it fussy, Koreans do a tornado swirl, Thais crisp theirs. So, how do you like your eggs in the morning?



VIR SANGHVI

Do you know anyone who is not encumbered by some handicap (an allergy to eggs, unthinking vegetarianism etc) who does not love an omelette?

I sure as hell don't.

And because a basic omelette is one of those dishes that tastes good even if you screw up the cooking, it is often the safest dish to order. I remember that Ajmer in the early 1970s was not exactly the gourmet capital of India. But when my friends and I would sneak out of boarding school and look for an escape from dire school food, we would end up at Ajmer Junction railway station. We would head for the restaurant (on Platform 1, if I recall correctly) and order the masala omelette.

Those omelettes have lingered in my memory and made anything that has an omelette in it an instant favourite: Masala omelette sandwiches, Sri Lankan omelette curry and kathi rolls with extra anda.

The thing about a masala omelette is that even if the eggs are industrial and tasteless (which in my school days they were not) the addition of chilli, tomato, and onion makes up for any taste deficiency. But as I was to discover, when I moved beyond Platform 1 and went out into the world, nearly every country has its own classic omelette.

Here are some of my favourites:

The French omelette.

In almost every way, this is the exact opposite of the masala omelette of my childhood. Our omelettes are idiot-proof when it comes to cooking them. A French omelette is one of the most difficult dishes for a chef to master. We rely on chilli, tomatoes etc. A French omelette can have only three ingredients: Eggs, butter and salt.

The making of the dish is extremely difficult because the chef must learn how to control temperature and must master the hand movements integral to its making. The omelette must be soft inside and have a skin that is firm but evenly cooked. If there are brown bits, the chef must throw it out and start again.

In my experience, very few Indian chefs get the technique right.

The Japanese omelette.

They are as difficult to make as French omelettes. The classic tamagoyaki has several layers of egg, and the only version you are likely to see is the simpler fassimile that is used as a topping for nigiri sushi.



There are different variations of omelettes around the world. Japan has omurice (top). In Billions (centre), Chuck Rhoades makes a US country-style omelette, while In The Bear (above), Sydney makes a cheesy one.

Tamagoyaki has a complex umami flavour which comes from the soya sauce and dashi (stock), which are often added along with such optional flavourings as sake and mirin rice wine. The real thing, made properly, is hard to find in India.

The Korean omelette. Korea and Japan have a fraught history so Koreans don't like being told that their omelettes are derived from Japan. While the Japanese focus on the flavour of eggs, Koreans will add seaweed and scallions.

Of particular contention is the Tornado omelette, which has acquired global fame thanks to Instagram videos of the process of making it. You need to keep using chopsticks to twist the egg mixture into a swirling vortex in the pan. The Japanese say that this is a variation on omurice, a Japanese dish of omelette and rice. This is almost certainly unfair to the Koreans, who say they created the swirling technique.

The Thai omelette. The Thais deep fry their omelettes so that they are crisp at the edges. The flavour comes from fish sauce, which may caramelise during cooking and change the colour of the omelette. At Thai restaurants, they like to stuff the omelettes with crab meat, though other flavourings are available (minced pork, for instance).

We shallow-fry Thai omelettes at home and avoid the crab. They taste just as good. **The Spanish omelette.** It's basically an omelette with potatoes. But that may be playing down what the Spanish do with eggs, because their omelettes are essentially egg-and-potato pies that you can eat hot or cold. In many casual restaurants in Spain, the omelette will be kept at the counter and they will cut a slice for you.

It's not easy to create a deep pie (that will hold its shape when cold) on a frying pan, and the first few times you make the omelette, the process of flipping it so that both sides are cooked can be traumatic.

The potatoes cannot be raw and it may take a while to cook them before you even begin to make the omelette. Spanish chef Ferran Adria has suggested that home cooks should just use potato crisps (what the Americans call chips and what we used to call wafers). But this suggestion kicked up a storm in Spain when he made it.

Favourites. I love all omelettes. But honestly, a masala omelette is still my all-time favourite, even if I am not eating it on Platform 1.

The views expressed by the columnist are personal



Kavya and Dhruv from Netflix's *Little Things* (below left) set new live-in love goals. Paul and Jane from @LowBatteryPeople (below right) are an AI-generated couple who sigh through married life. INSTAGRAM/ @LOWBATTERYPEOPLE



This week we're...

Feeling amazed

Is this the collab of the century? Astronomers discovered a massive red star, the size of our solar system, releasing energy the way a black hole does. All those little red dots in space? Maybe this is what they are. Project Hail Mary had its own version, with the stellar energy-consuming astrophage microbes. Someone hide Ryan Gosling!



Claw-struck

What do you do when you're obsessed with cats, but your husband is allergic to them? Sandy Lerner, founder of Urban Decay and Cisco Systems, was forced to be "catless", so she spent 40 years collecting cat memorabilia. Now, her 1,000 artworks, decorative objects, jewellery and collectibles are up for auction. The world is healing.

Foaming hot

A barista at The Craftery, Bengaluru, a Subko outlet, described a customer as "Little fat black shirt" on the bill. What happened next was worse. The brand thought calling themselves out was kinda chic, and put out a multi-slide, humble-brag, ChatGPT-sounding

apology. Bitter aftertaste. Why is this the age of performative regret?

On the pill

So, you hate going to the gym, but want a six-pack? A biotech company is developing a tablet that reduces appetite and weight, while keeping muscle mass intact. Cue intrusive thoughts: What happens if you take two pills? Will you get super jacked? Gym bros are going to lose their whole personality.

Throne for a loop

Clément Vandenkerckhove, a 26-year-old car salesman, just found out that he's a Belgian prince. No Princess Diaries tiara scene or eyebrow-wax makeover. No Julie Andrews to break the news. He was recognised as the son of Prince Laurent (King Philippe's brother)

in a town hall ceremony. Erm, Clément, you're stepping on our fairytale there. This was supposed to be our story.

Still raging

Party on! Luminate's 2026 mid-year report says that electronic music has outgrown every other genre this year, with bangers from Tinashe, FKA twigs and Skrillex. Great news for night-club devotees. Even better news for us. Clubbers can head back to actual raves, leaving us with lo-fi the way Nature intended.



WANT TO READ MORE?

Check out the second page of HT Brunch in the epaper. And dive into stories about life, love, good times and good vibes in the digital magazine, out every Saturday. We're also on hindustantimes.com/lifes-tyle/brunch, and the HT app (it's free!)



READ the e-mag here!



{ RIGHT NOW }

The espresso escape

Indie cafés may be all about the coffee. The real business is coming from solo women, who spend the day working, chilling and racking up a me-time bill

Sneha Krishnan

letters@hindustantimes.com

Pour yourself an oat-milk-aga-ve-matcha-deep-roast-latte and think of how far we've come. India's café scene only took off in the 2000s. Cafés started out as places where we learnt to say Espresso, not EXpresso, and pretend our gang was just like Chandler, Phoebe and the rest. The music was upbeat, the menu and vibe was buzzy. The mugs were gigantic, the sofas arranged for groups of six and more.

All that's changed. Not only is the indie café of today mellow and chill, it's designed for smaller groups and solos. And for much of the day, it's being kept afloat by women.

The women are pretty quiet, so, perhaps you haven't noticed. "This is not the noisy kitty-party crowd that used to pre-order set-lunches for 17 at restaurants," says hospitality-marketing professional Saroj Shah. "These are individual women, quieter groups of three at best, who drop in, bit by bit, during the daylight hours."

In the mornings, while male patrons take their cappuccinos to-go, women are popping in to do a quick Zoom meeting over a green juice, and then settling in—book, laptop, headphones and all—for a day of being unbothered. At lunch, it's girlfriends catching up, ordering half the menu, plus dessert, and lingering on. In the early evening, office-going women walk in, plonk the handbag on the spare seat, and escape rush hour outside with a snack and iced hibiscus tea. By sundown, as men and women fill up the place, no one realises how much business women have already drummed up at the same tables. "Women account for



Cafés now stock cosy-fiction novels. They also serve smaller salad and dessert portions for solo women. Some say 60% of their clients are female. @GREGGSCAFEMUMBAI; SHUTTERSTOCK

approximately 60% of our customer base," says Vandita Purohit, founder of Maui - The Time Café in Pune and Nagpur. In response, cafés are adapting to women too.

Corner office

It's no surprise that women are finding everyday refuge in a café. It's comfy, cheaper than a restaurant and better lit than a bar, with quiet corners to disappear into. The staff don't bother patrons, and the menu goes from sugar-free-dairy-free beverages to full-blown dessert. And it has what few third spaces have: Wi-Fi and a clean toilet.

"For a woman running a small business, working remotely, or even looking to unwind, the home isn't always the best place to get work done," points out Shah. "Regardless of whether she is married or single, there's always some domestic duty that needs doing, someone interrupting a thought, even a doorbell ringing. So, merely having a place close to home or the office, where a woman can now sit undisturbed for a long time, is largely the appeal."

Psycho-oncologist Chaitanya Agrawal, 26, says her local café is where she can have a slow, grounding session with herself after work. "I'm there almost every day!" She usually gets a coffee with a "small bite on the side" and doodles in her mini sketchbook until the order arrives. "Even when I'm done, I stay for two to three hours." It's the only chunk of the day when she feels truly free of her responsibilities.

Post-pandemic-era cafés have been leaning into that fuzzy-not-buzzy vibe. When Shah meets clients looking to open a café, she informs them that a large part of their daytime, weekday revenue will come from this quiet stream of women customers. "They're always surprised," she says. "I have to explain that this is a demographic that has more control over their money than ever before, wants to be seduced by a new item on the menu, won't make a racket, and won't leave a mess behind. Why wouldn't you want their business?"

So, while cafés have started stocking their bookshelves

with cosy-fiction titles, Shah gets them to go a step further. "The old formula to attract women customers was to 'make it pink'—pink suitcases, pink razors, pink laptops. Women never wanted pink things! What they do want, she says, are solo seats, low-sugar drinks, more fresh-ingredient salads on the menu, smaller dessert portions ("We need mini pastries in these places"), drinks that arrive frothy and pretty, for sipping, not chugging down. "And staff that is trained to greet women but not make unnecessary eye contact after that".

At the Maui Time cafés, "the first-half of weekdays, when we see a large number of women working or studying from our café," says Purohit. Her focus is on making sure the washrooms are always clean and training the staff to stay approachable but not heavy-handed on service. There's no pressure to upsell or order more during that time.

Agrawal recalls that one evening, after a difficult day at work, she walked into her regular café on the verge of tears, knowing that she wouldn't be disturbed. A staff member came over with a cookie and a note that read: "We all have bad days; we got you. Here's a treat from us."

Shah says that the obsession over artisanal roasts, local beans and coffee-extracting techniques are what make a café stand out in an increasingly crowded market. But the daytime crowd simply wants a place where "the coffee is decent but they really came for the vibe". They don't want to hear machines that grind beans noisily or to place a beverage order that requires too much decision-making.

The best sign that a café's formula is working: When one woman shares her safe space with another woman. "One of our regulars brought her daughter, who was visiting, to Maui, simply to show her the place she spends time as she likes," recalls Purohit. "She called it a 'home away from home' and said 'there's so much sukoon (peace) here.'"



{ PLAYBOOK }

Inspect your gadgets

From cables to dead phones and mystery chargers, here's what to keep, what to chuck and what to wipe when decluttering your tech drawer

Tanisha Saxena

letters@hindustantimes.com

Every home has one drawer we never want to open. It's got everything. The Nokia 3110, saved as a reminder of a more innocent time. One earbud—the other one went out in the lockdown and never came back. A nest of cables tangled more tightly than the Kardashians. USB A, USB B pins and their mini versions. The cover of the smart coffee cup you swear you haven't lost, just misplaced. And a charger, but to charge what? Maybe even a CD gleaming dully under it all.

What stays, what goes, what deserves a second life and what's still tracking you? We asked experts.

Pick the survivors. Amogh Deshmukh, assistant professor and assistant dean of student affairs at Woxsen University's School of Technology in Hyderabad, says that decluttering tech junk is no different from other parts of the home. "Spread everything out where you can see it, then sort it into categories. First, find the drives and memory cards. That is where the data lives." Store them where you keep your documents.

For cables and cords, Deshmukh applies the match test. "Pick up each one and find the device in your home that it powers or connects. If you cannot find it in under a minute, the cable has no reason to stay. Keep only one spare of the connectors you use—USB-C, lightning, HDMI—and let the rest go. Also check every charger for a fraying cable or a missing brand marking; those are fire risks, not backups. Label the items "iPhone charger," "office laptop charger," "old Bluetooth speaker cable," "spare HDMI" so future-you can locate it faster.

As for the rest, "figure out



Wireless earbuds (top) are among the least repair-friendly gadgets. Keep only one spare of the connectors you use—USB-C, lightning, HDMI—and let the rest go (above). Smartwatches (centre) may contain records of your sleep cycles, daily routes and addresses.

what still works," says Varun Bapna, VP of Amkette and founder of EvoFox. Most devices fall into one of three categories: Working, needs repairs, beyond hope. Rechargeable batteries for instance, may look dead, but can be revived when you "connect it to its original charger for 12 to 24 hours." Abhishek Maheshwari, CEO, OneAsist says that even if a device refuses to turn on, inspect it for visible damage: Swollen battery, corrosion, cracked display, broken hinges and damp. "It helps you decide what's not worth keeping, regardless of how much you once paid for it."

Ask this one question. People obsess over how old a gadget is. Bapna says they're asking the wrong question. Instead, ask: Will I use this in the next year? If not, could someone else use it? In India, many electronics get a second life because they get passed on to parents, siblings, cousins, or household staff. If nobody wants it, consider selling it while it still has value.

Pool in the data. Smartwatches, fitness bands, Wi-Fi cameras and smart speakers contain records of your heart rate, sleep patterns, daily routes and home address. "Back up the files you want," says Bapna. "Sign out of every account. Remove the device from your Apple, Google or Microsoft account. Take out the SIM card and memory card. Disable activation locks such as Find My iPhone before performing a factory reset." For older laptops, external hard drives and pen drives, use secure data-wiping software that overwrites the storage so it carries no traces of you when it leaves.

"Every connected device leaves two footprints: one on the device, and one in the cloud account it is paired with," says Deshmukh. "Cleaning the device is only half the job. Before passing on any smart gadget, unpair it from your phone, remove it from the companion app, and delete it from your account on the manufacturer's platform."

For cameras and speakers, also delete stored recordings and voice history from the cloud dashboard, and change your Wi-Fi password if the device knew it. A smart camera that is still registered to your account can, in the wrong hands, remain a window into your home long after it has left it.

Get calculating. Smartwatches and wireless earbuds are among the least repair-friendly. "If repair costs less than about 25% of the device's current market value, it's usually worth it, especially for common fixes such as battery replacements, charging ports, cracked screens, back panels, laptop RAM upgrades or cooling-system cleaning," says Maheshwari.

Remember that electronic devices, cables and chargers are all e-waste. Pass them on to an authorised recycler. Don't toss them into the trash.



{ LISTICLE }

So good at being bad

These 10 characters lie, manipulate and cheat to get what they want. And yet, somehow, we're always on their side

Arshia

letters@hindustantimes.com

The Coin (2024) by Yasmin Zaher

The unnamed narrator is a wealthy Palestinian in New York, trapped in compulsive rituals of cleanliness and control. This could have been quirky, but Zaher writes her as deliciously dubious. She sees the poor as "dirty," is transactional in relationships, neglects her underprivileged students while manipulating them into adopting her ideology. She gets into an illicit Birkin resale scheme! A hoarder with a cleanliness fetish, who never gets off her high horse. What's there to hate?

All Fours (2024) by Miranda July

The voice of the LA-based story is a 45-year-old artist, searching for freedom, but somehow desperate to deceive everyone around her. She abandons a cross-country solo road trip within minutes of setting off, and instead spends weeks secretly living a parallel life in a motel. Her husband and child know nothing, not even that she's obsessing over a younger married man working at the

motel. These aren't acts of self-discovery, they're just indulgence. But we're here for the ride.

Victim (2024) by Andrew Boryga

Javier "Javi" Perez is a Puerto Rican writer from the Bronx who learns to game the system by manufacturing stories of suffering, knowing that society rewards them. After a guidance counsellor encourages him to play up his father's murder in his college essay, Javi begins embellishing his life. He accuses campus police of racial profiling. His hot buttons are racism, poverty, and discrimination. You're not meant to like Javi, but he seduces you with his wicked charm. Who's the Victim of the title, really?

Creation Lake (2024) by Rachel Kushner

Spy fiction is fertile ground for thought experiments. And Kushner paints 34-year-

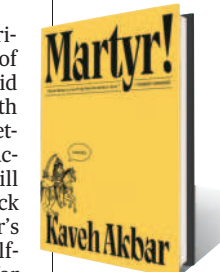
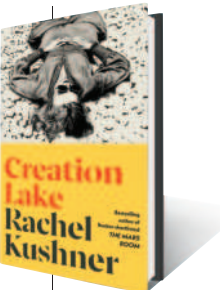
old former FBI agent, now freelance spy Sadie Smith (an alias) especially murky. Smith infiltrates a commune of suspected eco-terrorists in rural France for information and reports, preying on their vulnerabilities. They turn out to be just environmentalists. So, she plants false evidence, navigating her only through deception to come out as professional. The makings of a baddie, right there.

Liars (2024) by Sarah Manguso

Jane, a writer witnessing the collapse of her 14-year-old marriage to a filmmaker, isn't conventionally unlikeable. She went in expecting an equal creative partnership, she says. She ended up cushioning his professional failures, by pushing her own work and identity into oblivion. Jane is largely living in her head (taking us with her) and it feels like a torture chamber. Every compromise is recounted, every resentment logged with forensic precision. We hear no other side of the story—which is why it's so us.

Martyr! (2024) by Kaveh Akbar

Meet Cyrus Shams, 27, an Iranian-American poet who is newly sober after years of addiction. He luxuriates in misery to avoid accountability. He fills reams of pages with notes on secular martyrs, attends AA meetings only to argue over the meaning of sacrifice, and travels to meet a terminally ill Iranian artist in the hope that it may unlock the mystery of his mother's death. Akbar's genius lies in how he grants Cyrus self-awareness, wit, and an earnest longing for



connection. He's unlikely to mend his ways. We root for him still.

Audition (2025) by Katie Kitamura

Follow an unnamed actress, who convinces us that she knows exactly who she is, until a young man named Xavier insists he is her son. We see the world through her eyes, while she remains an opaque wall of uncertainty. She continues meeting him without resolving whether he is telling the truth, dragging her marriage, memories, and sense of self along with her. Kitamura presents her as someone who takes on her reality as a role. How else to create drama from life?

Murder Bimbo (2026) by Rebecca Novack

We never know her name. We only know her as a 32-year-old queer sex-worker who has just killed a far-right politician. She first emails a feminist podcast introducing herself as Murder Bimbo, convincing them that she was acting on behalf of undercover agents. But to an ex, she recasts the same tale as not the victim, but a calculating participant. There are more versions, more revisions. Don't

trust her. But hear her out. The true story underneath it all is how women, sex workers and killers are consumed as stories.

The Wrong Way Home (2026) by Shunali Khullar Shroff

Nayanara is that sly social climber we've all met, but can't ignore because they are so much fun. The 40-year-old PR professional is blindsided when her celebrity ex-husband marries a younger influencer barely a year after their divorce. She's broke, humiliated, desperate to matter again. The thing that makes Nayan's story unputdownable is how much she reminds us of us, almost guiltily so, at our worst. She is vain and judgemental but Khullar-Shroff redeems her with humour and bullishness. You can't hate her.

Flesh (2025) by David Szalay

It's easy to lose patience with István, who was only 15 when he entered into a sexual relationship with a 42-year-old married neighbour. It culminated in violence. He's now in juvenile detention, all set to grow up to be another emotionally unavailable man, unwilling to heal from trauma. He enlists in the military, works as a nightclub bouncer, and later as a chauffeur to a billionaire. He enters an elite world where he can never belong. It's maddening, and yet, you hope against hope that he finally finds himself.



SONIA GANDHI MEMOIR

distribute the book in India. Harper Collins declined comment for this story.

One of Gandhi's aides told HT about some of the sections that PRHI wanted removed. Primary among them were her recollections and observations about her meetings with Modi. The aide confirmed that she has gone into details about his comments about her and cited one calling her a "Jersey cow" at a public rally in Gujarat in 2004.

"She has had a long career in politics, and therefore her memoir is expansive. She has certainly given her impressions of the Prime Minister and details of what happened when they met," said the aide. "As a politician, she mentions how this issue was handled, but the publisher had problems with it."

PRHI initially objected to several passages, according to this person, but the book deal finally broke down over three or four crucial passages which Gandhi refused to alter or remove.

HT learns that Gandhi compares Modi to other prime ministers in the memoir. It is unclear exactly what Gandhi is reported to have written on the RSS.

PRHI issued a statement, maintaining that any suggestion that it decided not to publish the memoir because Gandhi declined editorial changes does not accurately reflect the circumstances.

"As a publisher, it is both our prerogative and our responsibility to fact-check and provide authors with recommendations that are in the best interests of their books. This is a normal part of the publishing process. Throughout the relevant discussions, Penguin Random House India's position was that we remained willing and keen to publish the book."

The Congress dismissed the statement. "If Penguin worldwide has published, then... [PRHI] claim of fact-checking is ridiculous," said the aide cited above.

Independent literary agents handled the memoir, and most Congress leaders are unaware of the full contents.

PRHI objected to Gandhi's references to the India-China relationship and intrusions into Indian territory, according to the aide.

Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi, the leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha, have been demanding the government come clean on the situation at the Line of Actual Control with China. They have accused the government of making false claims.

In February, much of Parliament's budget session was disrupted over former army chief General MM Naravane's unpublished memoir, which PRHI commissioned. The book was printed, e-commerce sites were taking pre-orders for it, when it was abruptly withdrawn citing the fact that Naravane had not sought clearance for it.

Opposition parties disrupted the House, demanding that Rahul Gandhi be allowed to speak about it. Speaker Om Birla did not allow Gandhi to refer to an article about the Naravane memoir, citing rules. Senior ministers also opposed it.

The impasse started when Rahul Gandhi wanted to refer to a magazine article with excerpts from Naravane's unpublished memoir. Outside the House, Gandhi carried a copy of Naravane's book and said he would present it to Modi if the PM came to Parliament.

He maintained that the "book clearly states that when the Chinese army had entered our border, in such a critical moment, the Army Chief was made to wait. And when the time came to take a decision, the Prime Minister simply said - 'Do whatever you think is appropriate'."

Gandhi alleged that Naravane wrote that he felt the political leadership had "left the army alone."

Congress leader Gaurav Gogoi criticised PRHI's state-

ment on Sonia Gandhi's memoir, calling it weak. "Penguin India is more than happy to publish 'Exam Warriors' and several books on RSS. No doubt there are those in the BJP government who have now become afraid of a book being...read by the people of India," Gogoi said on X. Exam Warriors, authored by Modi is an extension of the Prime Minister's programme called Par-eksha pe Charcha. It is a compilation of his advice to students taking exams about how to deal with stress.

NEPAL FLOODS

The deluge of ice and mud also caused huge lakes to form, with one of these formations becoming a direct threat to emergency workers scouring the region for survivors.

Nepali police urged all rescuers

to "immediately move to a safe location", saying it had received information that "a water dam has burst again on the Tibetan side". Separately in Tibet, China had earlier Friday paused its rescue operation at the hardest-hit area of Gyirong over the risk of renewed flooding, before later saying the threat had eased.

State broadcaster CCTV reported that a lake formed by immense piles of debris began overflowing toward where rescue teams were headed, but later said the water level of the pool was dropping so the "the risk is gradually decreasing".

Rescue operations were therefore "proceeding in an orderly manner", it added.

Chinese President Xi Jinping, who chaired a meeting on rescue efforts Friday, offered Beijing's help to Nepal's emergency operations.

Tunnel rescue operation

Emergency teams had been racing to retrieve survivors from affected zones, where the widespread devastation meant food and water supplies were running out.

The Nepali military had meanwhile located people trapped in the tunnel of Trishuli 3A hydropower project, where they were working to find a way in to extract the survivors.

"Two helicopters have been dispatched but it is challenging because it is tough to even locate the entry points of the tunnel," army spokesman Raja Ram Basnet told AFP.

Some 350 workers and residents have been brought to safety from the site, he added, but efforts were ongoing to rescue more than 100 people trapped in the same area.

Workers rescued from other

dam projects along the Trishuli valley described a disaster that unfolded with terrifying speed.

Buddha Tamang told AFP he survived only because he was inside a tunnel at the dam where he worked when the flood struck.

"I survived as I was in the tunnel," said Tamang, who was airlifted on Thursday after being marooned for more than 24 hours. "The senior officers working on the other side, they were all swept away," he told AFP.

Washed away

Survivors in a makeshift Nepali hospital endured an agonising wait for news of their missing loved ones.

Kula Priya, whose eldest son is missing, said she had lost everything when the wave of mud and water swept in.

"I don't care for wealth. I just want my son back. If any of you could rescue my son, please do it for me," she told AFP.

Nepal reported a death toll of 579 people on Friday.

In India, authorities said they had recovered seven bodies from rivers flowing from Nepal, believed to be flood victims.

There are 1,924 people, including 517 foreigners, who are out of contact in Nepal, the disaster authority said. The previous missing figure was 977.

Across the border in Tibet, which is largely inaccessible to foreign journalists and where the only sources of information are Chinese authorities -- officials say 558 people are missing and five died.

Authorities also said they had evacuated 555 stranded tourists and 499 Chinese residents from Tibet.

Prez clears rule for J&K high court bench in Ladakh

LEH/JAMMU: President Droupadi Murmu on August 27 promulgated a regulation establishing a bench of the Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court in the Union territory of Ladakh. The move addresses a long-standing demand for improved access to higher judicial remedies.

The Union Cabinet had approved the proposal on August 20.

K'taka Youth Cong files plaint against 'Jhoot ki Goonj'

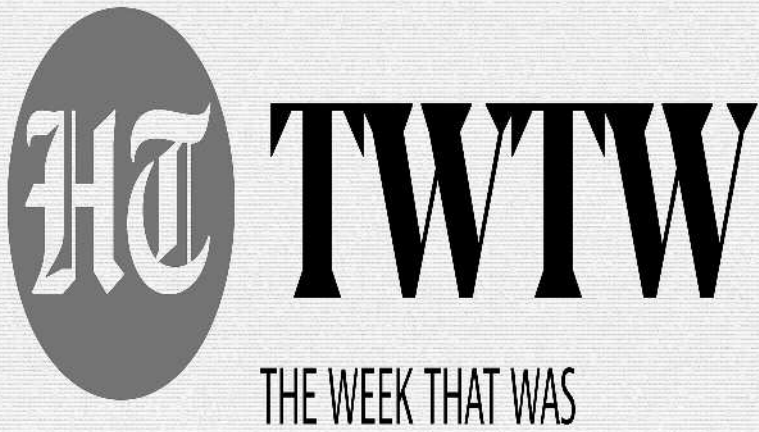
BENGALURU: The Youth Congress' legal cell in Karnataka has filed a police complaint against "Jhooth ki Goonj" and two X handles for circulating false stories against Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Instagram. The complaint says that two X handles falsely claimed that Gandhi promoted a story of "Jhooth ki Goonj" on Instagram.

AMU student dies by suicide in pvt PG in Aligarh

AGRA: A 19-year-old second-year French language student at Aligarh Muslim University allegedly died by suicide in his room at a private paying guest accommodation in Aligarh early on Friday, officials said. Police said a suicide note was recovered. According to police, the note mentioned a family-related issue, which appears to be the reason behind the suicide.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of



A quiz on the week's development.



‘State terrorism’: Iran slams new US economic sanctions

Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

DUBAI: Iran condemned the United States’ new economic sanctions on Friday as “state terrorism” and said other countries were legally obliged not to implement them, while the US Treasury Department announced additional targeted Iran-related measures.

The Iranian foreign ministry’s statement came as mediators stepped up efforts to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, which handled 20% of world oil supplies before the war began six months ago and whose status remains the biggest obstacle to a peace deal.

President Donald Trump’s administration on Monday warned countries to cut their business ties with Iran or face secondary sanctions as part of what it billed as an “economic D-Day”, though the Treasury Department stopped short of actually imposing penalties.

Trump reiterated on Thursday that the US was not talking with Iran, while the White House said Washington’s economic campaign would continue until Tehran decided to “come to the table in a meaningful way”.

Iran’s foreign ministry said in a statement on Friday that all countries were obligated under international law to refrain from implementing US sanctions against Tehran, adding that participation in them amounted to complicity in imposing one state’s unlawful will on independent states. It branded the new US measures a “crime against humanity” that put the health and livelihood of millions of civilians at serious risk, and called on other nations and United Nations bodies to uphold the rule of law.

Egypt bank targeted
Later on Friday, a US official told Reuters the Trump administration plans to impose limits on Egypt’s Banque Misr for doing business with Tehran by revoking US financial access to its branches

in the United Arab Emirates.

The official said the proposed rule, if finalised, would withdraw Banque Misr UAE’s correspondent banking access to US financial institutions.

Treasury officials separately issued sanctions targeting one entity based in Hong Kong and one person linked to Iran’s Bank Mellat, according to a notice posted on the department’s website.

With the US focused on its economic pressure campaign, others have sought to revive diplomatic efforts to end the war.

Qatari Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani said he had stressed during talks with Iranian leaders in Tehran on Thursday the importance of returning to the pre-war status of open shipping through the Strait of Hormuz.

‘Pressure doesn’t work’
Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araqchi on Friday described the talks with Al Thani as “creative”, and he renewed his appeal to the US to stop putting military and economic pressure on his country and to resume negotiations.

“Putting diplomacy back on track isn’t impossible. It hinges on US understanding of one simple fact: pressure doesn’t work,” Araqchi said on X.

Qatar, a US ally, and Pakistan helped broker a memorandum of understanding in June that led to a ceasefire but that quickly unravelled due to disagreements between Iran and the US over the Strait of Hormuz.

Iranian leverage

After the US and Israel launched the war on February 28, Iran threatened to strike any vessel transiting the strait without its authorisation, driving down traffic and sending up the price of oil, providing Tehran with leverage in the bargain.

Mohsen Rezaei, secretary of Iran’s Supreme National Security Council, said on Thursday Iran was preparing a list of conditions for reopening the strait.



The US is dispatching aircraft carrier USS Theodore Roosevelt (in picture) to relieve USS George Washington, which was deployed from Japan and arrived in West Asia last week. REUTERS

LNG price rises as Qatar extends force majeure

DOHA: Asian spot liquefied natural gas (LNG) advanced on sustained concerns about the Strait of Hormuz, with Qatar extending force majeure on deliveries of the fuel to European and Asian buyers by another month.

Spot prices rose to \$23.388 per million British thermal units, according to traders. State-owned QatarEnergy this week notified Pakistani buyers that LNG cargo cancellations will continue into October, traders familiar with the matter said.

Force majeure on supplies to Bangladesh has also been extended beyond September, they said.

Italy’s Edison SpA, one of QatarEnergy’s customers, said that cancellations were extended into early November. Other traders in Europe have also started receiving notices, according to two other people aware of the development.

Elsewhere, Indian importers recently purchased some spot cargoes. Bharat Petroleum and

Hindustan Petroleum bought a shipment for September delivery to India at the low-\$23/mmbtu level.

Qatar has largely halted LNG shipments through Hormuz since two vessels carrying its fuel were attacked in July.

Qatar has been more cautious on sending cargoes through Hormuz because LNG carriers are scarcer and more valuable than oil tankers, said Masanori Odaka, an analyst at Rystad Energy. “Going dark or running high-risk transits with those ships is a bigger capital and safety bet than doing the same with oil tanker,” Odaka said. “Oil can be shuttled and transferred; Qatar LNG still cannot, at scale.”

The squeeze has pushed LNG prices in Europe and Asia to nearly double the prewar levels

Qatar has been operating its Ras Laffan facility at reduced rates after it was attacked and shut in March. The plant is kept ready to ramp up output rapidly if Hormuz reopens. BLOOMBERG



China removes 2 officers from key military body

BEIJING: China removed two high-ranking officers from the country’s main military body [Central Military Commission] on Friday, state media reported, seven months after it was announced that Zhang Youxia and Liu Zhenli were being investigated for “serious violations of the law”. AFP

Trump admin’s ban on Anthropic unlawful: Judge

SAN FRANCISCO: A US federal judge ruled on Thursday that sanctions imposed by the Trump administration against AI giant Anthropic were illegal, finding that the government punished the company in a row over military use of its technology. AFP

Judge: No block on new birthright citizenship order

MARYLAND: Deborah Boardman, a federal judge on Friday declined to immediately block US President Donald Trump’s newest executive order limiting the number of people eligible for birthright citizenship, even as she questioned its viability after the US top court rejected his previous effort to do so. REUTERS

Tate brothers to remain in US jail pending ruling

MIAMI: Social media influencers Andrew and Tristan Tate will remain in a Miami jail for now as they contest extradition to Britain, where they are wanted on rape charges. REUTERS

WH reviews rule to end 60-day grace period for foreign workers

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: The White House (WH) has completed its review of the proposal to eliminate the 60-day grace period that allowed foreign workers, mostly on H-1-B visas, to search for new jobs after loss of employment.

The proposal was moved by the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) for review by the Office of Management and Budget earlier this month and details were not immediately available.

If finalised, the proposed regulation would eliminate the 60-day grace period accorded to certain principal non-immigrants and their dependants if the principal’s employment ceases before their period of stay expires.

THE RULE APPLIES TO E-1, E-2, E-3, H-1B, H-1BI, L-1, O-1 AND TN CATEGORIES OF VISA HOLDERS AND THEIR DEPENDANTS

The next step for the proposal is publication in the Federal Register with a public comment period, which is usually 30 to 60 days. The specific content of the rule will not be known until publication.

The 60-day grace period was introduced in 2017 to allow foreign workers and their dependants to stay in the US while searching for new employment

after a job loss. Immigration consultants said the DHS has the discretion to shorten or refuse the grace period, but has rarely done so. The grace period also allows US employers to more easily facilitate employment changes for existing or newly recruited non-immigrant workers. If the 60-day grace period is eliminated, foreign nationals whose employment ceases prematurely and their dependants would be required to depart the US immediately.

They would be unable to change status or employers within the US unless US Citizenship and Immigration Services exercises its discretion to forgive the lapse in status. Indians are among the largest beneficiaries of H-1B visas, comprising 71% of all successful applicants in 2024.

Norwegians mourn death of King Harald

OSLO: Thousands of people gathered outside Norway’s royal palace to pay their respects to King Harald, who died on Friday aged 89 after a reign of three and a half decades. Harald’s 53-year-old son immediately succeeded him on the throne, announcing he would reign under the name King Haakon VIII.

Haakon takes over a monarchy long hailed for its modernity and modesty, but beset by a string of scandals in recent years.

The new king arrived at the palace with his 22-year-old daughter Ingrid Alexandra — the new crown princess — to formally inform the government of his father’s death. In a statement, Haakon thanked “the government and Norwegian people for their support and sympathy for the Royal Family in this time”.

“An era has ended. A new one begins. The king is dead. Long live the king,” Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre said in a speech shortly after meeting the new monarch.

“We will remember King Harald for his love for his people, for his humour and warmth, and for



King Harald

his unwavering faith in us,” he said.

Europe’s oldest reigning monarch, King Harald had been in hospital in Oslo since August 17, suffering from haemolytic anaemia, a condition caused by an abnormally rapid destruction of red blood cells that leads to fatigue and shortness of breath.

Store said Harald, who ascended to the throne in 1991, was “a king of his time and for his time,” noting that he accompanied Norway through decades of enormous change during which the country “grew richer, we became more numerous, and we became more diverse”. AFP

PML-N’s IFTIKHAR GILLANI ELECTED AS PoK PREMIER

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

ISLAMABAD: Barrister Iftikhar Ali Gillani was on Friday elected to the so-called post of prime minister of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) following recent elections marred by violent protests and allegations of massive rigging.

Gillani, of the ruling Pakistan Muslim League Nawaz (PML-N), secured 30 of the 44 votes in the so-called legislative assembly during its session in Muzaffarabad, the region’s capital. His challenger, Mukhtar Ahmed of the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP), secured 14 votes.

The assembly comprises 53 members, but its present strength is 46 because elections for seven seats in Poonch and Sudhnoti districts have yet to be held due to what authorities described as a law and order situation. PML-N supremo Nawaz Sharif on Thursday nominated Gillani for the so-called post of prime minister.

The polls were held on July 27, August 2 and August 3.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn’t know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you’ve turned the page.



READ EVERY SUNDAY



Infra to get financing boost

Harsh Kumar

harsh.kumar@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: The finance ministry is drafting a new financing framework to help turn more projects into bankable ventures and widen the pool of funding beyond banks, as India faces an investment requirement of about ₹150 trillion till fiscal year 2031, according to three people aware of the development.

The framework, being prepared in coordination with the department of economic affairs (DEA) and department of financial services (DFS), will seek to accelerate projects from announcement to financial closure by identifying projects with greater economic and strategic relevance, speeding up environmental clearances, and standardizing detailed project reports (DPRs), the people said on condition of anonymity.

"A centre of excellence is proposed to develop standardized DPR templates and strengthen internal underwriting capabilities," one of the people said.

Progress will be tracked by the number and value of projects identified, shortlisted, and prioritized, and by how quickly prioritized projects move from clearance to financial closure. The framework also proposes moni-



The new financing framework aims to help India meet an investment requirement of about ₹150 trillion till FY31. AFP

toring the centre of excellence's role in strengthening underwriting capacity and improving closure rates.

The framework also seeks to deepen debt markets through credit enhancement for investment-grade critical projects, greater participation by institutional investors, and a unified request-for-quote (RFQ) mechanism to improve price discovery, a second person said.

Key indicators include the volume of credit-enhanced debt and ratings uplift achieved; capital mobilized from institutional investors such as provident funds, insurers, and the employees' provident fund organisation (EPFO); and transaction volumes

through the RFQ mechanism, a third person added.

According to the government document, India's average annual capex requirement could be around ₹30 trillion during FY27-31, implying cumulative investment of roughly ₹150 trillion over the five-year period. After accounting for internal accruals and budgetary support, about ₹50 trillion would be required to finance capital expenditure, while working-capital requirements would add another ₹35 trillion, taking the total external funding requirement to around ₹85 trillion.

Banks are expected to fund nearly ₹60 trillion, or about 70%, of this external requirement,

according to the government document reviewed by *Mint*. The government is therefore looking to supplement bank financing with a broader funding base, particularly for infrastructure and industrial projects with long gestation periods.

Queries emailed to the department of financial services, department of economic affairs, PMO, Niti Aayog, Sebi, IIFCL, NaBFID, and the finance ministry went unanswered.

The push to broaden the financing mix comes against the backdrop of sluggish private-sector investment, while the government continues to drive capital expenditure. The Centre has budgeted ₹12.22 trillion for capital expenditure in FY27, up from ₹11.21 trillion in the FY26 Budget estimate. "The focus on standardized DPRs and faster clearances can create a stronger pipeline of bankable projects and is as critical as the focus on financing," said Kanika Pasricha, chief economic advisor at Union Bank of India. "This should help accelerate financial closure and effectively crowd in private capital," Pasricha said. "Together, these measures can provide a strong impetus to India's next investment cycle, with green shoots already underway in various emerging sectors."

India, Canada to initiate investment treaty talks

Anirudh Bhattacharyya

letters@hindustantimes.com

TORONTO: India has expressed its readiness to initiate negotiations towards a bilateral investment treaty with Canada, according to a joint statement issued after the first Economic and Financial Dialogue between the two countries.

The statement was issued following the bilateral meeting between finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman and her Canadian counterpart François-Philippe Champagne in Toronto on Thursday morning.

It noted that the meeting reflected the "shared commitment" of the two countries to "deepen economic ties, including through enhanced trade and investment, and to deliver tangible outcomes that support economic growth and expand commercial opportunities in both countries."

They also discussed the mutual benefits of further strengthening bilateral economic and investment ties, to support financial and commercial linkages between India and Canada and support the "shared aspiration" of Prime Ministers Narendra Modi and Mark Car-



FM Nirmala Sitharaman at the Canadian Club in Toronto. AP

ney to expand trade to CAD 70 billion/₹4.65 lakh crore by 2030, through a comprehensive economic partnership agreement or CEPA. Negotiators are in an advanced stage in talks over the pact, which the PMs want concluded by the end of this year.

Sitharaman was in favour of discussions towards the foreign investment protection agreement being concluded at around the same time, as she announced during an event in Toronto on Tuesday.

Much of their discussion occurred through the prism of trade and tariff disruption the world is encountering, precipitated by recent action of the

administration of US President Donald Trump and the crisis in West Asia. As Sitharaman pointed out in a press conference after the Dialogue, "The world is going through a profound transformation, there's just a lot of uncertainty everywhere and the geopolitical and economic realities are constantly evolving. So in this background, closer economic cooperation has become increasingly important to build resilient, sustainable and inclusive economies both in Canada and in India."

After the Dialogue, the ministers participated in a discussion at the Canadian Club Toronto, moderated by Canada-India Business Council president and CEO Victor Thomas. They then jointly engaged with key representatives from Canada's financial services, FinTech, technology, artificial intelligence, infrastructure, and energy and natural resources sectors. "These engagements highlighted shared priorities and opportunities for fostering long-term growth and expanding collaboration among businesses, financial institutions and other stakeholders in both countries," the statement said.



PM Narendra Modi. PTI

PM MODI LAUDS JAN DHAN AS ACCOUNTS HIT 590 MN MARK

Rajeev Jayaswal

rajeev.jayaswal@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday lauded the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) for its "unprecedented scale and transformative outcomes" achieving 590 million bank accounts in the last 12 years with deposits of ₹3.16 lakh crore.

"Jan Dhan Yojana has had an unparalleled impact," he said in a post on X, pointing at rapid financial inclusion because of the scheme. According to the latest government data, about 78% of Jan Dhan accounts are in rural and semi urban areas, and 56% of the account holders are women. PMJDY was launched on August 28, 2014.

Highlighting growing participation in formal banking, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said PMJDY has brought transformation from "banking the few to banking for all". PMJDY has brought banking closer to the people, opening doors to opportunity, security and economic empowerment, she said.

Growing deposits in Jan Dhan accounts reflect more than increasing balances. They point to greater engagement with formal banking, stronger saving habits and growing financial participation among beneficiaries across the country, the finance ministry said.

PMJDY ensures that every unbanked adult has access to a basic bank account with zero balance requirements and no maintenance charges. Each account comes with a free RuPay debit card, offering an accident insurance cover of ₹2 lakh, encouraging digital transactions and financial security.

Fortnightly sugar quotas from September to check hoarding

Pallavi Singhal

pallavi.singhal@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The government on Friday announced the replacement of the monthly sugar quota system with a fortnightly mechanism from September, as it attempts to tighten its monitoring of supplies and direct mills to release their allocated stock in two tranches to prevent hoarding and artificial shortages amid the recent rise in prices.

Under the new system, mills will have to sell at least 40% of

their allocated sugar quota in the first week and release the remaining quantity in the following week. Sugar sold by mills will also have to be dispatched within seven days, a move aimed at preventing mills from withholding supplies after making sales, according to an expert.

"The recent surge in ex factory sugar prices was driven by several mills releasing small quantities at one level and holding back for higher bids at the next. The new fortnightly quota with weekly sales targets will

compel daily sales, curbing this tendency. It's an old playbook—last used in 2009—now revived," said G.K. Sood, chairman of KN Agri Ltd.

Sood said he expected the government to allocate around 2.3 million tonnes of sugar under the fortnightly system, including about 200,000 tonnes that could come from imported sugar, he said.

The allocation will be slightly higher than the 2.25 million tonnes the government allotted in August.

Jio Platforms gets Sebi approval for IPO

Aganidev Bhattacharya

aganidev.bhattacharya@livemint.com

MUMBAI: India's markets regulator has approved the initial public offering (IPO) of Jio Platforms Ltd, clearing the way for what could become the country's largest stock listing.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) issued its observation letter on the company's draft prospectus on Friday.

"The company can now formally begin marketing the offer, with management directly getting involved," a person aware of the developments told *Mint*. "Initial conversations have indicated



The company plans to raise ₹35,000 crore via IPO. REUTERS

strong demand from global investors, including sovereign and pension funds."

Jio Platforms plans to list on the stock exchanges within the next couple of months, the person added. A spokesperson for

the company did not immediately respond to *Mint*'s queries.

Jio Platforms, the digital services arm of Reliance Industries Ltd, plans to raise ₹35,000 crore (around \$4 billion) through the IPO, structured entirely as a fresh issue of shares.

At the targeted fundraising, the offering would surpass India's previous IPO records, including those set by Hyundai Motor India Ltd and Life Insurance Corp. of India (LIC), as well as the proposed ₹30,000 crore IPO of the National Stock Exchange of India Ltd (NSE).

Analysts at Morgan Stanley and Citi Research have valued Jio Platforms at around \$133 bil-

lion, implying a multiple of about 13 times its estimated enterprise value to earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization (Ebitda) for fiscal year 2027 (FY27).

The company plans to issue 270 million equity shares with a face value of ₹10 each. There will be no offer-for-sale component, meaning the entire gross proceeds from the IPO will accrue directly to Jio Platforms.

Reliance Industries currently holds a 66.43% stake in Jio Platforms. Meta Platforms Inc. owns 9.98% through its affiliate Jaadhu Holdings LLC, while Google International LLC holds 7.73%.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



HT wknd
A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY

hindustantimes tweets www.hindustantimes.com

INDUSTRIAL PRODUCTION RISES 6.7% IN JULY

Shreya Khandelwal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Growth in India's industrial output moderated to 6.7% in July after recording a 27-month high of 8.8% in June, according to Index of Industrial Production (IIP) data released by the National Statistics Office (NSO) on Friday.

Despite the loss in momentum, the July growth rate was faster than the growth rates seen from January to May, ruling out any big impact from the war in West Asia. However, experts were cautious about future growth because of an uncertain external environment and challenges from a dry monsoon season.

A breakup of the headline number by economic activity shows that most sectors recorded a slowdown compared to June, but still expanded faster than other months this year. Manufacturing, which makes up 76% of the index, expanded by 7.3%, slower than the 9.5% figure for June but faster than the growth recorded in every month from January to May. Within manufacturing 19 out of 23 industry groups expanded in July, with the highest growth recorded in the manufacturing of motor vehicles, electrical equipment, and machinery.

Outside manufacturing, electricity expanded by 8.7%, slower than the 10.3% and 11.3% growth recorded in the peak summer months of May and June, but otherwise faster than every month after July 2024. Mining contracted 0.9% compared to 1.6% growth in June. However, the contraction in July was less than in the February-May period. Water supply expanded 7.4%, the fastest rate since July 2025.

Breakup by use-based classification also shows a small loss of momentum across different kinds of goods, but capital goods, infrastructure goods, and consumer durables continued to record double-digit growth.

Primary goods, which have the highest weight of 31%, expanded 4.1% compared to 5.4% in June. Capital goods expanded 16.1% compared to 17.9% in June. Intermediate goods expanded 10% compared to 11.5% in June and infrastructure goods expanded 6.9%, down from 8.8% in June.

Bajaj turnaround push delivers KTM's first profit since insolvency

Ayaan Kartik

ayaan.kartik@livemint.com

MUMBAI: Bajaj Auto-owned Austrian bike maker KTM reported its first operating profit since filing for bankruptcy, as workforce and inventory cuts, along with a boost in sales, helped the company return to the black in the April-June quarter.

According to filings made to the Austrian stock exchange, KTM's holding company Bajaj Mobility AG reported earnings before interest and tax (Ebit) of ₹1.3 million in April-June, compared with a loss of ₹164.7 million in the year-ago period.

To be sure, the company has adjusted the operating profit number for 2025 by ₹1.2 billion, which was recorded as a one-time gain owing to its restructuring fund infusion to pull KTM out of bankruptcy.

The improvement in operating profit came as a result of a



Bajaj began its partnership with KTM in 2007.

jump in sales across global markets, with its revenue jumping 61% to ₹370 million during the period. Its net loss improved to ₹12 million from around ₹340 million, adjusted for the one-time restructuring gain. "Worldwide motorcycle inventory levels across the Group and its dealers were reduced by a total of 10,190 units since the beginning of the year, bringing inventories to a stable level," the company said in its earnings statement.

The company's total workforce has also gone down from 3,782 to 3,416 as part of its efforts

to cut costs.

KTM has also expanded its executive team with the appointment of chief commercial officer Stephan Reiff from April 2026, who will oversee global sales and marketing, as per KTM's investor presentation. Christof Lischka will join as chief technological and project officer to lead research and development and product strategy from October 2026.

Improvement in the performance of KTM also helped Bajaj post growth in its April-June results reported on 21 July. Bajaj Auto saw its revenue grow by 65% to ₹21,688 crore, while its net profit increased by 44% to ₹3,188 crore in the April-June period. Pune-based Bajaj began its partnership with KTM in 2007, when it picked up a 14.5% stake for ₹300 crore. Its share has now increased to 75% after it acquired majority shareholding in the company last May in an €800-million transaction.

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★

	3	5				4		
	4		8		3	9	5	
8	1	9		4		6	3	7
		2	6		4	8		
				1				
		1	7		5	3		
5	2	4		8		1	7	3
	9	8	3		7		4	
		7				2	9	

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW

SATURDAY Generally cloudy sky	SUNDAY Generally cloudy sky	MONDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain
28°C 21°C	29°C 21°C	29°C 21°C

ALMANAC

Today is

29th August 2026

• 15 Rabi ul Awwal, 1448

• 02, Bhadrapada, Krishna Paksha, 02

• Samvat: 2083

• Sunrise: Saturday at 06:32 p.m.

• Sunrise: Sunday at 06:58 a.m.

• Moonrise: Saturday at 06:53 a.m.

• Moonrise: Saturday at 07:20 p.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi 36°C | 26°C

Mumbai 31°C | 27°C

Kolkata 31°C | 26°C

Chennai 36°C | 28°C

Bengaluru 28°C | 21°C

SPORT

Not for the first time were Indian spinners swept into submission

SL batter Dinusha scored 173 runs playing sweeps without being dismissed in 2 Tests

Rasesh Mandani

rasesh.mandani@htlive.com

MUMBAI: Sonal Dinusha is not a name the Indian team will forget in a hurry. He was why they left the Sri Lankan shores deflated despite the series win. The southpaw's crouched stance, long reach and faultless sweeps will linger in memory.

For India, it wasn't just Dinusha's persistent presence at the crease - he spent 1139 minutes, faced 722 balls, scored 420 runs with 3 tons - but his methods that would have left them with a sense of deja vu. The left-hander scored 173 runs playing sweeps (conventional and reverse) without being dismissed. That's the most by anyone in the DRS era, surpassing the 164 runs Joe Root scored in England's 2021 Sri Lanka tour.

Indian cricket needs no reminding that strong players of the sweep shot have negated their spin strength before. Let's not go as far back as Graham Gooch in the 1987 World Cup semi-final or Jimmy Adams in the 1994-95 West Indies Test tour of India. Even Andy Flower's reverse engineering during Zimbabwe's 2000 Test tour of India and Matthew Hayden's sweeping masterclass against Indian spin in Australia's 2001 Test tour occurred in the pre-DRS era.

More recent examples include Joe Root in the 2021 series in India and Ollie Pope and Ben Duckett during the 2024 series, where they employed sweeps and reverse sweeps liberally on more spin-friendly pitches.

It's not that Indian spinners carry the psychological baggage of being troubled by sweeping. In Sri Lanka, Ravindra Jadeja was the only survivor from those home series against England. It's India's inability to counter a play they should have anticipated better that would rankle.

Dinusha, with his diminutive stature, employed sweep shots as his primary scoring option in his match saving innings (133*) in Colombo.

In an old Star Sports video, Hayden and Gautam Gambhir (as a TV pundit) discuss a batter's checklist before employing the sweep shot. Gambhir was

Sweeping Indian bowlers to ground

Sri Lankan batsman Sonal Dinusha showed how Indian spinners can be effectively tackled through the sweep shot, bringing back memories of how the shot has troubled India in the past as well



THEY SWEEP INDIA AWAY

SERIES	PLAYER	M	INNS	RR	RUNS BY SWEEP SHOT
2026	S Dinusha (SL)	2	4	8.57	173
2020-21	J Root (ENG)	4	7	10.15	110
2023-2024	B Duckett (ENG)	5	8	14	105
2016-2017	J Root (ENG)	5	7	12.89	101
2017	D Dickwella (SL)	3	6	8.14	95
2010-2011	B McCullum (NZ)	3	4	10.17	78
2009-2010	M Jayawardene (SL)	3	5	8.1	77
2023-2024	O Pope (ENG)	4	6	8.19	71
2012-2013	A Cook (ENG)	3	5	6.88	70

Matches abroad Matches in India

PHOTO: AFP

Source: CricViz

After day two, we hoped that it was going to be a win for us, and then Sri Lanka batted the way they did for these three days. Sometimes you have got to learn from the opposition and give credit to them.

— Shubman Gill, India captain

asked whether awareness of the nature of the soil was crucial to anticipate the bounce. "Forget the soil, most important is to trust your defense first," he said.

Dinusha primarily did that to boss the proceedings. Indian captain Shubman Gill too alluded to Dinusha's "solid defense" that thwarted their spinners' efforts.

Dinusha's execution of the sweep shots may have required hours of work behind the scenes. But his game plan was laid out in real time: he swept based not just on the line, but also the length of the spinner.

He could do that because the bounce on the Colombo strip on Day 5 was predictable even though spinners were getting the ball to turn.

"It's hardest (to sweep) when some spin and some don't. When it's consistent spin, you can work out when to take it on, and which balls from which line you can take a risk on," Root said during the 2024 tour of India.

Turn for the spinners became progressively slower at Colombo according to Gill. He felt that took lbw and bowled dismissals out of the equation.

This may have also blunted the prospects of India's most experienced spinner Ravindra Jadeja.

The only way India tried to apply pressure was through close-in fielders, but the spinners couldn't create enough chances to bring them into play. Sarfaraz Khan with the helmet got all the screen time for his banter, but that wasn't going to shake Dinusha's resolve.

Dinusha also had the wits to attack Manav Suthar, India's best spinner on show, with the reverse sweep in particular. Despite the overspin Suthar

imparts, Dinusha had the skills to stay on top of his sweeps.

At Galle, Dinusha had attacked Kuldeep Yadav with his slog sweeps. Sarnash Jain, Kuldeep's replacement in Colombo, could not challenge Dinusha enough.

While the off-spinner got Dinusha caught at slip in the first innings, he couldn't put together a threatening spell in the second essay. The left-hander frequently scored against the debutant spinner with conventional sweeps to render him ineffective. The craft and guile of R Ashwin was

sorely missed.

There's one stat, though, that sticks out exposing the limitations of India's bowling attack.

Sri Lanka's lower order (8-11) played out 292 balls to Dinusha's 264 on Day 4 and 5.

India's bowling attack consisting of five specialist bowlers to Sri Lanka's four couldn't trouble the tailenders. Once the young batting star was assured that he could trust the tail, he swept India into misery with every passing over, until the part-time spinners had to be called to complete the mandatory overs.

We needed to create more chances: coach Marijne

Sandip Sikdar

sandip.sikdar@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: Not so long ago, the Indian women's hockey team found itself at a difficult crossroad. Out of the Pro League, starved of top-flight international fixtures a year and reeling from the heartbreak of failing to qualify for the Paris Olympics, the squad was dogged by internal rifts and a fractured dressing room.

Yet, as the dust settled on their World Cup campaign in the Netherlands and Belgium, the narrative has been dramatically rewritten.

Against all odds, chief coach Sjoerd Marijne orchestrated a stunning turnaround, guiding the team to a brilliant fifth-place finish, India's best show at the World Cup since the inaugural edition in 1974 when they finished fourth.

Navigating elite opposition regularly, India suffered just one defeat in six matches, walking away with two commanding wins and three hard-fought draws. It was a masterclass in resilience. But according to the man at the helm, the transformation started long before the first pushback.

"It's not one thing, it's a combination," Marijne told HT on Friday from Amsterdam. "The most important thing is creating a culture where players can be themselves, where the discipline is really high. I have high expectations, but also a lot of space for fun and enjoyment."

To mend a divided squad, Marijne cleared everything back to a single, uncompromising philosophy: the team comes first. "Focus-



India hockey coach Sjoerd Marijne.

ing on team goals will help you achieve personal goals. But focusing on individual goals, you'll never achieve team goals. We created unity. We created the belief that they can do more than they think."

That unity was anchored by strict accountability, largely driven by the seasoned campaigners. In Marijne's system, the experienced players were tasked with setting the standard rather than dictating it.

"Always give a good example yourself. Don't point to others. Don't tell others what to do if you don't do it yourself," said the Dutchman.

This decentralised leadership allowed different personalities to shoulder the burden. Navneet Kaur and Neha Goyal became tactical voices on the pitch. Goalkeeper Savita Punia focused on team bonding and leading by example while Nikki Pradhan and Sushila Chanu acted as cru-

cial "connecting players", keeping a close eye on teammates who might be struggling.

This fortified support system provided a launchpad for the squad's younger talent—11 World Cup debutants to be precise. Players like Sakshi Rana (23 international caps) and Lalithanthuangi (6), found themselves seamlessly integrated into high-pressure roles.

The campaign's crowning moment came in a resounding 3-1 victory over two-time world champions Germany. "If you win 3-1 against a team of that quality, that's a very big step. The main thing will be to create more (opportunities). We defend really well but we need to create more. We have to be more accurate in our passing. That's what you saw against Australia, the level dropped too far. The basic level needs to go higher. And we need to be more consistent," said Marijne.

PAKISTAN BOWLED OUT FOR 110, ENGLAND EXTEND LEAD TO 261

Agencies

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

LONDON : England extended its lead over Pakistan to an intimidating 261 runs after two days of the Lord's Test on Friday.

The host side was 81/3 in second innings when bad light stopped play and in total command after routing a depleted Pakistan for 110 in the afternoon.

Pakistan medium-pacers Khurram Shahzad and Mohammad Ali did well to prise out Ben Duckett, Jordan Cox and Joe Root in the last session but they were bowling in damage limitation mode.

Their batters' failure conceded a hefty 180-run lead to England on the first innings. Pakistan hasn't totaled 180 in the series yet and was without opening batter Imam-ul-Haq, who suffered a left calf strain while fielding early Thursday and won't reappear.

England's four seamers feasted on a Pakistan batting order that wasn't compensated by the return of captain Babar Azam.

Pakistan was blown away in 37.2 overs, and back bowling just over four hours after finishing England's first innings at 290 in the morning.

Ollie Robinson took a sensational 4/11 in 13 overs, including six maidens, as Pakistan collapsed to 110 all out. Jofra Archer had 3-26 from 11.2, Josh Tongue had two wickets and a luckless Gus Atkinson none. England then slumped to 13/2 in their second innings on a pitch still offering seam movement.

Women's singles promises a wild swing of fortunes

Shahid Judge

shahid.judge@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: There are three possible outcomes from the women's singles draw at the US Open.

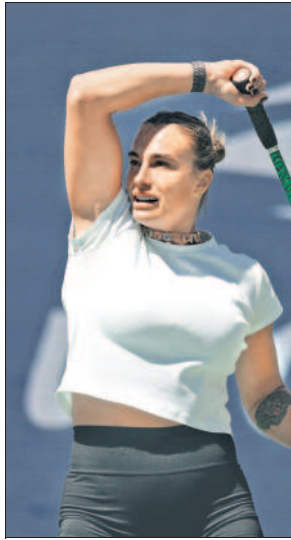
Aryna Sabalenka could become the first player since Serena Williams in 2014 to complete a hat-trick of titles in New York. The other option is that Sabalenka will be dethroned of the world No.1 spot she has held for nearly 100 consecutive weeks.

Or both - Sabalenka could win and yet still lose her spot at the top of the WTA rankings.

The way the 2026 calendar year started, these are unexpected circumstances that have led to the build-up of the season's last Grand Slam. And in the coming fortnight at the Billie Jean King Tennis Centre in Flushing Meadows, the culmination of these twists and turns will make for intriguing storylines.

At the start of the year, Sabalenka won 11 matches on the trot. The streak ended when she lost the Australian Open final to a resurgent Elena Rybakina, then ranked No.6 in the world. By the time the US Open ends and the rankings are updated on September 14, Rybakina may just be the new world No.1.

The Kazakh, who won Wimbledon in 2022, went on to win the clay title at the WTA 500 event in Stuttgart, while also reaching finals at Indian Wells and recently in Toronto. If the 27-year-old reaches the semi-final at the US Open, she will be the new World No.1 regardless



Aryna Sabalenka.

AFP

of who wins the title.

But there is some fitness concern she carries with her to New York, having being forced to withdraw from her quarter-final at the Cincinnati Masters due to an ankle injury. And to get to the semi-final, she may have to face six-time Grand Slam champion Iga Swiatek in the quarter-final, should they both reach that far.

Swiatek has also had an upswing in form, having ended her 11-month title drought with the triumph at the Canadian Masters (beating Rybakina in the final).

The Polish star, who has been world No.1 for 125 weeks over two stints, is the eighth seed in New York.

The permutations and combinations ahead of the US Open



Sri Lanka Dhananjaya de Silva and P Sooriyabandara.

AFP

SL batters raise hopes of revival of India rivalry

Sanjeev K Samyal

sanjeev.samyal@htlive.com

MUMBAI: The 2026 Test series between India and Sri Lanka comes at an important time for both countries, as both are in the middle of a transition.

Not long ago, the two teams enjoyed a healthy rivalry, matching each other player for player. Mahela Jayawardene, Kumar Sangakkara, Muttiah Muralitharan and Chaminda Vaas led the Sri Lankan charge against an Indian side featuring Sachin Tendulkar, Rahul Dravid, VVS Laxman, Anil Kumble and Harbhajan Singh, dishing out tough, memorable contests.

For Sri Lanka the transition has lasted longer than expected. Since Jayawardene and Sangakkara retired, Sri Lanka hasn't had batters worthy of being the pillars around which the lineup can revolve, nor have they found world-class bowlers.

The end of the Mahela-Sanga era coincided with the rise of the Kohli-Pujara-Rahane era for India. India dominated the bilateral competitions starting from the mid-2010s. The fighting draw in the Colombo Test on Thursday, ended Sri Lanka's run of six straight defeats to India on home soil.

The home team's new crop of young middle-order batters showed impressive skills and temperament to put up a good fight and produce a memorable series. More than the result, both camps have reason to be happy with a view of long-term gains. It has raised hopes that the next time the two sides meet, they will be more evenly matched, leading to a revival of their rivalry.

India's middle order was desperate for more quality options before settling on the right long-term players and the impressive performances of Devdutt Padikal and Dhruv Jurel will bring some joy.

A batting line-up of KL Rahul,

Yashasvi Jaiswal, Shubman Gill, Rishabh Pant, Paddikal and Jurel, looks balanced and strong.

In bowling, left-arm spinner Manav Suthar excelled for the second straight series, finishing as the leading wicket-taker with 16 wickets.

For Sri Lanka, young Pasindu Sooriyabandara and Sonal Dinusha (420 runs at an average of 140) both staked a claim for long-term Test prospects.

Getting a chance in the absence of injured first-choice senior batters, the two provided enough evidence to develop into fine specialist Test batters.

Add to it the fact that 27-year-old Kamindu Mendis is on the way to establishing his credentials as a solid middle-order player, averaging 53.65 plus in 18 Tests. In tough times, this young crop of batters has emerged as a breath of fresh air for Sri Lankan cricket.

Coach Gary Kirsten is most excited by Sri Lanka's breakout star of the series, Dinusha: "What I was encouraged by was when I watched him in the West Indies, I saw that he really thrives in tough situations. I love the way he plays Test cricket. He thinks about it."

Dinusha and Sooriyabandara have offered new hope but the key will be how Sri Lanka cricket handles them.

This could be the beginning of something nice for Sri Lankan Test cricket but the young players will need to sustain their performance over time.

Unlike Mahela and Sangakkara who had the time to first fully learn the longer format and then move into the T20 format, none of the current players want to be just Test specialists.

The challenge for Dinusha & Co is to immediately find the balance between T20 cricket and Test cricket. In this day and age, that is often easier said than done but Sri Lanka will hope they can make the right choice.

PCB COMPLAINS OVER ATHERTON'S INTERVIEW WITH IMRAN'S SONS

Agencies

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

KARACHI: The Pakistan Cricket Board has lodged a formal complaint with official broadcaster Sky Sports after it aired an interview with the sons of jailed iconic former captain and Prime Minister Imran Khan during the lunch break on the opening day of the second Test against England at Lord's.

The PCB had objected to the interview recorded on Wednesday and even considered keeping its players off the field after lunch in protest if Sky went ahead with the broadcast, sources aware of the developments said. Contacted, the PCB refused to comment on the matter. However Pakistan did take the field as scheduled.

Former England skipper Mike Atherton conducted the 18-minute interview with Imran's sons, Kassim and Suleman, at Lord's. The brothers expressed fears over the well-being of their father, whose health has been a growing concern in recent weeks.

Australia's Test and ODI skipper Pat Cummins threw his weight behind Imran Khan and said he should be treated with dignity. Cummins said his family should get access to Imran. "Adding my support here to GC (Greg Chappell) and the other former international captains. I hope the court ordered medical assessment be allowed to run its course, and that family visits continue. I hope Imran Khan is treated with the dignity anyone deserves," Cummins posted on X.

HT



Neeraj Chopra. HT

Neeraj qualifies for DL Finals

LAUSANNE: Indian javelin throw ace Neeraj Chopra recording a season-best throw of 88.05 meters at the Lausanne Diamond League. With a total of 12 points, Chopra has qualified for the DL Finals to be held in Brussels despite competing in just two events of one-day meeting series.

India finish 8th at FIH World Cup

NEW DELHI: Indian men's hockey team lost to Belgium in their final match of the FIH World Cup to finish a disappointing 8th. Playing against world No. 2 Belgium, they were trailing 2-3 as the match went into its final 21 seconds but Harmanpreet Singh got the equaliser from a penalty corner. That sent the match into a shoot-out but it was the Belgians who sealed the win 4-3 (SO).

Barcelona defeat Athletic Bilbao 2-0

BARCELONA: Barcelona secured a 2-0 La Liga victory over Athletic Bilbao at the partially-rebuilt Camp Nou to maintain their perfect start to the season. Raphinha opened the scoring in the 37th minute after rounding Unai Simon, before Fermin Lopez sealed the win in 82nd min.

NADA serves notice to Pal

NEW DELHI: Asian Games-bound long distance runner Abhishek Pal has been served notice by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) for an apparent doping violation. He has not been handed a provisional suspension.

How Pragg turned loss at Candidates into a lesson

The 21-year-old Grandmaster has become the first Indian to win the Grand Chess Tour

Susan Ninan

susan.ninan@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: It was a little after 3am on Friday in India, and a relieved, sleep-deprived Valbhav Suri was shooting off delirious texts in all caps. The recipient of his uppercase excitement, Pragganandhaa, had just become the first Indian to win the Grand Chess Tour title.

The 21-year-old grandmaster did it in thrilling fashion.

When Pragg walked into the final day of the Grand Chess Tour Finals, he had a mountain to climb. He was six points behind Fabiano Caruana, one of the strongest players in the world, with the title seemingly slipping away. But somewhere in that deficit was a version of Pragg that his team had been trying to build for the past two years – more ambitious, more resilient and, crucially, less willing to give up. That mindset became the defining feature of a remarkable comeback.

"He was in this headspace that, 'yeah, I am trailing, but screw it, I will give it everything because I really want to win', I could see that in the way we were preparing, the way we were talking about things," Suri, who has been working as Pragg's trainer for roughly two years now, told HT. "We had to win the first rapid game else it becomes really challenging," Suri pointed out. Pragganandhaa did exactly that.

"Fabiano was clearly under pressure when that happened. It was evident in the way he collapsed in Game 2," the 29-year-old grandmaster said. "Our plan was to put pressure on Fabiano as soon as possible, gain some time advantage and hopefully things start falling in place from there on."

Suddenly, the match had changed completely: from trailing by six points, Pragganandhaa was two points ahead. In the four Blitz games that followed, the first with an opposite colour bishop endgame ended in a draw before Caruana levelled scores with a win in the second. Pragg prevailed in a time scramble in the third and a draw in the last game was all he needed to walk away with the title.

Pragg had been in St. Louis,

PRAGG'S 2026 RUN

JANUARY	MARCH-APRIL	JUNE	AUGUST
Entered the Tata Steel Chess tournament in Wijk aan Zee as the defending champion. Finished 11th among 14 players with 5.5/13.	A disappointing second Candidates Tournament appearance. Finished seventh in the eight-player field with just one win.	Won Norway Chess. First Indian to win the tournament. Defeated Magnus Carlsen twice during the tournament	Won Saint Louis Rapid & Blitz Topped the Rapid section and went on to win the overall tournament in Blitz Finished joint first with 5.5/9 at the Sinquefeld Cup, before losing the playoff to Wesley So. Won the Grand Chess Tour Finals First Indian to become Grand Chess Tour champion Defeated world No 2 Fabiano Caruana 15-13 after trailing 3-9 heading into the final day's play

Missouri, for nearly a month, winning two of the three tournaments he played, while Suri, his trainer, back in India, had upended his sleep schedule to match American time. The original plan was for Suri to travel with Pragg, but his US visa application was rejected.

"The Rapid and Blitz days were slightly tricky in terms of staying up because there's this break between games so we would discuss about the next game and there are decisions to be made based on results and how other players are faring."

Pragg spoke of not being too optimistic of his chances, ahead of the final day. "Honestly, I didn't think I had many chances today. Six points is a lot," he said. "It would have been nice to

have it in the Candidates, but it's still nice to win tournaments like this."

The Candidates tournament where Pragg finished seventh out of eight players with a solitary win in 14 rounds earlier this year, still rankles. For an event that happens once in two years, there was a lot that rode on it for Pragg and his team. Hope, primarily. "It was painful because we really wanted to win it. But we took our lessons from it," Suri said.

"I remember being in this common room with Wesley So during a Tata Steel Kolkata event that Pragg was playing. He said something along the lines of Pragg needing to improve his Rapid and Blitz play. He was right. We have

been trying to get better at Rapid and Blitz in terms of openings approach and making efficient decisions."

"In last two years, both Pragg and I have been extremely self-reflective. The objective has been to examine games, identify what worked and what did not, and constantly reinvent the process."

The approach has coincided with an extraordinary run of results. Pragg won Norway Chess, beating Magnus Carlsen twice before his stunning run in Saint Louis this month. "I see a small change in Pragg's character too. He's a lot more ambitious and resilient."

Suri's relationship with Pragg has evolved too. "I remember when we started out, our con-

versations were restricted to chess. Now, we can discuss literally anything – from politics to art to movies. I get the feeling he values my views beyond chess as well. The way I see it, it's easier to put in long hours if you like the individual you work for."

Pragg, who takes home a whopping \$404,354 from the Grand Chess Tour alone, will want to catch a break before the Olympiad in September. He has easily been the most impressive player of the year, apart from Javokhir Sindarov's terminator mode at the Candidates.

"Pragg and I have this little tradition of celebrating a win with dessert," Suri said. "After he won, I was texting him in all caps, telling him he gets to have two desserts this time."

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

HT /FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

DPL: Jonty Sidhu propels Central Delhi to final



Central Delhi Kings captain Jonty Sidhu.

DPL

HT Correspondent

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

New Delhi: Jonty Sidhu led from the front with a blistering unbeaten century and a three-wicket haul to propel Central Delhi Kings to a dominant 72-run victory over Purani Dilli in the Delhi Premier League 2026 Qualifier 2 at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Friday.

The win ensured table-toppers Central Delhi set up a final clash against South Delhi Superstarz on Sunday. Batting first, Kings registered a formidable 218/5. Sidhu's destructive knock of 106* off just 46 balls was laced with 5 fours and 10 massive sixes.

The innings got off to a quick start courtesy of wicketkeeper Siddharth Joon, who smashed 20 runs off 9 balls with 3 sixes. Opening partner Samarth Singh played a steady role, contributing 25 off 26 deliveries before being caught off Udhav Mohan's bowling.

Although Yugal Saini (3) and Keshav Dabas (16) were dismissed, Sidhu held the innings together and dominated the

opposition attack. Sidhu stitched a vital 62-run partnership with Dabas, contributing 46 runs to it.

Towards the death overs, quickfire contributions from Vansh Bedi (11) and an unbeaten cameo from Aditya Bhandari (24*) provided the late flourish, pushing the run rate to an impressive 10.90 per over. Extras also contributed 13 runs to the total.

Pankaj Jaswal was the stand-out bowler for Purani Dilli with figures of 2/41. Already chasing a massive target, Purani Dilli were skittled for just 146 runs in 17.1 overs with Sidhu again playing a starring role with the ball, picking up 3/25.

Opener Samarth Seth was the top-scorer with 45 while Dhananjai Singh contributed 25. However, losing wickets regularly meant they never gained momentum. Rajneesh Dadar tried to add some flourish with his 10-ball 25 towards the end but it was too little, too late for Purani Dilli.

Money Grewal, Tejas Baroka and Gavnish Khurana also picked up two wickets apiece.

HAVE FUN WITH FACTS ON SUNDAYS

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

hindustantimes htTweets www.hindustantimes.com